

Happening today

● **SC WILL** hear a plea by former minister and DMK leader V Senthil Balaji seeking anticipatory bail in a case pertaining to alleged irregularities in TASMCA.

● **DELHI HC** will hear an appeal by Umar Khalid challenging the trial court's July 4 decision to dismiss his bail application.

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Business as Usual

By EP UNNAY



Shouldn't there be show of fairness: SC on PM panel choosing CEC

Office of PM has sanctity attached to it, counters Centre

Ananthakrishnan G
New Delhi, July 30

QUESTIONING THE appointment of the Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) and Election Commissioners (ECs) by a three-member committee comprising the Prime Minister, a Union Minister and the Leader of Opposition, the Supreme Court on Thursday asked "should there be no show of fairness" in the procedure.

The bench of Justices Dipankar Datta and S C Sharma was hearing petitions challenging the Chief Election Commissioner and Other Election Commissioners (Appointment, Conditions of Service and Term of Office) Act, 2023, which provides for their selection by the three-member panel.

Defending the law, the Centre, represented by Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, said it would be wrong to assume that the PM and the minister would "not act in the interest of democracy" because they have a "numerical majority" in the selection procedure.

Mehta submitted that the office of the PM has a "sanctity attached" to it and doubting the decision of the selection committee would undermine the

● CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

THE WORLD P16

DRONE STRIKE NEAR SUEZ RAISES MORE SECURITY THREATS

● CM HIMANTA SEEKS CENTRAL RELIEF AND REHABILITATION PACKAGE

'Not even our grandfathers saw this': Upper Assam reels as floods wash away villages

Swati Mishra & Rajat Sain
Nepalikhuti (Sivasagar), July 30

"THE 19TH is cursed for Assam," sighs cab driver Sumu on the way from Dibrugarh to Sivasagar. "Zubeen Da (singer Zubeen Garg) left us on the 19th... and then, on the 19th, came this flood that swept everything away."

In Lower Assam, flooding is practically a season. It arrives every year, sometimes forgiving, sometimes merciless. But

DAY AFTER LOK SABHA, RAJYA SABHA PASSES BILL BY VOICE VOTE AS OPPOSITION WALKS OUT

House clears anti-paper leak Bill, PM says nobody will be spared

Kharge raises police action on protesters: 'If Shah cannot answer, he should resign'



Leader of Opposition Mallikarjun Kharge in Rajya Sabha, Thursday. P11
Divya A. Nikhil Chanekar, Damini Nath & Jatin Anand
New Delhi, July 30

A DAY after it was cleared by the Lok Sabha, the Public Examination (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2026, which provides for stricter punishment for paper leaks, was discussed and passed by the Rajya Sabha through voice vote on Thursday.

Hours later, Prime Minister Narendra Modi posted a video on Instagram in which he assured that "any paper mafia, paper leak gang, gang which tries to play with the future of the youth of the country would not be spared".

Underlining that his government had delivered on its promise to bring a tough law, he said: "We are taking step after

step towards creating a reliable education system, whether it is the creation of a task force, fast-track courts, taking suggestions from states... A nationwide reform in education sector has become compulsory... work in this direction will continue."

Earlier, before Union Minister Jitendra Singh could respond to the debate on the Bill in the Rajya Sabha, INDIA bloc MPs walked out, demanding that Home Minister Amit Shah make a statement on the police action against protesting students last week. Singh said it was unfortunate that the MPs who had spoken most vociferously during the debate had walked out.

Referring to the Opposition members raising the issue of police action on students, ● CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Police rules allow pellet gun use, can look at specific cases, says SC

CJI bench to Govt: Preserve ammunition log of RAF personnel on Delhi protest duty

Ananthakrishnan G
New Delhi, July 30

STATING THAT the existing police regulations allow the use of pellet guns in exceptional circumstances for crowd control, the Supreme Court on Thursday said they can only be banned if these rules are found to be unconstitutional. The

court, however, said it was open to examining specific allegations of misuse on a case-by-case basis.

The bench, led by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, was hearing petitions — filed by Yashvardhan Azad, former Intelligence Bureau Special Director and Central Information Commissioner, and two per-

sons who allegedly sustained pellet gun injuries during the recent student protests in the Capital — seeking a ban on the use of pellet guns when dealing with civilian crowds.

The bench, which included Justices Joydip Bagchi and V Mohana, also directed the Centre to preserve the ammunition log of the Rapid Action Force (RAF) personnel deployed during the protest march to Parliament on July 20. The court issued notices to ● CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

POLITICS PAGE 6



PARLIAMENT CLEARS BILL MAKING INSULT TO VANDHE MATARAM A PUNISHABLE OFFENCE

WHY CENTRE IS HOLDING BACK KEY BILLS AS LOGJAM IN HOUSE CONTINUES

Delhi govt: No action on NEET protesters, except those with criminal past

Gayathri Mani
New Delhi, July 30

AFTER FOUR BJP-ruled states — Maharashtra, West Bengal, Assam and Bihar — began withdrawing cases against NEET-UG protesters following the Cockroach Janta Party's threat of a fresh stir, Delhi followed suit on Thursday.

In an order issued by the Home Department, the govern-

ment approved the withdrawal of 13 FIRs registered in connection with the CJP-led protests, stating that no action will be taken against those who participated. However, this won't include those with criminal antecedents.

"As of 6 pm on 29.07.2026, a total of 13 cases were registered by Delhi Police in connection with the protests relating to the

● CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

EXPRESS special

From govt to pvt: In 3 yrs, 1.54 lakh J&K Bank accounts were not linked to PAN

Data dump leads Income Tax sleuths to 'systemic failure'; bank says compliance report submitted to RBI

Ritu Sarin
New Delhi, July 30

AN INCOME Tax probe has found that 1.54 lakh accounts were opened with J&K Bank between 2021 and 2024 without any PAN details linked to them. And, deposits in such accounts with transactions touching Rs 15 lakh or more in a financial year totalled Rs 4.88 lakh crore, records investigated by The Indian Express show.

So much so that in its final report submitted late last year, the I-T Department said the probe's findings point to a "systemic failure" and a "significant red flag", warning that the unlinked accounts, with their substantial transaction volumes, present "a staggering potential avenue for tax evasion".

Most of the accounts under the I-T scanner were Savings Bank accounts, opened merely by filling Form 60, a "declaration form" used by people without PAN cards. The IT probe found that these non-PAN-linked accounts included:

● 32,498 Government-linked

● Crunching numbers

₹4.88 lakh crore

Deposits in accounts not linked to PAN with transactions of Rs 15 lakh+ in a financial year

Accounts not linked to PAN	
Govt associated	Private
32,498	1,25 lakh

10,464 Private accounts with credits of ₹50 lakh or more in a financial year

E. EXPLAINED

Under watch

The J&K Bank accounts not linked to PAN form less than 1 per cent of the bank's over-2 crore accounts base. But the range of such accounts, from corporate entities to those linked to government schemes, has brought them under the tax scanner.

Indian hockey ditches iconic blue for saffron; not consulted: 5 players, official

Mihir Vasavda
Mumbai, July 30

SINCE 1928, the Indian hockey team has played in different shades of blue or white almost every time at a major tournament. That will change next month.

When Harmanpreet Singh and Salima Tete lead the men's and women's teams for the World Cup, starting August 15 in Belgium and the Netherlands, the players will swap the iconic blue jersey that has defined the national side for a saffron-coloured one.

Hockey India said the "primary consideration was technical" since the blue uniform



Indian men's hockey team will be seen in their new jersey at the World Cup in the Netherlands and Belgium next month. @THEHOCKEYINDIA

from-coloured one.

Hockey India said the "primary consideration was technical" since the blue uniform

blended with the blue turf and made it difficult for a player to spot a teammate easily.

● CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Fudged records to political meddling: CAG red-flags cyclone relief under TMC

Raises questions over classification of 'damaged houses', grants to those rejected

Atri Mitra
Kolkata, July 30

THE USE of identical photographs for multiple claims, incorrect classification of damaged houses, duplicate transactions worth Rs 18.07 crore, and grants sanctioned on the recommendations of local political leaders.

These are some of the irregularities that the Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) has flagged in its report on relief distribution and restoration work in West Bengal following Cyclone Amphan in 2020.

The CAG has noted that the Trinamool Congress (TMC) government's estimates of damage were "not supported

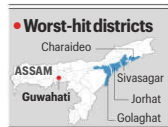
by proper evidence".

The auditor analysed 31,457 photographs and found that in 3,126 cases identical photographs were uploaded against the names of multiple beneficiaries. This suggested that undue house-building grants might have been extended, though the exact amount could not be quantified because the photographs were not linked to beneficiary forms, the CAG said. Using a data analytics tool to parse through the records of

● CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



In Nepalikhuti village in Assam's Sivasagar district. RAJAT SAIN



Upper Assam doesn't know that rhythm. So, when heavy rains in the Naga Hills broke over the region on July 19, it caught everyone completely off guard.

● CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Bill passed

Singh said: "There was also mention of the so-called brutality unleashed on the children. It is not so. There has not been any casualty reported".

Initiating the discussion in the afternoon, Leader of Opposition M K Sharma said that he demanded Shah's resignation. "Paper churane wale bachte rahie, mehnat karne wale pit te rahie. Yeh kaisa nray (Those behind paper leaks kept escaping, those who worked hard kept getting beaten up. What kind of justice is this)," he said, alleging that the government had ignored demands for a strong law against paper leaks in 2024.

Singh, who moved the Bill in the House, said the amendments reflect the government's willingness to "learn from experience" after the implementation of the 2024 law. However, Kharage said the amendments merely enhanced penalties and created new enforcement mechanisms without addressing the root causes of recurring paper leaks.

Amid repeated interruptions by the treasury benches during his hour-long interjection, Kharage questioned the use of force against students and sought accountability for the police action. "Who authorised the use of lathicharges, tear gas and pellet guns on students? Who were the people in plainclothes beating up students? Under whose orders did the RAJ and CRPF operate? The country wants answers. If the Home Minister cannot answer, he should resign," he said.

"This government wants to protect Home Minister Amit Shah, but it will not be able to protect him for long," he added. Kharage claimed that over 400 students were injured and several were hospitalised during the protest last week. "Many students are admitted to hospitals in critical condition. Many children have suffered pellet gun injuries on their bodies and eyes. Several students are hospitalised, some have lost their eyesight, while many have suffered broken limbs. Home Minister Amit Shah is responsible for this," he said.

Amid sloganeering from the

treasury benches, Opposition MPs sought an apology from Union Minister Gita Priya Singh as he alleged foreign funding during protests.

"What the government is doing today, we had suggested back in 2024, but at that time the government did not listen to us. Back then, the Lok Sabha elections were approaching, and the government wanted to play politics while Rahul Gandhi was raising questions about paper leaks during the Bharat Jodo Nyay Yatra," Kharage said.

The Congress president also accused the Centre of weakening academic freedom and promoting ideological appointments in higher educational institutions. He said educational institutions were being filled with people affiliated to the RSS.

Earlier in the day, as the House was informed that the Bill would be taken up for consideration, Congress MP Pramod Tiwari, Deputy Leader of the Opposition, said they attached a list to issue a statement on the police crackdown on protesters.

While Opposition members raised slogans of 'Amit Shah sadan mai aao (come to the

House)', Union Minister J P Nadda said: "I want to tell the House that the Opposition's stance has been negative since this session began. They only want to interrupt; they want to shift goalposts."

The Opposition staged a walkout before the House reconvened in the afternoon.

During the discussion on the Bill, several Opposition MPs raised the demand to do away with NEET altogether, returning to a decentralised system.

DMK MP Tiruchi Siva asked how one exam system could work in a diverse country like India. He said through NEET, the "criteria to become a medical student is money". SPMP Ram Gopal Yadav, too, demanded that the exam be handed back to the states. CPI(M) MP John Brittas and RJD MP Manoj Kumar Jha called for the NTA to be abolished.

Meanwhile, defending Shah, BJP MP Brij Lal, who is a retired Uttar Pradesh DCP, said: "Whenever there is a law and order situation, the magistrate decides, along with police officers, on the use of force."

around Rs 5 crore. Using the auditing software, the CAG found that Rs 92.95 lakh was paid to 1,576 beneficiaries whose claims had already been rejected.

Sixteen of West Bengal's 23 districts were affected in Amphan. The government, in a memorandum submitted in June 2020, estimated losses at Rs 1.02 lakh crore and sought Rs 35,000 crore NDRF assistance.

IMCT, in its September 20 report, recommended relief of Rs 2,500.29 crore. After deliberations of National Executive Committee, relief of Rs 2,077.77 crore was approved. MHA released Rs 2,250.28 crore from NDRF after adjusting available SDRF balance.

or voter ID details, bank passbooks, inspection reports, or photo of damaged houses.

Among other things, the audit questioned the classification of damaged houses. "It is evident that either many partially damaged houses were included in the category of fully damaged houses during assessment or these households were included later for reasons not on record," the report said. It flagged Purulia as an anomaly, noting that although the western district was not among the worst affected, all damaged homes there were categorised as "fully damaged".

The audit also identified doubtful transactions worth

1.54 lakh accounts had no PAN

accounts with credits of Rs 4.68,408 crore, including accounts of Self-Help Group (SHG) and Cluster Level Federation (CLF) members.

● 125 lakh private accounts with total credits of Rs 36,789 crore.

● 10,464 private accounts with credits of Rs 50 lakh or more in financial year—of these, 566 belonged to 510 individuals with PAN cards but these details were not furnished to the Bank while opening the accounts.

Asked about the probe, J&K Bank told *The Indian Express* (see page 2) that it subsequently called for a "supervisory meeting" with the RBI and AMFI (anti-money laundering/CFT) (Counter Financing of Terrorism) framework. While acceptance of Form 60 is a legally permitted mechanism under the Income-tax rules for eligible customers, the Bank has significantly enhanced monitoring by mandating PAN for all identified categories of accounts, automating threshold-based surveillance and ensuring STR (Suspicious Transaction Reports) reporting, wherever warranted, in full compliance with RBI, and statutory guidelines.

"The RBI reviewed the matter during a supervisory meeting with the Bank's senior management and advised further strengthening of the existing framework. The Bank promptly implemented the Bank's governance and compliance framework."

A key finding: "account holders were setting up multifarious bank accounts in the names of individuals and entities without any PAN linked with them"; "large transactions were made through the bank which were not recorded or highlighted to the Income Tax Department".

In all, 68 such bank accounts, opened between 2004 and 2013, were traced, several of them belonging to textile companies located in the valley. Substantial transactions were carried out in these unlinked accounts without being reported to the I-T Department, the probe report states.

Once the scope of the probe was widened, the J&K Bank admitted it had not flagged the

Strengthened framework: J&K Bank

Responding to queries from *The Indian Express* on the I-T probe, J&K Bank's Group Compliance Officers said: "The matter arose from a data dump submitted during an exercise undertaken during the election process, following which the information was examined by the Income Tax Department and was subsequently subjected to RBI and governmental scrutiny."

"The bank has comprehensively addressed the observations by strengthening its KYC and AMFI (anti-money laundering/CFT) (Counter Financing of Terrorism) framework. While acceptance of Form 60 is a legally permitted mechanism under the Income-tax rules for eligible customers, the Bank has significantly enhanced monitoring by mandating PAN for all identified categories of accounts, automating threshold-based surveillance and ensuring STR (Suspicious Transaction Reports) reporting, wherever warranted, in full compliance with RBI, and statutory guidelines."

"The RBI reviewed the matter during a supervisory meeting with the Bank's senior management and advised further strengthening of the existing framework. The Bank promptly implemented the Bank's governance and compliance framework."

problem of large transactions on unlinked accounts opened only through Form 60, and that it was charging 20% TDS on interest for these unlinked accounts, against 10% for PAN-linked account holders.

The probe found that un-

pliance report to the RBI. "The Bank has strengthened its PAN compliance framework through technology-driven controls, making PAN mandatory for identified categories of accounts and by automating the monitoring of existing accounts crossing prescribed thresholds. The Bank has instituted a mechanism of periodic quarterly review by the Chief Data Officer to ensure availability of PAN details in respect of accounts where PAN has been made mandatory, which was placed before the Audit Committee of the Board."

"The Bank's policy is to ensure regulatory compliance while protecting customer interests. Accordingly, rather than closing accounts, customers are provided adequate opportunity to submit PAN. Western PAN is not furnished despite due notice, debit operations are restricted till submission and validation of PAN."

"The revised framework provides for continuous system-based monitoring, automatic identification of threshold-triggered accounts, time-bound PAN compliance through customer notifications, and regulatory restrictions only in cases of continued non-compliance, with immediate restoration upon PAN validation. The exercise has further strengthened the Bank's governance and compliance framework."

linked accounts had also been opened for availing Government schemes, including J&K Bank Bima Bachat Khata, Prime Minister's Employment Generation Programme (PMEGP), National Urban Livelihood Mission (NULM), Subsidy Reserve Fund

Account (SRFA) and J&K's Spurring Entrepreneurship Initiative scheme.

For instance, cumulative credits of Rs 1.55 crore were recorded in SRNCC's Savings Accounts for NCC Cadets, the probe found.

The probe also analysed the top 30 non-PAN linked private accounts which PAN numbers were traced by the I-T Department, comparing them with declarations in Income Tax Return (ITR). In 11 cases, including owners of cement stores, gas stations, fabric stores and a hospital, it found credits in the J&K Bank to be higher than what had been declared in ITRs.

A glaring example was that of an account-holder with credits of Rs 4.05 crore in a non-PAN linked account in 2023-24, but gross income of Rs 3.22 lakh shown in the ITR for that year. There was also an infrastructure company that deposited Rs 5.88 crore in its J&K Bank account in the same year but showed gross receipts of only Rs 38.49 crore in its ITR.

The I-T Department noted that "such a practice helps the assessee conceal his/her assets from the Income Tax scanner as no PAN has been linked to such accounts and it is suspected that this is causing huge loss of revenue to the exchequer. This tax evasion tactic has been possible only because such Non PAN linked accounts were allowed to be opened by the J&K Bank."

The I-T Department recommended that if a specified threshold of quantum of deposits in a non-PAN account is breached, Suspicious Transaction Reports (STRs) should be filed with the Department and findings shared with the RBI. These and other recommendations, it noted, will promote greater accountability and transparency, as well as "enforcement of tax compliance, prevention of money laundering & terror financing and ensuring the integrity and stability of the financial stability of India."

CAG

19.38 lakh beneficiaries in six districts, the CAG also found that house-building grants were credited more than once—in some cases up to nine times—into the bank accounts of 19,826 beneficiaries through 9,291 transactions. No mechanism existed to prevent duplicate payments, the report noted.

The report also confirms *The Indian Express's* report at the time on local leaders with ties to political parties benefiting from relief disbursal. The CAG found that the districts of North 24 Parganas and South 24 Parganas

withdrew Rs 1,383.23 crore out of the total house-building grant of Rs 19,49.51 crore under 71% from the treasury and parked it in commercial bank accounts, before making DBTs. This was "highly irregular" under the West Bengal Treasury Rules, the auditor noted. These grants were often sanctioned based on the recommendations of local leaders without mandatory field inspections and the reports of local inquiry committees were ignored, the auditor said.

For instance, in South 24 Parganas, Rs 22.84 crore was disbursed in the Magrahat-I block and Maheshtala Municipality based on single-page applications that did not have Aadhaar

or voter ID details, bank passbooks, inspection reports, or photo of damaged houses.

Among other things, the audit questioned the classification of damaged houses. "It is evident that either many partially damaged houses were included in the category of fully damaged houses during assessment or these households were included later for reasons not on record," the report said. It flagged Purulia as an anomaly, noting that although the western district was not among the worst affected, all damaged homes there were categorised as "fully damaged".

The audit also identified doubtful transactions worth

Hockey

They added that the decision was based on "recommendations from detailed consultations with the players and support staff."

However, *The Indian Express* spoke to five members across the men's and women's teams, and each denying being part of the process. "I wasn't asked or consulted. It is not true," said one of the members, who requested anonymity. All five said they did not speak for the entire group, but their response suggests that consultations, if any, were not unanimous.

This newspaper has also learnt that some of Hockey India's top officials, including members of the executive committee, were not informed or consulted about the move. "It was not aware of the change in jersey colour nor was I part of an official meeting where this was discussed," an executive committee member told this paper.

Hockey India secretary general Bholu Nath Singh and president Dilip Tirkey could not be reached for comment.

Hockey India declined to comment when asked specifically who made the call to change the jersey colour.

But the decision drew backlash, including from former

players. "I am not inspired when I look at this jersey," Vasudevan Baskaran, who was India's captain when the team won the gold medal at the 1980 Olympics, told *The Indian Express*.

"Since 1928, our identities with players have worn the blue shirt. Suddenly, what is the reason for this change? Is it Government's decision or Hockey India? If it is Hockey India's, then they should have consulted former and current players first," he said.

Baskaran wondered if Hockey India had taken the Government's permission before "such a significant change". "Recently, we saw the All India Football Federation, which is headed by a politician, try and change the name to Football Federation of Bharat. It is a tamasha, I am hurt," he said.

Hockey India said in a statement: "It was observed that the blue playing uniform tended to blend/merge with the blue synthetic playing surface, which is now the standard colour of international hockey pitches. This visual similarity affected on-field clarity and visibility for the players."

It said: "In light of the above, the coaches and players suggested alternative colours such as yellow or saffron. After careful consideration, saffron was finalised. Apart from addressing the technical requirement,

saffron also holds deep significance as one of the colours of our National Flag, symbolising courage, sacrifice and national pride."

Blue has remained a colour entrenched in Indian sport for decades. The hockey team has worn the colour in successive Olympic and World Cup campaigns, with one exception in 2014, when it wore yellow because of a sponsor commitment.

Congress MP Priyanka Gandhi Vadra criticised the change. "Whether it's a jersey, uniforms or try to rewrite history through education policy, no matter what they do... You have seen what the youth of our country think about this," she told reporters on Thursday.

Odisha ex-CM Navin Pattnaik slammed the decision. He said: "Step was taken under pressure from BJP Government in Odisha." "Those in authority may deny it, but the fact is that for the last two years, everybody in Odisha has seen the obsession of this government with changing colours of buildings, buses and even bridges... now the same government has changed the colours of our national team." Hockey India declined to comment on whether the orange kit will also be worn at the Asian Games where the rest of the Indian contingent will be in blue.

Pellet gun

the Centre, Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) and RAJ. "Prayers (in the petitions) are not to use pellet guns. In exceptional cases, police regulations permit the use of pellet guns. If you are interested in phasing out pellet guns, you will have to challenge that very provision as ultra vires to Article 21," Justice Bagchi said.

The petitioners sought the declassification of wholly or partly metallic kinetic projectiles, including pellets fired from pump-action rifles or projectile action guns, for crowd dispersal by law enforcement agencies during civilian assemblies.

They argued that although these guns are described as "less lethal" or "non-lethal" alternatives to firearms, firing them at close range could cause fatal or severe injuries. Appearing for the petitioners, Advocate Vrinda Grover said a document of the BPRD, which prescribes the SOP for crowd control, does not include the use of pellet guns.

Justice Bagchi, however, said the document "is a proposal". The judge said the graded response starts with a declaration of a crowd as an unlawful assembly, an announcement for dispersal, and then the application of appropriate force. "One of those graded approaches includes

the use of pellet guns," he said.

Grover argued that the choice of weapon and level of force would have to be based on the "principles of reasonableness, necessity and proportionality". Justice Bagchi reiterated that the prayer for declassification of pellet guns was "vague", saying that the rule permitting it would have to be declared ultra vires first. "Here, we are not averse to examining the use of pellets in a particular incident. But when you say that at no stage metallic pellet can be used, you must clearly state that pellets which is (not) a permissible use as per the extant rules governing a graded response to force," Justice Bagchi said.

"Secondly, this graded response to force must clearly remove the use of pellets, when graded response... may permit the use of pellets in extreme cases," he said, adding, "allowing the use of bullets and no use of pellets cannot be on the same plane." The CJI said the petitioners could seek a court order for framing a protocol. Justice Bagchi said the petitioners must indicate any provision in Delhi, or elsewhere, to establish "that the use of pellets appears to be arbitrary, unreasonable and inappropriate... that it must first be rubber pellets and then only metallic pellets." SC asked petitioners to challenge any relevant standing orders.

PUBLIC NOTICE
GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA
EXCISE & TAXATION DEPARTMENT
NOTICE FOR INVITING E-TENDERS FOR GENERAL PUBLIC FOR RE-ALLOTMENT OF TWO ZONES OF RETAIL LIQUOR VENDS OF DISTRICT GURGRAM (EAST) AND GURGRAM (WEST) IN THE STATE OF HARYANA FOR THE REMAINING PERIOD OF THE EXCISE POLICY YEAR 2025-2027.
1. It is hereby notified for the information of the general public that e-tenders are invited for the re-allotment of Zone No. ZGRE13 and Zone No. ZGRW04 comprising of retail liquor vendes of Country Liquor (CL) and Indian Made Foreign Liquor (IMFL) (D-21-14A) in District Gurgram (East) and District Gurgram (West), respectively, in the State of Haryana, for the remaining period of the Excise Policy Year 2025-2027.
2. The schedule for submission of e-bids for the above said zones and evaluation thereof shall be as under:
Starting date and time for placing e-tenders From 31st July, 2026 (9:00 AM)
Closing date and time for placing e-tenders Till 1st August, 2026 (04:00 PM)
Evaluation of e-tenders 1st August, 2026 (5:00 PM)
3. The reserve price of these zones for the purpose of e-tendering has been decided as per the provisions of clause 2.1.7 and other relevant provisions of the Haryana Excise Policy 2025-27.
The reserve price and quota of these zones shall be displayed in the excise arrangement.
4. The e-tenders for these zones can be submitted online through the official website of the department i.e. www.haryanatax.gov.in. The remaining terms and conditions of e-tenders and allotment of zones shall be same, as informed vide the Public Notice, published in leading newspapers on 21st May, 2025, for inviting e-tender for allotment of retail liquor vendes in the State of Haryana. The copy of Public Notice dated 21st May, 2025 is also available on the official website of department i.e. www.haryanatax.gov.in. The detailed procedure of registration for participation in the allotment process and submission of e-tenders is also available on the official website.
5. The excise arrangements of these zones containing number of vend, liquor quota, location of vend, colour and area applicable and reserve price thereof, as well as the venue for evaluation of e-tenders shall be conspicuously displayed in the office of DETCS (Excise) and DETCS (ST) of the district concerned. These details shall also be available on the official website i.e. www.haryanatax.gov.in.
6. The re-allotment of these zones shall be done at the risk and cost of original allottee. The original allottee shall be liable to make up any deficiency incurred by the State as a result of the re-allotment of these zones.
7. The allotment and grant of licence shall be subject to the provisions of the Haryana Excise Act, 1914, the rules framed thereunder, orders/instructions issued by the competent authority and the Excise Policy for the year 2025-27. Any clarification regarding the procedure may be obtained from the office of DETCS (Excise) in any of the districts. The copy of Haryana Excise Policy for the year 2025-27 is available on official website of the department.
8. The allotment shall be subject to the approval of Excise and Taxation Commissioner (PCH), Haryana. He may reject, without assigning any reason, any allotment in public interest as the case may be, within 10 days of the date of allotment.

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Delhi FIRs

alleged irregularities in the NEET (UG) examination... No adverse legal action will be taken by... police authorities within the national capital against those persons who have been involved in these protests," read the note undersigned by Principal Secretary (Home) Santosh D Vaidya. The protection, however, will not extend to persons with criminal antecedents, as mandated in the Supreme Court order, it added.

In a statement, Delhi Home Minister, Ashish Sodhi, said: "The department... has clarified that students who participated peacefully in the protest have no reason for concern or fear. The government fully respects the democratic right to peaceful expression, but no leniency will be shown towards those who disrupt law and order or engage in violent activities."

"This relief," he said, "will not apply to individuals who already have criminal cases registered against them or those who indulged in violence, vandalism, or any other unlawful activities under the guise of the protest. Such persons will face action."

Assam

The official death toll in the flood-ravaged state this year stands at 78. At its height, the number of people affected by these floods was over 7 lakh, but as the floodwaters gradually receded, it came down to around 3 lakh. Thousands have been displaced—at its peak, over 1.15 lakh were taking shelter in relief camps, which has now come down to 16,556.

For his part, Assam CM Himanta Biswa Sarma has hinted at a relief and rehabilitation package after the Inter-Ministerial Central Team concluded its four-day assessment of the flood-hit districts Wednesday. "Our Double Engine Govt will support the sufferings of our people," Sarma said on X.

In Nepalkhuti village in Sivapagar's Nongla block, right along the Assam-Nagaland border, Hari Sarma stands under a banyan tree some 200 metres from the Dikhow River, knee-deep in mud and wearing nothing but a pair of shorts. He's lost everything: his tin-roofed house, his clothes, furniture, documents and 15 of his cattle. "Over 1,200 cows and calves were swept away in an instant across the village," Sarma, a resident of Nepalkhuti, in the rev-

enue village Garhmurmi, tells *The Indian Express*. He looks down at his shorts. "This is all I have left."

With the IMD issuing an Orange Alert across parts of the Northeast for next three days, residents are an anxious lot. "Not even our grandfathers have witnessed such a flood this catastrophic," one resident of Nepalkhuti says.

Nepalkhuti, on the banks of the Dikhow River, which flows from Nagaland into Assam before joining Brahmaputra near Dikhowmukh, bears witness to the devastation of the floods. On July 19, the river that was its lifeblood engulfed this village of at least 500, sweeping into homes, breaking down walls and tearing through lives, its surging current taking away everything—clothes, beds, utensils, and cattle.

Residents, many of whom are dairy farmers, say they had little time to think. Many were sleeping in the open, but even those who were swept away, where the river peaked at six-and-a-half feet.

Assam government has announced an ex gratia of Rs 9 lakh for kin of those who have died in the floods; and an interment amount of Rs 15,000 for families severely affected in the village confronted the deaths of Shivsagar, Charadeo, Jorhat and Golaghat. WITH INPUTS FROM SUKRITA BARUAH

A suffocating blanket of mud and debris covers the village, and a heavy stretch of decay hangs in the air. Roads and houses are coated with quicksand-like sludge. "No one knows what lies beneath the mud around them: decaying livestock or human remains," says Hari Sarma, gesturing towards a mound of sludge.

For many, their entire existence has shrunk into one exhausting, hopeless battle: digging mud out of their homes, bucket by bucket.

That's what Anupal Baruah and his family are now doing. He is a school teacher, but the main road, an old one where the family lives, and a new one, finished only a month ago.

Both houses have now turned to sludge. In the new house—a long-cherished family dream—two feet of heavy mud now coats the floor, and higher up, the black water stain marks the place where the river peaked at six-and-a-half feet.

Assam government has announced an ex gratia of Rs 9 lakh for kin of those who have died in the floods; and an interment amount of Rs 15,000 for families severely affected in the village confronted the deaths of Shivsagar, Charadeo, Jorhat and Golaghat. WITH INPUTS FROM SUKRITA BARUAH

9 DEAD IN MARCH 18 BLAZE

Bronto Skylift failed, crew not trained — magisterial inquiry report on Palam fire

Gayathri Mani
New Delhi, July 30



At the site of the blaze in Palam. FILE

BRONTO SKYLIFT (hydraulic crane) of the Delhi Fire Services (DFS) failed during the rescue operation after its boom became entangled in overhead cables and banners, no backup high-reach rescue equipment was available and firefighters had to rely on a manual ladder that could not reach the third floor balcony — these are the major findings of a magisterial inquiry into the March 18 fire in a four-story building in Palam that killed nine people, including three children, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

The report was submitted by District Magistrate (South West) Mekala Chaitanya Prasad to the Home department last month. The file is now proposed to be placed before the Lieutenant Governor for consideration, officials said.

"The Bronto Skylift (BS-III) failed at the scene — most likely due to cables/wires/banners entangled in its boom and no effective second line of defence (an alternative tall ladder) was immediately available... a manual ladder could not reach the third floor balcony," the report said.

The inquiry also found that the crew assigned to operate the skylift had never received formal training from the authorised dealer since the machine was procured in 2006. "They learned informally from predecessors," the report said.

It added that maintenance logs of the skylift shows no prior faults were reported despite it being used in operations at IGI Airport, Tilak Nagar and Palam during incidents of fire.

Further, the report highlighted several lapses by the MCD and other agencies,

which resulted in the tragedy. It blamed the MCD for allowing commercial activity on the building's first floor though the licence permitted commercial use only in the basement and ground floor.

As per the report, the fire probably originated from an MCB box located on the ground and first floor stairs, a point where around six electrical connections were concentrated. It added that the fire "spread rapidly, aggravated by combustible cosmetic stock".

While a short circuit is considered the probable cause of the fire, the report said this cannot be confirmed until the forensic report is received because the electrical installation was extensively damaged.

The report recommended disciplinary action against MCD licensing inspector Narendra Dabas for failing to check violation of license conditions. "Dabas, who was working under the supervision of assistant commissioner Najafgarh Zone also failed in his duty to remove aerial banners on roads," it added.

According to the report, firefighters had to manually clear

low-hanging cables and banners with the help of local residents before positioning the Bronto Skylift.

It also flagged that the assistant electrical inspector, who led the inspection, had received no technical training since he joined the Fire department in 2012. "...admitted he had never been able to determine the cause of fire in any of 8-9 prior inspections — a serious capability gap in a statutory technical role," the report highlighted.

It recommended that a technical expert committee be set up to investigate the Bronto Skylift's failure, ensure deployment of backup high-rise rescue equipment at major fires and filling up of 853 vacant posts in the Fire department on priority.

Highlighting that the fire could not be controlled due to "unauthorised cabling" in the area, the report recommended: "Bring all local cable/Internet service providers under a regulatory framework... Make provider name-marking on cables compulsory for identification of violators, consider road width as a criterion (while deciding on installing) overhead (or) underground cabling..."

Delhi Police chief sets priorities for force; stresses result-oriented policing, timely complaint disposal

Mahender Singh Manral
New Delhi, July 30

NEWLY APPOINTED Delhi Police Commissioner Anurag Kumar has asked his colleagues to maintain the highest standards of integrity, professionalism and ethical conduct, irrespective of their ranks.

At an interaction with senior officers on July 18, Kumar underlined a set of policing priorities for various districts and units. He stressed visible policing, timely complaint disposal, integrity in administration and better coordination among agencies.

The meeting was attended by special commissioners, joint

commissioners, additional commissioners, and deputy commissioners.

"He (CP Kumar) told officers that the Delhi Police is counted among the finest police forces in the country, a standing that is tested every day under intense scrutiny and in an increasingly complex operating environment. But its reputation and image have to be restored through credible, visible and result-oriented policing on the ground," a senior police officer, who attended the meeting, said.

One of the key directions issued at the meeting was to make basic policing a priority for every officer.



Delhi Police Commissioner Anurag Kumar FILE

On integrity and institutional accountability, Kumar underlined a zero-tolerance approach towards corruption, unethical practices and undesirable conduct.

Kumar clearly conveyed

that "strict action will be taken against erring officials", adding that supervisory officers should maintain continuous oversight over subordinate staff.

"He asked [officers] to ensure transparency, fairness and objectivity in transfers and postings, and administrative decisions. There will not be any instance, under any circumstances, of transfers/postings against illegal gratification," the officer added.

Officers were also directed to monitor platforms for feedback, intelligence and ground-level sentiment, and use official handles for public communication and grievance redressal. Kumar cautioned that organ-

isational goals should guide the use of social media and that it should not be used for "self-promotion".

"He said in the meeting that a manpower audit is also to be conducted in every unit to assess optimal utilisation of available strength, followed by rationalisation of deployment," the officer said.

On grievance redressal, Kumar directed that an open-door policy be followed by all officers, with complainants given proper access to senior officials. "Complaints must be disposed of within defined timelines, and feedback on action taken should be shared with complainants," the officer said.

CJP stir: Noida woman booked for 'abusive' remarks against PM

Drishiti Jain
New Delhi, July 30

THE NOIDA Police has lodged a zero FIR against a woman for allegedly making "objectionable remarks" against Prime Minister Narendra Modi during the Cokroach Janta Party's (CJP) protest at Jantar Mantar on July 23, officers said on Thursday. The complaint was filed by Smriti Singh, a resident of Ghaziabad on Wednesday at the Expressway Police station against Ruchika Singh, a resident of Noida, an officer said.

In the complaint, Smriti alleged that Ruchika used abusive and objectionable language against Modi. The complaint further alleged that the remarks did not only "undermine the dignity of the constitutional office", but also deliberately intended to spread hatred and disrupt public peace."

The police have registered a case under sections 352 (intentional insult to provoke breach of peace), 353(1) (statements conducing to public mischief) and 356(1) (defamation) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), the officer added.

A zero FIR means that a complaint can be filed at any police station irrespective of the place of alleged crime or where the incident took place, post which it is transferred to the police station of the concerned jurisdiction.

According to officers, the FIR has been transferred to the Parliament Street Police station. "The accused is a resident of Faridabad, and used to stay in Noida. We have transferred the FIR to the concerned jurisdiction where further investigation will take place," an officer added.

This comes amid the Delhi Police also filing an FIR over "objectionable and defamatory" social media posts targeting the PM during protests at Jantar Mantar and asking social media platforms to take down such content.

A case under charges of criminal intimidation, public mischief, and defamation has been lodged at the Special Cell IPSO (Intelligence Fusion and Strategic Operations) unit in connection with the matter. *The Indian Express* had reported.

Govt to introduce Land Records Bill, issue smart cards to all properties

Gayathri Mani
New Delhi, July 30

TO CREATE a unified database of its own, the Delhi government is set to introduce a Delhi Land Records Bill 2026, under which it will conduct a survey of all residential and commercial properties in both rural and urban areas and digitise the records. The digitised land records will be linked to the government's Family Card initiative, which is aimed at creating a unified database of Delhi's households, to streamline the distribution of welfare schemes, healthcare benefits and other government services.

Speaking about the survey, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said, "The entire Delhi will be surveyed and mapped using aerial and drone surveys."

Gupta said that every household in the city will be issued a unique property card and a family Aadhaar card, and if any family sells their property, the property card will be transferred to the new owner.

Mentioning that the Delhi government had already prepared smart property cards for 30 rural villages under the SVA-MITVA scheme, Gupta said that the government, building



Chief Minister Rekha Gupta. X/COMODLHI

on this experience, will now undertake a comprehensive survey of land and properties across the NCT.

"Currently, the survey work has been started on a pilot basis in rural areas. Information will be gathered about land belonging to farmers and eliminate disputes... It is, in a way, like an Aadhaar card for land," the CM said.

"Every property in Delhi will now get a secure and authentic digital identity. This will make property records across the Capital more transparent, well-organised and technologically secure. The government will also convene a special session of the Delhi Legislative Assembly in connection with the Bill," Gupta added.

"A digital record will be cre-

ated for every floor of every building, ensuring that no property in the Capital remains outside the scope of the exercise... For decades, the absence of a systematic land records system has caused difficulties in proving ownership, property transactions, inheritance, securing loans, building plan approvals and resolving disputes pending before courts. Authenticated digital property records will eliminate ambiguity, improve transparency and significantly reduce land-related disputes," she said.

The CM said that the aim is also to lay a strong foundation for Delhi's future digital governance framework. She further said that the Delhi Land Records Bill is currently in the approval stage after an extensive review by the Group of Ministers.

The family card, to be provided to every household in Delhi, will bear details of members, their caste, occupation, mention if they are availing any benefits under any welfare scheme, vaccination records and other essential information. Officials said that this can be used as a proof by people seeking benefits under various social welfare schemes of the Delhi government.

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Likely before fast-track court: Paper leak cases impacted after judge moved out at key stages

Nirbhay Thakur
New Delhi, July 30

THE FAST-TRACK court of Special Judge Anil Grover Baliga will take up the CBI's 20,000-page chargesheet in the NEET-UG 2026 paper leak case on Monday.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi announced the setting up of fast-track courts to ensure swift and stringent punishment for exam fraud in the midst of the students' protest demanding accountability for the NEET leak.

Besides the NEET case, Judge Baliga's court is also likely to take up other exam fraud cases.

Here are three cases which had come before Additional Chief Judicial Magistrate (ACJM) Neetu Nagar of Rouse Avenue Courts before the judge was deputed to the National Green Tribunal last month.

2003 CAT paper leak

STATUS: Still at the stage of

"arguments on charge" before a Rouse Avenue Magistrate Court. This is the stage before the framing of charges. Trials start after charges are framed.

AFFECTED CANDIDATES: More than 1.25 lakh candidates had applied for the Common Admission Test scheduled for November 23, 2003. The test was cancelled, and held in February 2004.

WHAT HAPPENED: On November 22, a day before the exam, the Delhi Police was tipped off that the paper had been leaked. The CBI, which took over the probe, zeroed in on a hotel in Mahipalpur in south-west Delhi where it seized various documents of the alleged question paper from individuals.

Investigators recorded the statements of candidates who claimed that Rs 2 lakh to Rs 4 lakh had been demanded from them for the "leaked paper".

The CBI submitted the chargesheet in 2004.

PROGRESS OF CASE: From May 2019, when the case

was transferred to the Rouse Avenue Court, to May 2026, there were nine hearings every year on average. The Covid-19 pandemic contributed to the delay.

On June 3 this year, ACJM Nagar reserved her order on the charges due to the "heavy case list" and because "no time was left". The ACJM said the order would be passed on June 26. However, on June 22, she was deputed to the NGT's Principal Bench in New Delhi, where she is currently Deputy Registrar. The case is now before a 'link' judge, who is also a Magistrate at the Rouse Avenue Court.

2023 AIIMS NORCEFT-4 leak

STATUS: Arguments on charge were heard for about a year, but not completed. They will now be heard afresh by the fast-track court.

AFFECTED CANDIDATES: Around 90,000.

The case was transferred to the exam to recruit nurses in AIIMS and four other hospitals in



The recent protest at Jantar Mantar over 2026 NEET paper leak. FILE

Delhi was held on June 3, 2023. Two days later, a leak was alleged on social media. Screenshots, allegedly of a candidate's console, were posted. On June 6, the Associate Dean (Exams), AIIMS, filed a complaint against one Ritvi, and Gian Jyoti Institute of Management and Technology, Phase-II, Mohali. The CBI filed an FIR alleging that a computer at the institute was used by or on behalf of Ritvi for the "purpose of cheating".

The CBI alleged a criminal conspiracy to "rig the examination process by using unfair means in favour of accused candidates against illegal monetary consideration". It claimed that the accused had informed others that they "would get the answers before 30 minutes of completion of the examination".

PROGRESS OF CASE: On August 28, 2023, Magistrate Deepak Kumar 2 took cognisance of the chargesheet. Later, the case came to ACJM Nagar, who had replaced Kumar.

ments on June 9.

2024 UGC NET paper leak

STATUS: CBI has filed a closure report, which the court has refused to accept.

AFFECTED CANDIDATES: The alleged leak impacted more than 9 lakh candidates who appeared for the exam in 317 cities.

WHAT HAPPENED: The eligibility exam for entry-level teaching jobs in colleges and admission to PhD courses was held on June 18, 2024. On June 19, the Education Ministry cancelled the exam after "inputs from National Cyber Crime Threat Analytics Unit of Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C)...prima facie indicate(d) that the integrity of the...examination may have been compromised".

In July, the CBI found that the alleged evidence on which the Education Ministry had acted was "doctored". This alleged "evidence" was a pur-

ported screenshot of the paper that was circulated on Telegram around 2 pm on the day of the exam, with messages and comments suggesting the paper had been leaked before the first session of the exam.

PROGRESS OF CASE: The CBI filed a closure report in January 2025, saying it had found no evidence of a leak. It said that forensic experts had established that the purported screenshot was created by a school student using a mobile phone application. After the report was filed, 13 hearings were held. On May 15, 2026, ACJM Nagar asked CBI to explain why it had filed a closure report even though its own findings showed that a suspect had collected money from candidates by "turning them with leaked question papers".

The explanation furnished by the investigating officers yet to be considered by the court. After ACJM Nagar was deputed to NGT, the case was heard once by a link judge. The next date of hearing is August 6.

Umar Khalid moves HC for third time seeking bail

Sohini Ghosh
New Delhi, July 30

FOR THE third time, activist Umar Khalid has moved the Delhi High Court, seeking bail in the larger conspiracy case of Northeast Delhi riots in 2020. He has been booked under the stringent Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA).

Khalid's appeal challenging the trial court's July 4 decision to dismiss his bail application is listed for hearing before a bench of Justices Prathiba Singh and Vikas Mahajan on Friday.

The HC had earlier rejected his bail plea twice – in October 2022 and September 2025. Both times, the Supreme Court had upheld the HC order.

Khalid, arrested in September 2020, was booked under UAPA for being one of the "masterminds" of the riots that had left 53 people dead and more than 700 injured. Besides him, activist Sharjeel Imam, among others, was also booked in the case.

The SC, in its order on January 5, had refused bail to Khalid and Imam, but granted bail to five other co-accused while establishing the "hierarchy of participation". In this hierarchy, Khalid and Imam were classified to be on a "higher footing" compared to the five others who were granted bail by the SC.

The trial court, while rejecting Khalid's and Imam's bail pleas on July 4 had observed that it "has no option but to follow" the January 5 judgment of the Supreme Court, whereby the petitions of both the applicants were dismissed. The SC had also observed no change in their circumstances to allow a fresh plea before the trial court had added.

Khalid, a former JNU student leader, has been booked for offences under the IPC, Prevention of Damage to Public Property Act, Arms Act and UAPA.

Govt plans random, door-to-door visits to verify women eligible for Lakshmi Yojana

Gayathri Mani
New Delhi, July 30

THE DELHI government is planning to conduct door-to-door, random verification of women found eligible for the Delhi Lakshmi Yojana, under which beneficiaries will receive a monthly financial assistance of Rs 2,500. *The Indian Express* has learned.

As part of the verification process, the government will check whether applicants meet the scheme's eligibility conditions – whether they have more than three living children, if they are residents of Delhi and registered voters of the city, if they pay income tax, are they in the 21-60 years age group, whether their family's income is up to Rs 2.5 lakh per annum and if they receive any other financial aid from the Centre or the state, among others.

The three-child cap is a first-of-its-kind exclusion criteria introduced by the Delhi government for its social welfare schemes.

"The application process is very simple and easy. People can submit their information from anywhere. Verification is necessary to ensure only eligible beneficiaries receive the assistance," a senior government functionary said.

The functionary added that the Women and Child Development (WCD) department might engage a third-party agency to conduct the random checks. "The objective is to ensure that the scheme reaches the needy and deserving beneficiaries while maintaining transparency in the implementation process."

Asked about the three-child cap, the senior functionary said, "Some Opposition parties are trying to give it (three-child

cap) a religious angle but they are wrong. Be it Hindu or Muslim, it is one's choice on how many children they want to have."

Besides, this might be a step towards better family planning and population control, the functionary said. "People these days are educated and follow family planning. But in many lower middle class families, women are still pressured to have four-five children until they have a boy."

"For family planning and population control, you have to take steps somewhere... The government has come up with a proper financial plan with two bifurcations – the woman can either invest the Rs 2,500 and get a lumpsum amount with interest after three years or she can invest Rs 1,500 and spend the rest through a digital card," the functionary said.

"This gives her the right to decide where she wants to spend her money... In many families, husbands pressure them... take their money to buy alcohol and tobacco... We want our mothers and sisters to independently use their money," the senior functionary added.

According to officials, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, who holds the WCD portfolio, has specially said that the scheme should empower women and also that their health is a priority.

The scheme, approved by the Cabinet on Tuesday, was one of the major poll promises made by the BJP in the run-up to the Assembly elections in 2025.

A portal for registration under the scheme will be launched on August 1 and the disbursement of first instalment will begin from Raksha Bandhan, said officials.



For the Kanwariyas

Tents being built for Kanwariyas along Delhi-Meerut Expressway as Thursday marked the beginning of Sawan month and the Kanwar Yatra.

Love, lies and fake gold: An extramarital affair that led to a Rs 3-crore loan fraud

Pragnesh
New Delhi, July 30

IT BEGAN with a phone call received from a wrong number.

Around 2015, Pankaj Kumar, a gold appraiser at non-banking financial company (NBFC) Sai Corporation in Delhi, received a call from a woman who had dialled the wrong number. The two stayed in touch and eventually began an affair. Pankaj, however, was already married with two children.

He soon found out that it was difficult to support both his family and the woman on his salary. The result: he went on to siphon money from his company, orchestrating a gold loan fraud worth more than Rs 3 crore over six years. During this time, he transferred around Rs 90 lakh to bank accounts linked to the woman in multiple transactions.

According to the Economic Offences Wing (EOW) of the Delhi Police, between 2019 and 2025, Pankaj and his colleague in Sai Corporation, S P Bansal, created 683 fake gold loan accounts



Accused Pankaj Kumar

using forged KYC documents and artificial jewellery. Loans worth over Rs 3 crore were allegedly taken in the names of 28 people, many of them former customers of the company.

Pankaj was arrested on July 7, Bansal is out on bail.

The alleged fraud came to light during an internal audit at Sai Corporation in August 2025.

Pankaj had worked as a gold appraiser with the company for over a decade. His job was to verify the jewellery to be used as collateral by checking its hallmark and weight before approving loans and storing the ornaments in the company's lockers.

"One of the company's di-

rectors, Dr R K Tandon, said that there were discrepancies in the accounts Pankaj was handling. Following this, he was transferred to another branch, but refused to join work. The company then ordered an audit," said an officer.

During the audit, when Pankaj was questioned about gold worth nearly Rs 14 lakh that was missing from the company's lockers but found mentioned in the official records, he allegedly lost it. "He allegedly shouted and stormed out of the office. He never came back," the officer said.

"Pankaj facilitated the creation of fake gold loan accounts by appraising fake and artificial gold ornaments as genuine and using forged KYC documents and fake customer identities," said Special Commissioner of Police (EOW) Nupur Prasad.

The company got an FIR lodged. When an EOW team led by DCP Amit Verma started going through company records, they found that the story began around 2015 when he received the call from a wrong

number. "The woman was from Delhi. The two started talking and entered into a relationship," said the officer. At that time, Pankaj, now in his 40s, lived with his wife and two children in Rohini's Budh Vihar.

"We traced the money that Pankaj had siphoned from the bank. One of the transactions was of Rs 16 lakh, which was credited to the woman's account in 2019," said the officer.

According to the police, between 2019 and 2025, Pankaj transferred over Rs 90 lakh to multiple accounts linked to the woman. "He said there was no other way for him to take care of her and his family at the same time," the officer said.

When police tracked people whose identities were used to secure the fraudulent loans, they found that many were former customers of Sai Corporation. "Two of them were Suresh, an MCD worker, who lives in Rajouri Garden, and his wife. He used their details to create two accounts," said the officer.

Pankaj and Bansal were eventually arrested.

• Skywatch



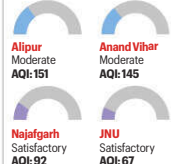
Forecast: July 31, 2026

Generally cloudy sky, possibility of very light rain
MAX: 34-36
1.6°C below normal

MIN: 25-27
0.1°C below normal

• Sunrise: 5:43 AM (August 1)
• Sunset: 7:13 PM (July 31)
• Moonrise: 8:22 PM (July 31)
• Moonset: 7:59 AM (August 1)

• AQI Tracker



● Good (0-50)
● Satisfactory (51-100)
● Moderate (101-200)
● Poor (201-300)
● Very Poor (301-400)
● Severe (401-500)

MCD signs deal with OIL to set up 2 compressed biogas plants

Mishal Mussaddique
New Delhi, July 30

TO CONVERT 800 tonnes per day (TPD) of wet waste into biogas and organic fertilisers, the Municipal Corporation Delhi (MCD) and the Oil India Limited (OIL) on Thursday signed an MoU in the presence of the Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta and Mayor Praveesh Wahi for the establishment of two bio-methanation based compressed biogas (CBG) plants, officials said.

According to an official statement, two Bio-CBG plants with a combined processing capacity of 800 TPD will be established in the first phase. A 500-TPD plant will be developed on 10 acres of land at Tehkhand, while a 300-TPD plant will be set up on seven acres at Okhla, an official said.

These facilities will scientifically process segregated organic waste to produce CBG and organic fertiliser, contributing to cleaner and more sustainable waste management, the official added.

Gupta said that addressing Delhi's civic challenges "requires coordinated efforts by the Centre, the Delhi government, local bodies, public sector enterprises, the private sector and civil society".

"Delhi generates nearly 13,500 metric tonnes of solid waste every day, while the existing processing capacity remains inadequate, leading to the accumulation of landfill mounds over the years. The two CBG plants with a combined capacity of 800 TPD will provide a sustainable solution by converting wet waste into biogas and organic fertiliser, benefiting the environment, promoting clean energy, and supporting the agricultural sector," Gupta also said.

Wahi said, "Not a single rupee will be spent by the MCD. The cost of around 400 crores and operation of the plants will be borne by OIL and MCD will provide land for the plant site."

• FASTER INTERCHANGES, LINKS TO OLD CITY AND DWARKA EXPRESSWAY

Gurgaon's upcoming 28-km Metro line will make your daily commute easier

Abhimanyu Hazarika
Gurgaon, July 30

FOR COMMUTERS in Gurgaon, changing Metro lines could soon mean a walk across platforms instead of a trip outside the station. The city's upcoming 28.5-km loop will create seamless interchanges with existing and upcoming transit networks while extending connectivity to areas of Old Gurgaon that have remained outside the Metro grid.

Running in a continuous loop, the line will start at Millennium City Centre on Delhi Metro's Yellow Line. It will cover areas such as Sector 45, Cyber Park, Subhash Chowk, Palam Vihar, Udyog Vihar Phase 6,

Cyber City, before terminating at Sector 101 on the Dwarka Expressway spur. (see map)

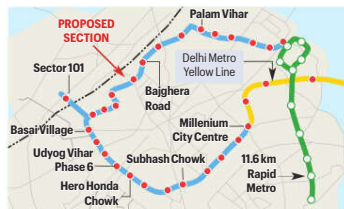
After inspecting the entire alignment, including Rapid Metro, and the upcoming Delhi-Awar rapid rail corridor inside Awar, paid corridor.

At Millennium City Centre, the new line will connect with Delhi Metro's Yellow Line through a platform-to-platform interchange. Additional multimodal integration points are planned at Subhash Chowk to link with the proposed Bhonsli line; at Hero Honda Chowk for the Delhi-SNRRTS; at Sector 5 for the Gurugram Railway Station; and at Sector 10 for a planned mega bus terminal.

signing a terminal station equipped with a double vestibule. It will allow commuters to hop directly between the two lines.

At Millennium City Centre, the new line will connect with Delhi Metro's Yellow Line through a platform-to-platform interchange. Additional multimodal integration points are planned at Subhash Chowk to link with the proposed Bhonsli line; at Hero Honda Chowk for the Delhi-SNRRTS; at Sector 5 for the Gurugram Railway Station; and at Sector 10 for a planned mega bus terminal.

• THE NEW METRO LOOP



GMRL is attempting an ambitious spatial fix along the stretch from Sector 7 to Cyber

City. As the line will pass through congested residential pockets where roads are narrow,

GMRL and the Gurgaon Metropolitan Development Authority are evaluating double-decker station designs at Baighera Road and Sector 21.

By stacking Metro tracks directly above existing road flyovers within the same median footprint, the project aims to avoid aggressive land acquisition while preventing severe traffic chokepoints. While the ring completes a full circuit through the city's commercial nerve centers, Old Gurgaon and the Dwarka Expressway belt will gain the most from this layout.

For decades, densely populated areas such as Sectors 3, 4, 5, 7, 9, Basai, and Palam Vihar were entirely omitted from the Metro

grid. This loop brings Old Gurgaon directly onto the map, connecting residential neighbourhoods directly to office hubs in Cyber City and Udyog Vihar.

The Dwarka Expressway belt will also get a direct link through a two-station spur line from Basai Village to Sector 101.

Work on the ground is moving into heavy construction mode. The first Rs 1,503-crore package (Package CC-01), awarded to Dilip Buildcon-Ranjit Buildcon joint venture, covers a 15.2-km stretch and has a 30-month construction timeline.

Casting yards are operational, producing precast concrete segments for the elevated viaduct, while piling and pier

work is underway between the GMDA office and Hero Honda Chowk. The narrow Old Gurgaon stretch, designated as Priority-2, is being prepared for the next phase with World Bank funding assistance.

According to timelines discussed in meetings chaired by Union Minister Rao Inderjit Singh, GMRL has set August 2028 as the completion deadline for the primary Millennium City Centre-Sector 9 corridor. Officials are pushing contractors to complete major civil structures in Package 1 by late 2027 to allow early trial runs. As of July 21, the 28.5-km project had achieved around 11% physical progress, officials said.

Citing need for Central funds, Kerala UDF reverses stand on PM SHRI

Shaju Philip
Thiruvananthapuram, July 30

KERALA'S RULING Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF) Thursday decided to implement the Union Government's Pradhan Mantri Schools for Rising India (PM SHRI) scheme in state-run schools — a significant U-turn for a coalition that had once strenuously opposed it.

After a UDF meeting on Thursday, alliance convener and Congress MP Adoor Prakash said the coalition had decided to implement the Bharatiya Janata Party-led Centre's PM SHRI in Kerala schools.

"The previous UDF government had signed an MoU with the Centre. Hence, the present government cannot withdraw from it. The UDF government will take forward the project to get the fund, which is not a magnanimity of the Centre. A UDF sub-committee will finalise the schools where the project has to be implemented," he said.

It is a significant departure from the UDF's previous stance.

As Opposition, it had criticised the scheme, accusing the previous UDF government of facilitating the Sangh Parivar's "safonisation" of education by signing the MoU with the Centre.

Ally IUML's, one of the scheme's most vocal critics, stance is also softened, which now holds the education portfolio. In the run-up to the polls, the IUML had warned that the scheme would be "abandoned" if it was voted to power. They justified this by arguing that Kerala needs the central funds while safeguarding the rights in the field of education.

"The shift comes at a time of financial constraints and rising education arrears in Kerala, which stand at Rs 1,466 crore. It has prompted the UDF and UDF governments to change their previous positions.

In Kerala, 33 Kendriya Vidyalayas and 14 Navodaya Vidyalayas are part of the scheme. Under PM SHRI, states have to bear 40% of the project expenditure. So far, 13,095 schools, from primary to higher-secondary level, across 776 districts have become part of the scheme.

'Obsessed' with changing colours: Naveen on new Hockey jerseys

Sujit Bisoiy
Bhubaneswar, July 30

QUESTIONING HOCKEY India's decision to change the national hockey team's jersey from its traditional blue to saffron, former Odisha chief minister Naveen Patnaik Thursday alleged that the move was made under pressure from the BJP government in the state.

"The Odisha government is the official sponsor of the team. Patnaik said on X that the Odisha BJP government has shown an "obsession" with changing the colours of build-

ings, buses and even bridges.

"I strongly condemn this attempt by BJP-Odisha to politicise a national game like hockey. It has deeply hurt the sentiments of lakhs of sports lovers across the country and the pride with which Odisha has supported national hockey," noted Patnaik.

"Our blue jersey is to us what the iconic stripes are to Argentina and the yellow jersey is to Brazil. It is etched in our collective memory. Any change in this colour, is a crass attempt to erase our priceless sporting legacy. National symbols are meant to unite us, not divide," he said.

**दिल्ली प्रौद्योगिकी विश्वविद्यालय**
DELHI TECHNOLOGICAL UNIVERSITY
(Formerly Delhi College of Engineering)
Shahbad Daultpur, Bawana Road, Delhi - 110042

OPEN TENDER NOTICE
On behalf of Hon'ble Vice Chancellor, Delhi Technological University (DTU), Delhi Officer In-Charge (Purchase Section), invites bids under a two-bid system (Technical and Financial Bid) in Delhi Technological University from an authorized Firm/OEM for the purchase of the following item:

Sr. No.	Description	GeM Bid ID
1	Gas Analyser (Lab equipment)	GEM/2026/B/778400
2	High-End Desktop Computer	GEM/2026/B/7798153
3	Workstation with Graphic Card	GEM/2026/B/7811907

The details are available on the GeM Portal. Firms must submit their offer only through the GeM Portal in two bid system. The bid document is also available for viewing on the website of DTU, www.dtu.ac.in. For any query, please contact us at the telephone no. 011-27871018.

Note: Corrigendum, if any, will be issued through the GeM portal only.

TATA					
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Registered Office: Bombay House, 24, Homi Mody Street, Fort, Mumbai - 400 001 India Tel.: 91 22 6665 8282 • Email: cscec@tatasteel.com • Website: www.tatasteel.com CIN: L27100MH1907PLC000260					
NOTICE					
Extract of Standalone Financial Results for the quarter ended on 30th June 2026					
Particulars	Quarter ended on 30.06.2026	Quarter ended on 31.03.2026	Quarter ended on 30.06.2025	Financial year ended on 31.03.2026	
	Audited	Audited	Audited	Audited	
Total revenue from operations	36,896.55	38,447.96	31,014.36	1,39,720.22	
Net Profit / (Loss) for the period (before tax and exceptional items)	6,112.02	6,477.98	4,776.84	22,451.96	
Net Profit / (Loss) for the period before tax (after exceptional items)	5,820.52	6,345.93	4,557.76	21,353.10	
Net Profit / (Loss) for the period after tax	4,535.59	4,659.74	3,523.25	16,065.13	
Total comprehensive income for the period [Comprising Profit / (Loss) for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax)]	3,477.29	(143.12)	6,743.37	13,295.44	
Paid-up equity share capital [Face value ₹ 1 per share]	1,248.60	1,248.60	1,248.60	1,248.60	
Reserves excluding revaluation reserves				1,34,284.71	
Securities premium reserve	31,290.24	31,290.24	31,290.24	31,290.24	
Net Worth	1,35,822.61	1,32,345.31	1,30,287.29	1,32,345.31	
Paid-up Debt Capital	15,159.95	15,159.21	15,157.00	15,159.21	
Debt Equity Ratio	0.49	0.48	0.46	0.50	
Earnings per equity share:					
Basic earnings per share of ₹ 1 each (not annualised) - in Rupees (after exceptional items)	3.63	3.74	2.82	12.87	
Diluted earnings per share of ₹ 1 each (not annualised) - in Rupees (after exceptional items)	3.63	3.73	2.82	12.87	
Debt Redemption Reserve	1,328.75	1,328.75	1,328.75	1,328.75	
Debt Service Coverage Ratio	4.27	6.42	1.34	2.85	
Interest Service Coverage Ratio	7.68	8.27	6.91	8.08	

Extract of Consolidated Financial Results for the quarter ended on 30th June 2026					
Particulars	Quarter ended on 30.06.2026	Quarter ended on 31.03.2026	Quarter ended on 30.06.2025	Financial year ended on 31.03.2026	
	Unaudited	Unaudited	Unaudited	Audited	
Total revenue from operations	60,794.29	63,270.13	53,178.12	2,32,139.94	
Net Profit / (Loss) for the period (before tax and exceptional items)	4,183.01	5,150.42	3,199.20	17,001.15	
Net Profit / (Loss) for the period before tax (after exceptional items)	3,837.53	4,810.37	3,067.08	15,968.69	
Net Profit / (Loss) for the period after tax	2,385.24	2,965.00	2,007.36	10,885.82	
Total comprehensive income for the period [Comprising Profit / (Loss) for the period (after tax) and Other Comprehensive Income (after tax)]	2,336.83	3,755.68	4,351.52	16,377.93	
Paid-up equity share capital [Face value ₹ 1 per share]	1,247.44	1,247.44	1,247.44	1,247.44	
Reserves (excluding revaluation reserves) and Non controlling interest				1,02,533.01	
Net Worth	1,01,054.51	98,768.46	91,464.44	98,768.46	
Debt Equity Ratio	0.80	0.79	0.91	0.82	
Earnings per equity share:					
Basic earnings per share of ₹ 1 each (not annualised) - in Rupees (after exceptional items)	1.86	2.34	1.67	8.65	
Diluted earnings per share of ₹ 1 each (not annualised) - in Rupees (after exceptional items)	1.86	2.34	1.67	8.65	
Debt Redemption Reserve	1,328.75	1,328.75	1,328.75	1,328.75	
Debt Service Coverage Ratio	1.03	0.92	0.98	0.98	
Interest Service Coverage Ratio	4.53	5.27	3.69	4.72	

Note:
The above is an extract of the detailed format of Standalone and Consolidated financial results for the quarter ended on 30th June 2026 filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 and Regulation 52 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulation, 2015. The full format of the Standalone and Consolidated results for the quarter ended on 30th June 2026 are available on the websites of the Stock Exchanges (www.nseindia.com) and the Company's website (www.tatasteel.com).



Sd/-
T V Narendran
Chief Executive Officer & Managing Director
Mumbai, July 30, 2026

Sd/-
Koushik Chatterjee
Executive Director & Chief Financial Officer

TATA STEEL

**ICL Fincorp**

This is an advertisement issued pursuant to Regulation 30(1) of the SEBI (Issue and Listing of Non-Convertible Securities) Regulations, 2021 as amended, for information purpose only.


(Please scan the QR code to view the Prospectus)

ICL FINCORP LIMITED

ICL Fincorp Limited ("our Company" or "the Company" or "the Issuer" or "ICL") was originally incorporated as Jawahar Finance Limited at Chennai, a public limited company under the provisions of the Companies Act, 1956, pursuant to a certificate of incorporation dated December 9, 1991, issued by RoC. The name of our Company was changed to "Irinjalakuda Credits & Leasing Company Limited" pursuant to a fresh certificate of incorporation dated April 26, 2004, issued by the RoC. Later, the name of our Company was changed to "ICL Fincorp Limited" pursuant to a fresh certificate of incorporation dated May 8, 2016, issued by the RoC. Our Company holds a certificate of registration dated June 09, 2016, bearing registration number B-07-00437 issued by the Reserve Bank of India ("RBI") to carry on the activities of a non-banking financial company without accepting public deposits under Section 45 IA of the Reserve Bank of India Act, 1934. For further details about our Company, see "General Information" on page 39 of the Prospectus and "History and Certain Other Corporate Matters" on page 127 of the Prospectus.

Registered Office: Plot No. C308, Door No. 66/40, 4th Avenue, Ashok Nagar, Chennai-600 083, Tamil Nadu, India. Tel: +91 44 4208 2381, 2958 0014; Corporate Office: ICL Fincorp Limited, Main Road, Irinjalakuda, Thrissur - 680121, Kerala, India. Tel: +91 480 267 0400, 282 8071, 283 1305; Corporate Identification Number: U65191TN1991PLC021815; PAN: AAACJ1806C; E-mail: info@iclfincorp.com; Website: www.iclfincorp.com; Company Secretary and Compliance Officer: Visakh T.V. Email: cs@iclfincorp.com; Tel: +91 480 267 0400, 282 8071, 283 1305; Chief Financial Officer: Madhavankutty Thekkedath; Email: cfo@iclfincorp.com; Tel: +91 480 267 0400, 282 8071, 283 1305;

PUBLIC ISSUE OF UP TO 10,00,000 SECURED, REDEEMABLE, NON-CONVERTIBLE DEBENTURES (NCDs) OF FACE VALUE OF ₹1,000 EACH

NOTICE TO INVESTORS

This notice is with reference to the public issue of up to 10,00,000 secured, redeemable, non-convertible debentures of face value of ₹1,000 each, ("NCDs") at par, for an amount up to ₹5,00,00,000 thousand ("Base Issue Size") with an option to retain oversubscription of up to ₹5,00,00,000 thousand aggregating up to ₹10,00,00,000 thousand (the "Issue") by ICL Fincorp Limited ("Company") in accordance with Securities and Exchange Board of India (Issue and Listing of Non-Convertible Securities) Regulations, 2021, as amended (the "SEBI NCS Regulations"), the applicable provisions of the Companies Act, 2013, as amended from time to time, and rules made thereunder the SEBI Circular no. SEBI/HO/DDHS/DDHS-Pd/P/CIR/2025/0000000137 dated October 15, 2025, as amended ("SEBI Master Circular"). The Company has filed prospectus dated July 28, 2026 ("Prospectus") with the Registrar of Companies, Tamil Nadu at Chennai ("RoC"), Securities and Exchange Board of India ("SEBI") and BSE Limited ("BSE") (the "Stock Exchange"). THE ISSUE IS NOT PROPOSED TO BE UNDERWRITTEN.

ISSUE PROGRAMME **ISSUE OPENS - AUGUST 10, 2026 (MONDAY)** **ISSUE CLOSURE - AUGUST 21, 2026 (FRIDAY)***

*The Issue shall remain open for subscription on Working Days from 10:00 a.m. to 5:00 p.m. (Indian Standard Time), during the period indicated in the Prospectus, except that the Issue may close on such earlier date or extended date as may be decided by the Board of Directors of the Company or the Finance and Management Committee, subject to relevant approvals (subject to a minimum period of two working days and a maximum period of ten working days from the date of opening of this Issue).

In the event of an early closure or extension of the Issue, our Company shall ensure that notice of such early closure or extension is given to the prospective investors through an advertisement in a national daily newspaper and a regional daily newspaper in Tamil Nadu where the registered office is located, with wide circulation on or before such earlier date or extended date of closure. Application Forms for the Issue will be accepted only from 10:00 a.m. to 5:00 p.m. (Indian Standard Time) or such extended time as may be permitted by the Stock Exchange, on Working Days during the Issue Period. On the Issue Closing Date, Application Forms will be accepted only between 10:00 a.m. to 3:00 p.m. and uploaded until 5:00 p.m. (Indian Standard Time) or such extended time as may be permitted by the Stock Exchange.

Allotment on "first come first serve basis" #

#As per the SEBI Master Circular, the allotment in this issue is required to be made on the basis of date of upload of each application into the electronic book of the Stock Exchange. For further details refer section titled "Issue Related Information" on page 258 of the Prospectus.

In accordance with the provision of and requirement under Section 30 of the Companies Act, 2013 read with Regulation 30(1) of the SEBI NCS Regulations, the Company has published statutory advertisement dated July 30, 2026 on their website at www.iclfincorp.com on which contains the disclosures as per Schedule V of the SEBI NCS Regulations ("Statutory Advertisement"). The Statutory Advertisement can be viewed through the QR code and web link given below:

<https://www.iclfincorp.com/fileupload/gSAP0X0JLN>


(please scan this QR code to view the detailed advertisement)

Capitalized terms not defined herein shall have the same meaning as assigned to such terms in the Prospectus.

All the potential investors are advised to please provide attention to the above mentioned update and take an informed decision accordingly.

For ICL Fincorp Limited
Sd/-
K.G. Anilkumar
(Chairman & Managing Director) DIN: 00766739

Place: Irinjalakuda
Date : 30/07/2026

**Government of West Bengal**

**Prosperous Farmers, Progressive Bengal**

A landmark initiative of the Government of West Bengal

Additional Subsidy on Agri-Pump Electric Connections

₹2 additional subsidy per unit

provided by the State Government

To reduce the cost of farming and enhance farmers' income, the State Government has decided to provide an additional subsidy of ₹2 per unit on electricity for agricultural pump connections.

How farmers will be benefited?

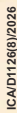
**Lower Irrigation Costs**
Additional subsidy of ₹2 per unit will reduce the cost of irrigation.

**Higher Farm Income**
Lower input costs, better savings and more income.

**Agricultural Growth**
Affordable and dependable electricity will enable productive farming.

**Village Development**
Prosperous farmers, prosperous Bengal.

Affordable Power, Prosperous Farmers, Brighter Future



Empowering Agriculture. Energising Rural Growth.

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Department of Agriculture
Government of West Bengal

Department of Power
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Mango Party For All

AMID THE stand-off between the Treasury Benches and the Opposition in Parliament, a get-together hosted by Congress leader Shashi Tharoor at his official residence in the Capital saw a unique mix of guests on Wednesday. Although rain and the ruckus in the Lok Sabha played a spoiler, Tharoor's 'Mango & Chat Party' saw a decent attendance of MPs from around 15 parties, diplomats from 35 embassies and a cross-section of government officials and mediapersons. The gathering was a mix of political and non-political discussions while relishing a spread of mangoes. The BJP was represented by senior MPs Rajiv Pratap Rudy and Shashank Mani Tripathi. Many Congress MPs could not reach in time because of the developments in the Lok Sabha after Gandhi of Opposition Rahul Gandhi took on the government over the recent police crackdown on protesters at Jantar Mantar. Union Minister Jitendra Singh and BJP MP Tejasi Surya, who were in the House, conveyed their good wishes while regretting their inability to attend the get-together, said sources.

E20 petrol can reduce fuel economy by 2-6%: Gadkari

New Delhi: Petrol blended with 20% ethanol (E20) can reduce fuel economy by 2 to 6% depending on the vehicle category and vintage. Road Transport and Highways Minister Nitin Gadkari informed Parliament on Thursday.

The Union Minister, however, argued that tests for engine durability on a dynamometer and on-road vehicle tests have not shown any failures due to E20.

In a written reply to the Lok Sabha, Gadkari said E20 fuel provides better acceleration, improved ride quality and approximately 30% lower carbon emissions compared to E10 fuel.

"The fuel efficiency of vehicles may be reduced by 2 to 6% depending on the vehicle category and vintage. The tests for engine durability on a dynamometer and vehicle tests on road have not shown any failures due to E20," the minister said. PTI

With CJP stir, Gen Z caught the BJP off guard. Can the Opposition make it count?



MANY AGREE that if the BJP had sent emissaries — even members of the Delhi Government — early on to Jantar Mantar to talk to fasting activist Sonam Wangchuk and the Cuckoo Party (CJP) leaders, who were then holding a sit-in to demand accountability over the NEET exam paper leak, the crisis would not have escalated as it did.

The BJP government misread the Gen Z protests and miscalculated its response to the situation, which has landed it in a spot.

The Monsoon Session of Parliament was supposed to be about a renewed push for the constitutional amendment legislation linked to the Delimitation Bill the Narendra Modi

Amid Opp protests, House clears Bill criminalising insult to Vande Mataram

Centre calls it a 'Bill of national pride'; DMK says it reflects 'communal outlook'

Deeptiman Tiwary
New Delhi, July 30

THE Lok Sabha on Thursday passed the Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Bill, 2026 amid protests by the Opposition over the police "excesses" on protesters at Jantar Mantar and the Ram Temple donation theft row.

The Bill was cleared in about 15 minutes during the post-lunch sitting after repeated adjournments since morning amid the din. Throughout the debate, Congress and Samajwadi Party members continued sloganeering from the Well of the House. The DMK was the only Opposition party to participate in the discussion.

Moving amendments to the Bill, DMK MP A Raju alleged that the Bill reflected a "communal outlook".

"This is a very dangerous day for Parliament and the country. I have carefully gone through the reasons and objects of the Bill... One person and one song [are] important for this country having a communal outlook. Why did Partition

happen? One person... and one song...," he said.

Raju sought to make "a legal point", but the Chair did not allow him to continue and put his amendment to vote, which was defeated.

Joining the debate, DMK MP Kanimozhi alleged that the Bill was a "Hindutva agenda masquerading as nationalism" and accused the government of trying to "impose nationalism through law". She argued that the Constituent Assembly had consciously accepted only the first two stanzas of Vande Mataram and said making all six stanzas mandatory would undermine the country's secular character. Referring to Tamil Nadu's long-standing state song, she said the legislation disrespected states with their own official songs and accused the government of using the issue to polarise the country.

Minister of State for Home Nityanand Rai rejected the criticism, asserting that the legislation was "a Bill of national pride" and was "not against any state, ideology or person". He said the government respected all state



MoS Nityanand Rai (above) and DMK MP A Raju (right) speak in Lok Sabha on Thursday. ANI

songs and insisted that the amendment only sought to ensure that the National Song received the same respect as the National Anthem. Rai also accused India's first Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru of accepting only two stanzas of Vande Mataram in 1937 "for appeasement politics", claiming that the decision encouraged the ideology that eventually led to Partition.

Participating from the Treasury Benches, BJP MP Sambit Patra said the amendment was "not an ordinary Bill" but one

that intended to ensure that people, particularly school students, could express respect for both the National Anthem and the National Song "without any hurdle". He said the president of the Constituent Assembly, Dr Rajendra Prasad, had given an assurance that Jana Gana Mana

and Vande Mataram would enjoy equal respect, but the promise has not been fulfilled over the past 76 years because of the Congress leadership.

Earlier, while introducing the Bill, Rai had described it as "not just a statutory amendment" but "a commitment to India's soul, cultural heritage, national consciousness and the ideals of the freedom struggle". Invoking Vande Mataram composer Bankim Chandra Chatterjee, Swami Vivekananda and Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel, he said Prime Minister Narendra Modi was fulfilling the vision of according Vande Mataram its rightful place in national life. Rai recalled that Patel had asked classical vocalist Omkarnath Thakur to sing the full Vande Mataram on All India Radio on the morning of August 15, 1947, and said freedom fighters, including Chandrashekhar Azad, Ram Prasad Bismil and Ashfaqullah Khan, had gone to the gallows with "Vande Mataram" on their lips.

The Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Bill is the first legislation to be passed by both Houses of Parliament in the ongoing Monsoon Session, which has seen frequent disruptions by the Opposition mainly over the NEET paper leak issue.

Govt on UN Rapporteurs' SIR concern: Due process followed

New Delhi: Almost three months after three United Nations Special Rapporteurs wrote to the government, raising concern over large-scale deletion of electors and alleged discrimination through the SIR, the Union government acknowledged the communication on Thursday, informing the Rajya Sabha that the exercise was "carried out by following the due process of law without prejudice to any group or community". ENS



PM meets President

President Droupadi Murmu with PM Narendra Modi at Rashtrapati Bhavan, Thursday. The meeting comes days after the President returned from a tour of Moldova, North Macedonia and Romania. X/IGRASHTRAPATI BHAVAN

Why govt is holding back key Bills as Parliament logjam continues

Liz Mathew
New Delhi, July 30

WITH THE Opposition intensifying its protests against alleged police excesses against student protesters and the alleged theft of donations at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya, the government appears to be slowing down on its legislative agenda for the moment. The government, insiders said, is waiting for the Opposition to get back to allowing Parliament to function before taking up crucial pieces of legislation.

The Centre on Thursday managed to get the Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Bill, 2026 — also known as the Vande Mataram Bill — passed amid the din in the Lok Sabha. The Bill saw a brief discussion involving only two members: Union Minister of State for Home Nityanand Rai and DMK MP Kanimozhi. While Rai defended the legislation, saying all six stanzas of the song were needed to ensure "Ek Bharat, Shreshtha Bharat (One India, Best India)", Kanimozhi termed it "a Hindutva agenda masquerading as nationalism".

"It is against federalism. You cannot impose nationalism by bringing a law, the song goes against the secularism of the country. The founding fathers had the wisdom to stop only



During the debate on Vande Mataram Bill on Thursday, DMK MP Kanimozhi said it is against federalism, and the song goes 'against secularism'. ANI

with two stanzas, but today you are trying to polarise the country by... making it a criminal offence if we do not sing all the six stanzas," she said.

The government deferred the consideration and passage of the Supreme Court (Number of Judges) Amendment Bill. According to sources, the Bill, which was deferred on the request of the Opposition, is now likely to be taken up in the Lower House on Monday. It proposes to increase the SC's sanctioned strength from 33 to 37 judges.

Many Opposition parties did not want a detailed discussion on the Vande Mataram Bill as the optics of vehemently opposing it could have been politically damaging, while backing it would have hurt their

support base," a BJP leader said. The Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Bill, passed by the Rajya Sabha on Wednesday, makes the intentional disruption of the national song a criminal offence, punishable with up to three years' imprisonment. The Bill has placed several parties, including the Congress and the SP, in a difficult position, with Muslim organisations strongly opposing it.

BJP sources said the Treasury benches are expected to introduce the MSME Development Act, 2006 (Amendment) Bill and the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Amendment Bill next week. "We do not want to rush these Bills. We want the Opposition to discuss crucial pieces of legislation such as the FCRA Bill. That is why the government is taking its time before bringing it up," a BJP leader said.

The FCRA Bill seeks to amend the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act, 2010, which regulates the acceptance and utilisation of foreign contributions and foreign hospitality to "ensure that such inflows do not adversely affect national interest... or national security". The Opposition and minority groups have alleged that the proposed amendments would adversely affect in-

stitutions run by minority communities, including Christians. The proposed amendments to the MSME Development Act seek to introduce mandatory digital invoicing, strengthen safeguards against delayed payments and ensure faster settlement of disputes. The changes are aimed at improving liquidity and reducing the long payment delays that often leave small businesses short of working capital.

Government sources also indicated that repeated adjournments and the loss of working hours could delay the government's plans to take up the 133rd Constitution Amendment Bill, which seeks to increase the number of seats in the Lok Sabha. The Bill is linked to the implementation of the Women's Reservation law and the Delimitation Bill during the ongoing Monsoon Session, scheduled to conclude on August 13.

Two other key legislations — the 130th Constitution Amendment Bill and the Viksit Bharat Shiksha Adhishthan Bill, 2025 — have also been delayed. Senior BJP leader and Lok Sabha Chief Whip Sanjay Jaiswal said the government would be compelled to pass the Bills amid the pandemonium if the Opposition continued its protests.



CJP supporters celebrate Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation, at Jantar Mantar in New Delhi last week. PRAVEEN KHANNA

The ruling camp's biggest miscalculation could be the use of force by the police to bring the protesters to heel, which often turned out to be counter-productive. Buoyed by the BJP's heavy success in West Bengal and the ease with which regional Opposition parties such as the Trinamool Congress (TMC) and the Shiv Sena (UBT) were subsequently split — bringing two-thirds majority in Parliament within striking distance — the

port base and he can ill afford to antagonise them.

The PM eventually decided to let Pradhan go in a bid to end deepening crisis. The BJP brass did not want heated sentiments of Gen Z, who account for about a quarter of the population, to influence the next year's Assembly elections in several states, including UP, Punjab, and Gujarat.

Did the Opposition miss a chance?

While the protests were spearheaded by students, they have given a new heart to an otherwise demoralised Opposition. Any growing discontent against the government is likely to benefit the Congress, the largest Opposition party, more than the regional parties that have weakened lately. The visuals of Rahul Gandhi bleeding from the nose while being dragged by the police from his dharna outside the PM's residence, and of Akhilesh Yadav being similarly whisked away, may have created a resonance in UP and other states. Such moments come rarely

Figuratively, Dubai 15th dist of Kerala, says CPM MP as JDU's Jha claims foreign role in CJP stir

Deeptiman Tiwary
New Delhi, July 30

JDU MP Sanjay Kumar Jha on Thursday alleged foreign involvement in the Jantar Mantar agitation, triggering protests from the Opposition in the Rajya Sabha.

Participating in a discussion on the The Public Examination (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2026, Jha said while the Cuckoo Party protests were underway, he had seen a Malayalam television channel reporting that "some Dubai-based businessmen had secured travel tickets for 25 people and helped them participate in the protests".

"What relation did these people have with NEET? The demand of students and their sentiments are genuine. But it is a matter of investigation as to who were the people who were trying to hijack it," Jha said.

The remarks immediately sparked protests from the Opposition benches, led by MPs from Kerala, who sought to rebut the allegation. The Chair, however, did not permit interventions as Jha was still speaking.

Later, CPI(M) MP A Rahim said this should authenticate his statement about watching a Malayalam channel, arguing that his allegations were not supported by facts. The Chair said it would examine the matter.

CPI(M) member John Brittas argued that those who had travelled from Dubai were Indian citizens and had every right to participate in protests.

"They are citizens of India. Figuratively, Dubai is the 15th district of Kerala. They have every right to come to India and participate in a protest. A wrong message should not go from this House," Brittas said.

Responding to the controversy over Sanjeev Mukhiya, whom the CBI gave a clean chit in the 2024 NEET paper leak case last year, Jha said Mukhiya remained lodged in Buxar jail in



(Top) JDU MP Sanjay Kumar Jha and CPI(M) MP John Brittas in Rajya Sabha on Thursday. ANI

connection with other criminal cases. "There are so many cases against him that there is no possibility of him getting out," he said.

The issue of Mukhiya, who was initially arrested by Bihar Police in the 2024 NEET paper leak case and later taken into custody by the CBI, had been raised earlier in the debate by Leader of the Opposition in the Rajya Sabha Mallikarjun Kharge.

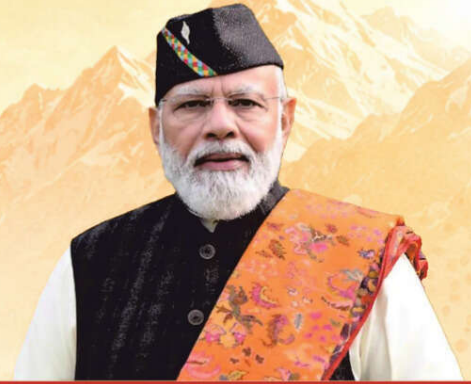
Jha appealed to the members to rise above partisan politics while discussing exam paper leaks. "When a question paper is leaked, it does not merely violate the secrecy of the exam but also erodes the trust in the system... So I request that this issue not be measured on the yardstick of politics. The students are not asking who belongs to which party. She is asking if their hard work is seen and if she will get justice. Parliament has to answer this question," he said. Calling paper leaks a recurring national problem, Jha said: "Paper leak is not a new issue. This is not a question of the failure of a party or government; it is a national challenge. Its solution should be found with a national perspective."



Govt. of Uttarakhand



Devbhoomi
Uttarakhand



“The construction of a developed India in the 21st century rests on two main pillars: first, pride in our heritage, and second, making every possible effort for development. Today, Uttarakhand is continuously strengthening both these pillars. This decade is the decade of Uttarakhand.”

Narendra Modi
Prime Minister

“Hon'ble Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi Ji has called the third decade of the 21st century the decade of Uttarakhand. In line with the Prime Minister's vision, we are working with a 'resolve without alternative' (Vikalp Rahit Sankalp) to make the state an ideal state in every field.”

Pushkar Singh Dhami
Chief Minister, Uttarakhand

**Viksit Bharat
Sashakt Uttarakhand**



Sewa - Sushasan - Samarpan

Employment

- Strict Anti-Copying/Anti-Cheating Law & Transparent Recruitment Process: Selection across multiple departments 33,000 youths given government jobs in the past 5 years.
- Chief Minister Skill Upgradation & Global Employment Scheme: Budget increased from ₹75 lakh to ₹33 crore; foreign language training provided to 147 children, with 92 securing employment abroad.
- Growth in MSME Employment: Number of people employed in MSMEs increased from 3,43,922 in 2022 to 4,56,605 in 2025.
- 10% Horizontal Reservation for Agniveers: Applicable to direct recruitment in Group 'C' uniformed services in government jobs.
- Devbhoomi Entrepreneurship Development Scheme: 300+ students established enterprises, registration of nearly 1,200 students is underway, and employment generated for 1,541 students and others.

Industries

- New Momentum to Development Through Grounding of Investments Worth Over ₹100 Lakh Crore.
- Investment Agreements Worth ₹3.56 Lakh Crore: Signed during the Global Investors Summit.
- Expansion of Land Bank: Over 6,000 acres of additional land bank developed for industries.
- Thriving MSME Sector: Over 96,400 MSME units active across the state.
- Massive Job Creation in MSME: Generated over 4.70 lakh jobs in the MSME sector.
- Flourishing Startup Culture: Over 1,750 startups established in the state.
- National Recognition: Uttarakhand recognized as a "Leader" state in the States' Startup Ecosystem Ranking.
- Large-Scale Industries: 128 large industrial units currently operational in the state.

Education

- Uttarakhand has become the first state in the country to implement the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020.
- Under the PM SHRI Scheme, 141 schools were selected in the first phase and 84 schools in the second phase.
- Virtual classrooms are being operated in 500 Government Secondary Schools across the state.
- The total number of Government and Private Degree Colleges in the state increased to 139 by 2025.
- The total number of Engineering Colleges (Government and Private) in the state increased to 52 by 2025.
- Under the Secondary Education programme, free textbooks are being provided to students of Class I to XII studying in Government and Private schools across the state.

Health

- Construction of the AIIMS Satellite Centre at Kichha is underway, with 85% of the work completed.
- The AIIMS Kichha project includes a 250-bed hospital, 10 Operation Theatres (OTs), 30 ICU beds, advanced Diagnostics & Laboratory facilities, and speciality departments including Cardiology, Nephrology, Urology, Neurology, General Surgery, Orthopaedics, General Medicine, Paediatrics, and an Emergency & Trauma Centre.
- More than 6.1 million Ayushman Cards have been issued across the state under the Atal Ayushman Yojana.
- Under the Atal Ayushman Yojana, more than 1.7 million patients have received cashless treatment worth over ₹3,400 crore.
- 207 types of pathology tests are being provided completely free of cost across the state.
- A target has been set to establish a Medical College in every district. At present, five Medical Colleges are operational, while two more are under construction.
- Super-speciality healthcare services are available at the Medical Colleges in Dehradun, Haldwani, and Srinagar.
- The newly constructed Child and Mother Care Hospital in Haridwar is now operational.

Connectivity

- Inauguration of the 210-km Delhi-Dehradun Economic Corridor, featuring Asia's longest 12-km Wildlife Corridor.
- The Rishikesh-Karnaprayag Rail Project is progressing at a rapid pace.
- The state's road network has expanded to 51,728 km.
- The All Weather Road Project has ensured seamless connectivity to the Char Dham shrines and border areas.
- A new terminal has been developed at Dehradun Airport, with regular flight connectivity to major cities across the country.
- 13 new heliports are currently under construction.
- Construction of the Sonprayag-Kedarnath (12.9 km) and Govindghat-Hemkund Sahib (12.4 km) Ropeway Projects has commenced.

Women Empowerment

- 30% horizontal reservation has been implemented for women in Government jobs across the state.
- 33% reservation for women has been ensured in Co-operative Management Committees.
- Under the Chief Minister Self-Help Group Empowerment Scheme, Self-Help Groups are provided interest-free loans of up to ₹5 lakh.
- Under the Lakhpati Didi Scheme, more than 2.54 lakh women in the state have become Lakhpati Didis.
- Under the Chief Minister Mahalakshmi Kit Scheme, women are provided with essential maternity kits after childbirth.
- Under the Nanda Gaura Scheme, the State Government provides ₹11,000 on the birth of a girl child and ₹51,000 for higher education after she passes Class XII.

Youth Welfare

- Under the New Sports Policy, a historic decision has been taken to provide Government jobs to medal winners at the National and International levels.
- The daily diet allowance for sportspersons has been increased from ₹250 to ₹480 per athlete per day, in line with the Sports Authority of India (SAI).
- Under the Chief Minister Emerging Sportsperson Development Scheme, around 3,900 emerging athletes aged 8 to 14 years are being provided a monthly sports scholarship of ₹1,500.
- Sportspersons who have won medals or represented the country at National and International events such as the Olympic Games, Asian Games, Commonwealth Games, etc., will receive the benefit of the 4% Sports Quota in Government Services.
- 60 Patent Information Centres have been established in various colleges, universities, and other institutions across the state.



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Calcutta HC sets up five fast-track courts for paper leak cases

Tanusree Bose
Kolkata, July 30

THE CALCUTTA High Court on Wednesday designated three fast-track courts in Kolkata and two in the Andaman and Nicobar Islands for question paper leak cases.

They must complete trials in cases registered under the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act 2024 and deliver verdicts within three months of chargesheets being filed.

The development came after Prime Minister Narendra Modi's announcement last week that fast-track courts would be set up to try exam malpractice cases, following the NEET paper leak controversy.

Bench 1 of the Calcutta City Sessions Court has jurisdiction over cases investigated by state government agencies across West Bengal. Court No. 2 of the special CBI court within the City Sessions Court will also

function as a fast-track court for such cases in the state.

The third fast-track court for exam malpractice cases is the court of the First Additional Chief Judicial Magistrate (ACJM) in Kolkata.

The court of the Additional District and Sessions Judge and the court of the Chief Judicial Magistrate, both in Port Blair, will hold fast-track trials in exam malpractice cases registered in the Andaman and Nicobar Islands.

The islands fall under the Calcutta High Court's jurisdiction. The High Court notification specifies that any appeal or revision petition against a fast-track magistrate court's order must be made to the corresponding fast-track sessions courts.

These designated courts will operate independently and have no link to the 88 other fast-track courts in the state.

The Lok Sabha passed an amendment to the 2024 Act on Wednesday. Once the Rajya Sabha also passes it and the President gives his assent, the amendment Bill will become law.

Maharashtra to withdraw FIRs through regular legal process

Mohamed Thaver & Sadaf Modak
Mumbai, July 30

THE MAHARASHTRA government has decided to withdraw FIRs registered against individuals who protested in support of the Cuckooch Janata Party (CJP) over NEET paper leak through the state's existing mechanism for withdrawing and social protests.

It has directed officials to complete the exercise in a "prompt and time bound manner" instead of the six months to one year it usually takes for such withdrawals.

The cases, however, will not be closed immediately. Instead, they will follow the prescribed legal route in which the police will complete the investigation, file chargesheets and thereafter the prosecution will seek permission from the court to withdraw the cases after the proposal clears two government committees.

The cases will be withdrawn as per the procedure laid down in the Government Res-

CJP founder accuses BJP of issuing threats, ruling party denies charge

Pune: Alleging threats from BJP, CJP founder Abhijeet Dipke on Thursday said he was pressured to either join the party or risk being shot dead.

"I have received many offers from them (BJP). But I won't join BJP. If I wanted to join BJP, I would have done it earlier," he said on Wednesday. "I also received threats that it would be better if I join BJP. They asked me to call off the protest, otherwise, 'we will beat you up and shoot you.' This is the very language of love of the Sangh and the BJP."

Dipke said his family was also threatened. "They said 'we will deal with your mother and father. We will visit your home and take care of this'... I asked

them 'You are threatening a 30-year-old youth?.. You should be ashamed of yourself. I mean, what are you doing?' He, however, did not name as to who issued the threats.

Reacting to this, BJP's spokesperson Keshav Upadhye said, "It is completely false that he was threatened to join BJP. He conducted a protest, which he did from his perspective... This doesn't mean anyone gets the right to beat or threaten anyone. We should either reveal his name or not indulge in defaming BJP."

MANOJ MORE

government official said.

Asked whether the government had fixed a deadline, the official said no specific timeline had been set. "We cannot rush through the procedure... every legal requirement has to be met.

But it will be completed as expeditiously as possible," the official said. Another source said the government was conscious that any decision to withdraw the cases could later be challenged in court and, therefore, every procedural requirement had to be followed.

Senior officials said the government had also examined the option of filing closure reports in the FIRs, but found it legally impractical. Closure reports are ordinarily filed when an FIR is found to have been registered due to a mistake of fact, when evidence is insufficient or when the offence remains undetected. "We assessed the available options and decided on the most practical legal course for withdrawing the cases. The DCP was asked to take a decision accordingly," a senior government leader said.

With the procedure now clarified, police are expected to begin probes and file chargesheets in nearly 20 FIRs registered in Mumbai, besides a few others across the state.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Minister in RS: Potential conflict of interest in RDI Fund disbursement

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 30

THE COMMITTEE responsible for selecting companies for receiving money from the newly created Research, Development and Innovation (RDI) Fund had picked at least 15 companies in which members of the committee themselves had a personal stake, according to information provided by the government in Parliament on Thursday.

In a written answer in the Rajya Sabha, Science and Technology Minister Jitendra Singh provided a list of seven members of the committee who had personal stakes in these 15 companies that have been among those chosen for receiving money from the RDI Fund. The RDI Fund is a Rs 1 lakh crore corpus created by the Centre last year to promote research and development activities and innovation in the private sector, particularly in high-priority areas like deep-tech. The fund is meant to provide long-term, low-cost financing to the private sector. The funds are channelled through what are known as second-level fund managers (SLFMs).

These are a few selected organisations which have been empowered to invest in private sector companies in the form of equity, debt or both, using money from the RDI Fund. Current SLFMs include Technology Development Board under the Department of Science and Technology, and Biotechnology Industry Research Assistance

Council under the Department of Biotechnology. Every SLFM is supposed to have an investment committee for assessing and vetting investment proposals from the private sector companies seeking funding from the RDI Fund.

In response to a question by Rajya Sabha member Praveen Chakravarty, Singh gave names of seven members of the Investment Committee of the Technology Development Board who had made investments in at least 15 entities selected for receiving money from the RDI Fund. Singh said that the TDB had a conflict-of-interest policy for members of the investment committee, but did not specify what this policy was, or whether the selection of these companies constituted a violation of the policy. The implementation guidelines for the RDI scheme say that the investment panel "must be constituted in a way that avoids potential conflicts of interest."

It added that the SLFM must take care to ensure that there was no conflict of interest in the choice of specific projects for financing. "Given the likelihood of domain experts on the IC (investment committee) being investors in ideas and companies," it is also not clear if any of the members of the investment panel named in Singh's response in the Rajya Sabha participated in the decision-making process that led to the selection of the company in which they had investments, or they recused themselves in any manner.

Long after these UP mafia dons were killed, their wives remain absconding

Manish Sahu
Lucknow, July 30

LAST WEEK, the Uttar Pradesh Police lodged a fresh criminal case against Raju Ansari, the wife of mafia lord-turned-politician Mukhtar Ansari. He died in Banda jail in March 2024; she has been "absconding" since then.

In that, Afsha has company. The wives of two other known mafia dons of the state are also wanted by the UP Police since the death of their husbands, and have eluded the authorities for even longer. Atiq Ahmed and younger brother Ashraf were gunned down in April 2023 while in police custody and on live TV. Apart from their wives Shaista Parveen and Zainab Fatima, respectively, police have been looking for the brothers' elder sister Ayesha Noori since then.

All four women, who are between the ages of 50 and 60, remain missing despite police announcing cash rewards for information on their whereabouts, including Rs 50,000 each for Shaista and Afsha, and Rs 25,000 each in the case of Zainab and Ayesha. All four are accused essentially of playing a "conspiratorial" role in the offences carried out by the late mafia dons. Police say they are making every effort to track down the women, including pressuring them to surrender.

The latest case in which



Atiq Ahmed's wife Shaista Parveen; Mukhtar Ansari's wife Afsha (R)

Afsha was booked recently to a revolver obtained under an arms licence issued in her name. She faces five other cases, including one under the UP Gangsters and Anti-Social Activities (Prevention) Act, Ghazipur Superintendent of Police Iqbal Raja said, adding her properties have been attached under the Act.

Shaista, Zainab and Noori are wanted for alleged roles in a murder conspiracy. Shaista and Zainab were based in Prayagraj when they went missing while Ayesha was living in Meerut. Afsha is a native of Ghazipur district.

The Ghazipur SP said: "Afsha remains a wanted fugitive and police teams are conducting raids to trace her."

Sources in the UP Police said that after they received intelligence suggesting Afsha could attempt to flee the country, they approached Central agencies, including the CBI and Immigration Department, for lookout notices against her.

The latest case against Afsha

was filed after a police verification report on firearms issued to Ansari, his family members and close associates, based on purchase and sale records. The inquiry found that Afsha held an arms licence in her name, against which a revolver was purchased and later sold and another firearm acquired.

However, the records documenting the purchase and sale of the revolver were found to be missing from the archives of the Ghazipur District Magistrate's office, with police suspecting the records were removed in collusion with the staff. Police said they have not been able to trace the revolver either, and believe papers regarding it were deliberately concealed to facilitate its use by members of the Ansari gang.

Apart from Afsha, the FIR names Brij Narayan Ram and Bhishim Singh Yadav, who worked as record assistants with the DM office. Ram is deceased. Provisions of the Arms Act have also been invoked

against the accused.

Atiq Ahmed's wife, sister and sister-in-law are wanted in connection with the February 2023 killing of a lawyer, Umesh Pal, and his wife, Sandeep Singh, in Prayagraj. The attack had taken place in broad daylight outside Pal's home, with gunmen opening fire and hurling crude bombs.

The Prayagraj Police have also registered cases against the three for failing to appear despite being declared proclaimed offenders.

Ayesha's husband Akhlaq Ahmed, a doctor who used to work at a Community Health Centre in Meerut, is under arrest in the same case, charged with giving shelter to one of the accused in the Umesh Pal murder, Guddu Muslim. Guddu remains missing too. Atiq's two sons, Ali Ahmed and Mohammad Umar, are also in prison.

Incidentally, Guddu along with Sabir, another accused in Umesh Pal's murder, figures among the UP Police's list of 30 most wanted. Both carry a reward of Rs 5 lakh each on their heads. The four women are not on the list, with Deepthi Bahal the only woman featuring on it.

A former college principal, Bahal has been on the run since 2019 and is accused of fraud allegedly amounting to Rs 4,500 crore in a bike taxi venture. She is named in 118 cases lodged across the country.

Modi reviews safety of seafarers, supply chain constraints in extended CCS meet

ENS & PTI
New Delhi, July 30

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi on Thursday discussed with a group of senior ministers the prevailing geo-political situation in West Asia and measures to keep supply chains uninterrupted despite conflicts surrounding the Strait of Hormuz, the Black Sea, the Red Sea, and the Gulf of Aden.

The extended Cabinet Committee on Security (CCS) meeting in Parliament House, chaired by the PM, was attended by permanent members, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh, Home Minister Amit Shah, External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar, and Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman, as well as special invitees, Chemicals and Fertilisers Minister J P Nadda, Commerce Minister Piyush Goyal, Shipping Minister Sarbananda Sonowal and Petroleum Minister Hardeep Pur, official sources said.

"Prime Minister Narendra Modi today chaired a meeting of the Cabinet Committee on Security to review the situation in the context of the ongoing West Asia conflict and measures taken by various Ministries and Departments. This was the 4th special CCS meeting on the issue," a statement issued by the PMO said.

Cabinet Secretary TV Somanathan briefed the CCS about the present geo-political situation and spoke about the initiatives taken to ensure adequate supply of petroleum products, including LNG/LPG and fertilisers, it said. The cabinet Secretary told the CCS that sources

for procurement of LPG have already been diversified and the overall stock and supply positions remain adequate.

Availability of adequate crude oil has enabled Central Public Sector Enterprise (CPSE) refineries to operate at utilisation levels exceeding 100 per cent, ensuring continued production of petrol, diesel and other petroleum products.

Initiatives have also been taken to expand Pipel Natural Gas (PNG) connections, which have resulted in a substantial increase in subscriptions. The government is also facilitating industrial substitution of LPG through expansion of the National Gas Grid, augmentation of LNG import and re-gasification infrastructure, expansion of City Gas Distribution networks, and time-bound pipeline and last-mile connectivity approvals under the Pipeline Infrastructure Order, 2026.

"During the meeting, requirements for the fertilisers for the ensuing Rabi season were assessed, and alternative sources of fertilisers were also discussed. The PM said that all measures taken for ensuring uninterrupted supply of fertilisers," the statement said.

The ministers gave presentations on their respective ministries and steps taken by them to ensure uninterrupted import of all goods, including petroleum, natural gas and fertilisers, they said. The PM is learnt to have given certain directions to the ministers to ensure the safety of Indians, India's economic interests and find ways to clear the supply chain hindrances.

Attacks on Indian seafarers in Black Sea unacceptable: Jaishankar to Ukraine's Sybiha

Divya A
New Delhi, July 30

IN THE wake of a merchant vessel carrying 13 Indian seafarers being stuck near Ukraine's Black Sea coast, and with continuing attacks on cargo ships in Black Sea, killing several Indians, External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar held a conversation with his Ukrainian counterpart Andriy Sybiha and took stock of the situation.

Over the past two weeks, several Indian seafarers have lost their lives in missing after the ships came under attack from both the Russian and Ukrainian sides in Black Sea. Jaishankar conveyed to Sybiha New Delhi's condemnation of such attacks by any side involved in the conflict, calling them unacceptable.

"Glad to connect again with FM Andriy Sybiha of Ukraine, after our respective travels," the minister said, adding, "Dis-



EAM S Jaishankar

cusced attacks on commercial shipping and Indian seafarers in the Black Sea. Such attacks by any party are absolutely unacceptable and India condemns them unequivocally."

Kyiv Thursday said they have pitched for India to play an "active role" in ending its conflict with Russia. In a social media post, the Ukrainian Foreign Minister said he had a "good" conversation with Jaishankar and that he briefed his Indian counterpart about President Volodymyr Zelenskyy's recent visit to Washington DC.

Gurgaon-Jaipur corridor on NH 48 to go barrier-less from tomorrow

Dheeraj Mishra
New Delhi, July 30

FROM AUGUST 1 and commuters will no longer have to stop at any toll plaza to pay user fees while travelling through the Gurgaon-Jaipur corridor of National Highway 48 (NH-48).

The corridor is set to become a completely barrier-less system starting Saturday. Officials said the Multi Lane Free Flow (MLFF) tolling system on Shahjahanpur toll plaza in Rajasthan is likely to go live on August 1. The MLFF is active on



The 270-km section on NH-48 is one of the busiest among all national highways. EXPRESS

Delhi; Gharunda (NH-44 in Haryana); Manoharpur (NH-48 in Rajasthan); and Daulatpura (NH-48 in Rajasthan).

Apart from this, Indian Highways Management Company Ltd (IHMC) — NHA's tolling implementation agency — has awarded the MLFF contract for 12 more sections. These are Barich on NH-48 in Gujarat; Nemli / Sri Perumbudur and Chennasumudram on NH-48 and Parunur on NH-45 in Tamil Nadu; Kasepalli, Amakathodu and Marun on NH-44 in Andhra Pradesh; Chalakudi and Hilarwagaon Pava on NH-50 in Ma-

2018 flood rehabilitation project: Kerala Vigilance drops probe against CM

Shaju Philip
Thiruvananthapuram, July 30

THE KERALA Vigilance and Anti-Corruption Bureau (VACB) has dropped its probe against Chief Minister V D Satheesan in connection with the allegation that he had collected money from abroad in violation of the Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act (FCRA) for a 2018 flood rehabilitation project.

Home Minister Ramesh Chennithala said VACB has wound up its probe as there is no proof against Satheesan. "The VACB has taken the decision to close the case that the previous LDF government had registered against him. The allegation was that he had travelled to the UK and raised funds for the project (called Punarnani, which was conceived to rehabilitate flood-affected people in Satheesan's constituency, Paravur)," he said.

"The probe has found that funds were handled by the Manappatt Foundation (the corporate social responsibility wing of the



Kerala CM V D Satheesan

Dubai-based Manappatt Group) and their FCRA account. Probe revealed that Satheesan played no role in it. Hence, the case registered against Satheesan under section 7 (a) of the PCA, was dropped," Chennithala said.

He said the previous CPI(M) government's decision to hand over the case to the CBI was politically motivated. "After that, the VACB director had examined the files and recommended that the matter should not be taken ahead. This clean chit to Satheesan is not because of the change in the government," the Home Minister said. The VACB probe started in 2023, while Satheesan was serving as the LoP in the Assembly.

ISRO & Japanese scientists review mission Chandrayaan-5 preparation

Anjali Marar
Bangalore, July 30

A JAPANESE space delegation on Wednesday held discussions with their counterparts at Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) to take stock of the progress being made in the preparation for the joint mission to the Moon scheduled for 2028.

Scientists from Japan's Aerospace Exploration Agency (JAXA) visited the UR Rao Satellite Centre in Bangalore on Wednesday. The two countries have been working on Chandrayaan-5 also known as Lunar Polar Exploration Mission (LUPEX), a first-of-its-kind joint rover mission to the Moon. For this project, ISRO is building the lander module, while JAXA is developing the rover, the one which will come out of the lander module after landing and move around on the surface of the Moon, surveying the topography and collecting data.

The mission will take off on a Japanese rocket, H3, and is planned to carry seven scientific instruments for carrying out different kinds of experiments. The

Gaganyaan-1 in progress

Bengaluru: The assembly, integration and testing of the Crew and Service Modules of the Gaganyaan-1 human spaceflight mission are nearing completion. Science and Technology Minister Jitendra Singh said in a written reply in Lok Sabha on Wednesday. He detailed the mission's status, and completed tasks in his reply to Jaipur MP Rao Rajendra Singh.

Gaganyaan-1 underwent mission tests originally scheduled for launch in late 2025. It was later pushed to the first quarter of 2026. Singh had, during the Winter Session of House, 2025, said that the G-1 launch would take place before March 2026. But, ISRO is yet to release the revised launch date. ENS

National Aeronautics and Space Administration (NASA) of the US and the European Space Agency (ESA) are also participating in this mission, and will be mounting their payloads on the rover. The ESA is developing the

mass spectrometer and NASA is developing the neutron spectrometers. Chandrayaan-5 is planned to stay on the Moon for 100 days i.e. 3 and five months.

During their Wednesday meeting, scientists of ISRO and JAXA discussed the technical co-ordination required for inter spacecraft communication of Chandrayaan-5. This mission aims to study water and water-ice both on the lunar surface and the subsurface.

The two agencies took stock of the on-board payloads and on the possible launch window, which is likely to be in 2028. Last week, JAXA successfully performed the second Payload Operations Simulation at Tsukuba Space Center. The complex operational scenario, involving both spacecraft bus and payload operations, were tested in parallel.

Chandrayaan-5 was approved by the Government in March 2025 in the backdrop of India's landing on the lunar south pole with the Chandrayaan-3 mission in August 2023. ISRO's immediate next mission to the moon will be the Chandrayaan-4 mission.

ISRO's NavIC system can no longer provide navigation data independently: Govt

Annona Dutt
New Delhi, July 30

FOR THE first time since positioning data from one of its satellites was lost in March, the government has accepted in the parliament that the seven-satellite navigation constellation (NavIC) can no longer independently aid people in navigation.

The Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) earlier this year informed that IRNSS-1F satellite, which was launched in March 2016, completed its designed mission life of 10 years and the on-board atomic clock stopped functioning.

"...presently the NavIC constellation has three satellites for providing PNT (Positioning, Navigation, Timing) services: IRNSS-1B, IRNSS-1I and NVS-01. To provide basic positioning service, minimum four operational satellites are required in orbit. Hence, the NavIC constellation cannot provide standalone positioning service, however time-based service is available," the minister of state for space Dr. Jitendra Singh replied in a written answer in Parliament.

The reply said that the armed forces continue to use NavIC signals as part of the multi-constellation GNSS — Global Navigation Satellite System using data from US GPS, EU's Galileo, and Russia's Glonass among others to navigate.

When asked whether it compromises accuracy for navigation or real-time mapping, the reply stated: "Since NavIC is being used in multi-constellation environment for most of the use-cases, there is no vulnerability for the users."

While end-user applications were developed for utilising NavIC signals in aviation, shipping, railways, and even in everyday cell phones, all of these devices carry a GNSS receiver, meaning they can continue to get positioning data from other constellations.

The reply also stated: "Next NavIC satellite NVS-03 is ready for launch and two more satellites NVS-04 and NVS-05 are in advanced stage of realisation."

The constellation can still provide accurate time signals for digital devices as well as broadcast emergency messages.

The Indian Regional Navigation Satellite System (IRNSS) — also referred to as the operational name of Navigation with Indian Constellation (NavIC) — was planned to be a seven-satellite system to provide positioning data over the Indian subcontinent and 1500 km around it. Ever since its inception, however, it has been plagued by problems affecting its positioning data.

Low turnout, high stakes: B.P faces Bankipur battle

Santosh Singh
Patna, July 30

A GOVERNMENT servant who cast her vote at a thinly attended polling booth in Patna on Friday for the Bankipur by-poll refused to reveal her preference but observed with a tone of resignation: "Sab ke aankhon par BJP ki patthi padhi hai. Everyone is wearing BJP blindfolds."

Yet, just a few kilometres away, a voter was heard repeating "Jai Jan Suraj, Jai Prashant" as he entered a booth in a locality with a substantial Muslim population.

As voters trickled into polling booths on voting day for the Bankipur by-poll in Bihar, with turnout at 34.2% as of 8.30 pm, all three key contenders — the BJP's Neeraj Kumar Sinha, Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD)'s Rekha Gupta, and Jan Suraj Party's (JSP) Prashant Kishor — were seen justifying their presence.

Among them, Kishor appeared the most active in the high-profile constituency vacated by BJP national president Nitin Nambh on his elevation to the Rajya Sabha.

Following a heated argument on Wednesday evening



People arrive at a polling station during the Bankipur by-election on Thursday. RAHUL SHARMA

with Jankapur police station in-charged Rituraj Kumar Singh over the undisclosed location of two detained JSP workers, Kishor successfully pressed polling officials to rectify a malfunctioning electronic voting machine (EVM) at Daddai, near Daryapur Gola, on Thursday morning.

Reacting to the clashes, Kishor told the Jankapur police, "Either tell us the location of our two detained workers or be ready to lose your job."

The Jankapur SHO subsequently accused Kishor of "threatening a police officer inside a police station".

side a police station".

Tensions also flared between supporters of the JSP and BJP workers — the latter led by Abhishek Bunt, who was forced to opt out of the by-poll and replaced by Sinha — clashed in S.K. Nagar.

In another incident near a polling booth in Anandpur, former M.A. and JSP leader Kishore Kumar Munna was shoved by BJP workers following a heated exchange.

The BJP has won the Bankipur seat in consecutive elections since 1995.

Appoint Polar Ambassador, join Arctic Council, suggests panel

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 30

THE PARLIAMENTARY committee on External Affairs in its report has recommended that India should appoint a Polar Ambassador and urged the government to seek "full-fledged membership" of the Arctic Council so that India can engage in its activities more effectively.

India is currently one of the 13 observer countries of the Arctic Council, whose full membership is restricted to nations that have landmass in the region. The observer countries do not have decision making powers. They also can't make financial contributions or undertake research in the Arctic directly.

The committee, in its recommendations said: "...it is imperative that India also has such an Ambassador at a level equivalent to other countries exclusively to deal with polar regions. Creating such a position will not only help India project the importance given to these regions in its foreign policy architecture but will also help India to assert its policy stance in relation to polar regions or pursue polar diplomacy in a more effective manner."

With several Russian research activities in the Arctic region having been paused following the conflict with Ukraine, the committee recommended that India through its diplomatic channels inform Russia upon the seven other countries of the need for having Russia on-board for the scientific work in the region which is experiencing drastic climate change — the impact of which will be felt across the globe. The committee also recommended that government explore the possibility of accessing the Russian Arctic Research Stations.

Govt to House panel: Hasina not allowed to conduct political activities from India

Divya A
New Delhi, July 30

IN THE wake of former Bangladesh Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina's recent remarks that she might return to Bangladesh by the end of this year, the government has told a Parliamentary panel that the former Bangladesh PM is not permitted to conduct political activities from India.

On Thursday, Bangladesh Law Minister M Asaduzzaman said that Hasina is likely to be arrested instantly on her return from India.

Meanwhile, the Ministry of External Affairs told the panel, "The extradition request (sent by Dhaka for Hasina) is being examined by the competent authorities of the Government of India in accordance with applicable law and established procedures."

The Committee — led by Congress MP Shashi Tharoor — noted that Hasina's stay and India's approach in this regard is guided by "its civilisational ethos and humanitarian tradition of offering refuge to individuals facing circumstances of grave distress or existential threat."

The panel noted that while extending such humanitarian consideration, India has strictly adhered to the principle that no political activity is directed against any other country from our territory.

In its latest report on the 'Future of India-Bangladesh Relationship', the Committee recommended that "the government should continue to uphold its principled and humanitarian approach... while ensuring that such situations are managed with due sensitivity".



Former Bangladesh PM Sheikh Hasina

The parliamentary committee also sought an early normalisation of visa processing for Bangladeshis nationals, expressing concern that reduced visa processing volumes for Bangladeshis nationals harm public perception and bilateral ties. India resumed tourist visa services for Bangladeshi nationals on June 28, 2026, ending a two-year suspension that began in July 2024 following political unrest and security concerns.

With the Ganga Water Treaty of 1996 between India and Bangladesh set to expire this year, the panel has urged the government to initiate discussions with Dhaka "without further delay".

Noting that the treaty is set to expire in 2026 and that bilateral discussions on its renewal had not yet commenced, the committee has recommended early initiation of renewal discussions, guided by updated hydrological data and climate change projections, and in consultation with the state governments of West Bengal and Bihar, the report said.

The committee also recommended that the MEA should continue to prioritise the protection of minorities in Bangladesh as a core element of its diplomatic engagement.

Amid demolition probe, Gujarat HC asks why Surat civic chief remains in post

Aditi Raja
Vadodra, July 30

THE GUJARAT High Court on Thursday orally questioned how the Surat Municipal Corporation commissioner could continue in office while a state-level inquiry into the controversial Nasir Nagar demolition is underway, observing that Gujarat's state, even as the state informed the court that two officers "best officers in municipal administration" had been appointed to conduct the probe.

Hearing the petition filed by 26 residents of Nasir Nagar, Justice Nikhil Kariel repeatedly expressed concern over the government's decision to allow the Municipal Commissioner to remain in the same position while the inquiry is underway. The court orally observed while it appreciated the State's seriousness in constituting an inquiry, the message being sent out was that senior officers "cannot be touched".

On May 30, the Surat Municipal Corporation demolished around 100 shanties, and in Nasir Nagar allegedly encroaching on private land in the Ved Road area, displacing as many families. Twenty-six affected residents have challenged the action before the High Court, seeking accountability and rehabilitation.

Authorities on 'high alert' as floods wreak havoc in north Odisha

Sujit Bisoyi
Bhubaneswar, July 30

OVER SEVEN lakh people have been affected as floods triggered by heavy rainfall wreak havoc in several north Odisha districts.

Officials said the situation continues to be grim in Bhubaneswar, Balasore and Jajpur, with the administration on its toes to manage the crisis. Authorities said nearly two lakh people are being evacuated.

Revenue and Disaster Management Minister Suresh Pujari said that although water levels are receding in several north Odisha districts, many rivers are still flowing above the danger mark. The state government has said the situation is under control. But with the floods causing widespread damage, it is also preparing to pay what Pujari described as "adequate compensation" to those affected.

Meanwhile, while the Mahanadi silt in state, the prospect of a medium-range flood looms over districts such as Puri, Cuttack, Jagatsinghpur, Kendra-

'How are you keeping unelected minister?' SC asks Bihar govt

Ananthakrishnan G
New Delhi, July 30

THE SUPREME Court on Thursday questioned how the Bihar government could retain a minister who has remained unelected in Bihar for more than a year, even though the constitutional limit and asked the state to explain its position.

A three-judge bench, presided over by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, was hearing a request to fix a date for hearing a plea challenging the appointment of Deepak Prakash as Panchayati Raj Minister in Bihar for more than a year without having been elected as an Assembly member. "It is a pure legal issue. How are you retaining a minister beyond 6 months when he is not elected?" CJ Kant asked the counsel appearing for the Bihar Government.

Article 164(4) allows a non-member to remain minister for six months, subject to getting elected as a member within that period. The counsel appearing for Rakesh Kumar Singh, a petitioner from Bihar, said that when the matter came up for hearing on July 15, the state sought time, stating it wanted to file a counter-affidavit but had not done so yet.

"Seven months and 22 days have passed, and he is still continuing as the minister," he said. CJ Kant said that whether the state files a counter or not, the court will not give any more time.

time. The court fixed the next hearing date for August 4.

Deepak Prakash, the son of Rashtriya Lok Morcha (RLM) leader Upendra Kushwaha, was made Minister of Panchayati Raj on November 20, 2025, in the NDA government. However, even though he was not a member of the Bihar Legislative Assembly or the Legislative Council. However, after a fresh council of ministers was constituted following Kumar's exit, and Samrat Choudhary became the Chief Minister, Prakash was once again made Panchayati Raj Minister on May 7, 2026.

Singh, the petitioner, has argued that it was a one-time opportunity and cannot be utilised every time there is a change of government. He had to get re-elected between November 20, 2025, when he first sworn in, and May 20, 2026, the plea pointed out. Singh contended that the re-appointment was in circumvention of constitutional safeguards and undermines representative democracy. He argued that it undermines the principles of parliamentary democracy, representative government, collective responsibility and electoral accountability.

The plea urged the Supreme Court to declare Prakash's re-appointment and continuance in office unconstitutional, illegal, and void, and to restrain him from exercising the powers vested in the ministerial office.

Insurer not liable to pay compensation for accident if driver's licence is invalid: SC

Press Trust of India
New Delhi, July 30

INSURANCE COMPANIES are not liable to pay compensation for accidents if the driver's licence was not valid or not renewed at the time of the incident, the Supreme Court on Thursday said and urged the Centre to undertake awareness campaigns to emphasize the importance of valid driving licences and streamline the process of issuance and renewal.

"The Ministry of Road, Transport and Highways, Government of India, as also the respective counterparts of the states should, we may suggest, undertake campaigns through all mediums such as awareness drives, social media, etc. to drive home this importance; introduce measures to ensure strict compliance; and also streamline the process of issuance/renewal of licences. Other issues such as regulation of driving schools, the affordability thereof, and accessibility in terms of regional languages, when it comes to applications and tests, etc. also need urgent attention," observed a bench of Justices Sanjay Karol and N K Jaiswar.

The bench said that an insurance company could not be saddled with the liability if the offending vehicle was driven without a valid driving licence.

The top court made the observation while setting aside a Punjab and Haryana HC order that had fastened liability on the insurer. The matter arose from a 2009 accident where a vehicle driven by Om Parkash hit a two-wheeler. The Motor Accidents Claim Tribunal originally held that the insurer, Reliance General Insurance Co Ltd., was not liable because the driver's licence had expired.

However, the HC reversed this, accepting a letter from a licensing authority which claimed that licence records for the period between 2007 and 2010 were "lost" due to a technical error during a data transfer between IT companies. The HC ordered the insurer to pay a revised compensation of over Rs 1.08 crore. The SC scrutinised the evidence and found the high court's reliance on the "missing data" theory to be flawed. While the court absolved the insurance company of financial liability, it protected the claimants.

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Extract of Consolidated Financial Results for the Quarter ended June 30, 2026

Particulars	Quarter Ended June 30, 2026		Year Ended March 31, 2026		Quarter Ended June 30, 2025	
	Unaudited	Audited	Unaudited	Audited	Unaudited	Audited
Total income from operations	4921	13980			3178	
Net profit / (loss) for the period before tax and exceptional items	754	2961			738	
Net profit / (loss) for the period before tax and after exceptional items	733	2872			738	
Net profit / (loss) for the period after tax and exceptional items	566	2138			548	
Total comprehensive income	645	1958			546	
Paid up equity share capital	169.23	169.23			169.23	
Other equity excluding revaluation reserve		8220				
Earnings per share (Face value of ₹5 each) (Not annualised):						
Basic (in ₹)	14.87	63.92			16.19	
Diluted (in ₹)	14.87	63.92			16.19	

Notes:
1 Summary details of standalone financial results of Torrent Pharmaceuticals Limited:

Particulars	Quarter Ended June 30, 2026		Year Ended March 31, 2026		Quarter Ended June 30, 2025	
	Unaudited	Audited, Restated	Unaudited	Audited	Unaudited	Audited
Total income from operations	4158	11422			2616	
Profit before tax	663	2721			742	
Profit after tax	492	2034			551	
Total comprehensive income	559	1889			524	

2 The above is an extract of the detailed form of Financial Results for the quarter ended June 30, 2026 filed with Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format of the same, along with the notes, are available on www.nsdlindia.com and on the Company's website (URL: www.torrentpharma.com/investors/financial-information/quarterly-results/). The same can be accessed by scanning the QR code provided below.

For TORRENT PHARMACEUTICALS LIMITED

Place : Ahmedabad, Gujarat
Date : July 30, 2026

AMAN MEHTA
Managing Director
DIN: 08174906



The Indian EXPRESS

—FOUNDED BY—

RAMNATH GOENKA

IN 1932

BECAUSE THE TRUTH
INVOLVES US ALL

SC strikes balance on ecology, public interest

INDIA'S ENVIRONMENTAL Impact Assessment is grounded in the precautionary principle — it prioritises the integrity of ecosystems over minimising harm or compensating for damage later. From 2017, the government has tried to dilute this safeguard by allowing developers to violate the ecological clearance after commencing a project. A notification issued that year provided a one-time window to defaulters to comply with due procedures. It inaugurated a regime of post-facto clearances, which was consolidated in 2021 when the Centre issued an Order Memorandum (OM) to regularise violations. On Wednesday, the Supreme Court said this OM and closed the door on blanket regularisation of projects that have not complied with environmental safeguards. However, the Court also departed from its May 2025 position that prohibited ex-post facto environmental clearances “in any form”. Instead, it held that a “narrowly tailored amnesty scheme” may be permissible where it is justified by “public interest”.

The judgment is significant because it clarifies the Court's own position on post-facto environmental clearances. In its 2020 decision in *Alembic Pharmaceuticals Ltd v Rohit Prajapati*, the SC held that retrospective clearances are contrary to the philosophy of environmental regulation. The May 2025 verdict reiterated that such retrospective developments violate the law, the first and seek regularisation later. However, the Court appeared to move in the opposite direction six months later. Following review petitions filed by the Centre and industry bodies, a three-judge bench recalled the May 2025 judgment.

Wednesday's verdict now places the onus on the government to make a reasoned selection of projects that may be excused from the requirement of environmental clearance. The Court's insistence on proportionality is consistent with the broader trajectory of environmental jurisprudence in India. For more than two decades, the SC has interpreted constitutional provisions expansively to affirm that a healthy environment is intrinsic to the right to life. In the same vein, it has now required the state to demonstrate that the public interest served by a project is sufficiently compelling, that any relaxation is strictly necessary, and that the environmental costs have been weighed against the anticipated public benefits. The verdict thus transforms what had become an open-ended administrative discretion under the post-2017 regime into a narrowly circumscribed constitutional exception. The flexibility recognised by the Court could prove valuable in cases involving national defence, when healthcare facilities are urgently needed in underserved areas, or highway projects become imperative to improve connectivity in remote regions. However, at a time of climate change and accelerating ecological degradation, the government, too, must recognise that environmental protection is an integral component of public interest.

On Vande Mataram, a law in search of a crime

PARLIAMENT PASSED the Prevention of Insults to National Honour Act on December 23, 1971. Barely a generation removed from colonial rule, India since the late 1960s bore signs of erosion of its early idealism. The victory against Pakistan in the Bangladesh War earlier that month had provided a moment of national triumph. The law, which purportedly sought to give legal backing to a Directive Principle of State Policy, criminalised insults to the national anthem, flag and Constitution. Then as now, however, it is likely that few believed that respect and reverence can be enforced through punitive legislation. The law was meant, arguably, to capture a political moment and give expression to it. Now, the Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Bill, 2026 — passed in Parliament this week — makes an “insult” to the national song punishable by up to three years' imprisonment, placing ‘Vande Mataram’ at par with the national anthem. In essence, it is a law in search of a crime. At best, it is superfluous and at worst, a blunt instrument in the hands of an overzealous prosecutorial machinery.

According to data from the National Records Bureau, there were 1,102 arrests under the 1971 Act between 2014 and 2024, with just 60 convictions. Acquittals outpaced convictions each year, and an average of 48 cases were pending investigation and 221 cases pending trial in the same period. The rate of “crimes against national symbols” per lakh population is extremely low. By all accounts, then, the amended law expands the ambit of criminality with little justification. In the current context, too, the government frequently invites accusations of weaponising the criminal justice system to target opponents. The 2026 Amendment can only deepen apprehensions of its misuse.

In the Budget Session, the Union government tabled, and Parliament passed, the Jan Vishwas (Amendment of Provisions) Bill, 2026. It built on the 2023 Jan Vishwas Act by decriminalising and removing several economic offences. That legislative scheme indicated the government's commitment to its slogan of “minimum government, maximum governance”, especially welcome, given that the state is a litigant in over half the pending cases in India's overburdened courts. In letter and spirit, the ‘Vande Mataram’ law is a backsliding on that commitment.

Numbers don't capture Ajinkya Rahane

AJINKYA RAHANE retired from international cricket on Thursday, signing off as “Cap 278”. He leaves with 85 Tests, 90 ODIs, 20 T20Is and more than 8,000 international runs. The numbers do him injustice.

There was a stretch, deep into the last decade, when Rahane's batting belonged in the company of Virat Kohli, Joe Root, Kane Williamson. MS Dhoni once said his gift was “the timing, and his ability to exploit gaps in the field”. He never built the mountain of runs that talent seemed to promise, and that gap, between what he could do and what he actually left behind, is the real story of his career. Perhaps the reassurance he sought from team management never quite came, and he felt the pressure to hold his place during Kohli's reign as captain.

Handed the captaincy in Australia after the ignominy of 36 all out at Adelaide in December 2020, Rahane walked out of the MCG and made a century that turned the series. India went on to win it 2-1, one of the great away triumphs in the game's history. It should have been the beginning of something larger. Instead, he was stripped of the vice-captaincy within a year, and out of the side not long after, returning only once more, for the 2023 World Test Championship final at The Oval. Rahane leaves as he played: Understated, gifted, and never quite paid in full for either.

Neither government nor Opposition can look youth in the eye on education

ONE DOES NOT need social scientists to explain the meaning and significance of what happened on July 20. It was a protest alright, but it was also an outburst. It is apparent that the government yielded to that pressure with poignance. This was exemplified by the “welcome” accorded to the minister who had resigned. That act of showing contempt for the protests fits into a pattern — while the government buckled under pressure, the pro-BJP ecosystem has been busy spreading all kinds of explanations for the outburst, conspiracy and “foreign hand” included.

Whether the Cockerroach Janta Party is a tool for someone, whether some parties sought to hijack the agitation, or whether the Prime Minister's midnight message on Instagram hit record views are irrelevant tidbits worthy of corner columns in newspapers. The real — and admittedly intriguing — aspect of the BJP protests has been the unexpected and unanticipated spontaneity, right from the first post by Abhishek Dipke about cockroaches. Instead of examining this aspect, the government seems content with either damage control or talking of the spurious issue of “intelligence failure”. When you mute all voices, except those reflecting narcissistic praise, intelligence failures are bound to happen.

Besides, on the watch of the current regime, there is a clear lack of reliable empirical data on what people think. This is for two reasons: Methodologically, when public opinion is permeated by extreme toxicity and pressure of social desirability bias, data

from public opinion studies can be somewhat distorted. And secondly, this regime has been anti-data and has ensured that no independent actors will be able to collect public opinion. Post 2014, there is a singular lack of data leading to the “all is well” cacophony of the parties.

No wonder everyone was taken unaware by the extent and intensity expressed during the CJP protests. While pro-government media is still circulating news about the alleged misbehaviour of participants and the weight of the waste left behind, they are oblivious to the real weight in political terms that these protests have left behind for politicians to tackle. Unfortunately, the regime seems to be unwilling to even read these signals properly.

Three issues are flagged by the protests that engulfed politics over the past four or five weeks. For starters, they were pegged around the NEET and exam-leaks, but by no means were they just about that. The government, sheepishly and wrongly, responded to only the technology of conducting the exam. Even before the protests erupted, this intellectual bankruptcy was evident in deploying the Air Force for delivering exam papers. That same mentality has surfaced again in the appointment of the committee to ensure leak-proof exams.

Yes, we have made a mess of exams, but that is not merely because greed and deceit led to paper leaks. The real elephant in the room is the education system



SUHASH PALSHIKAR

itself. A meaningless system that merely works as boring time-pass or as creches for young adults is the root cause — this malady leads to a senseless premium on exam results, meaningless exams and the coaching industry. Neither the government nor the Opposition can look youth in the eye and explain the meaning of wasting years in the name of education. The latest protests are symptomatic of that larger malaise.

Secondly, the protests and the striking energy they displayed represent the utter meaninglessness of life that confronts the youth. This is not merely about employability but about a future that holds only uncertainty. It would be foolhardy to respond to this issue only by throwing numbers — that so many jobs will be created when a corporate house is granted some largesse by the government. Overall life conditions and the deeper inequalities that characterise Indian society are factors that shape the clouds of uncertainty. If at one stage, capitalism was accused of producing the lumpen element, the economy today produces what sociologists have described as the “precariat”.

Life is precarious, irrespective of whether you belong to low-income groups or the so-called middle class. This government has discovered a politically advantageous palliative to that — to use the evocative phrase employed by the Prime Minister himself, the *revdis*. But the loss of dignity involved in *revdi* politics and the

continued uncertainty of life would surely push large sections into dissatisfaction notwithstanding the heavy rainfall of *revdis*. The CJP protests may not have touched upon these larger aspects of social unrest. But it would be at our own collective peril to ignore these underlying frustrations that are not easily defined. The protests are over for the time being, but these conditions remain and, if not attended to, they are bound to produce more cockroaches than the system can afford to suppress.

Finally, the police action. It represents the political response and tells us what ails our politics. It is not sufficient to smugly say that all protests face some police excesses. Large numbers of handsets on social media have been gleefully telling us that the police have video recordings and participating persons will be hounded. This threat — most likely backed by clandestine police follow-up — tells us what is wrong with politics. By invoking election victories, the victors claim carte blanche; by counting votes, politicians decide citizens of agency; by throwing legislative majorities in our face, governments duck both constitutional morality and routine democratic accountability.

In sum, the prelude, the actual protests and now their aftermath tell a monstrosity — protests have wasted many minds but not our political leadership. Because the regime is bent on not learning anything from the protests except the technology to suppress the next round of protests.

The writer, based in Pune, taught Political Science

For renewable energy answers, ask the right questions



SANJIV SAHAI

INDIA'S RENEWABLE energy sector is facing institutional challenges that need flexible solutions. Propelled by falling solar module prices and government policy, solar capacity has expanded to 162 GW by June 2026. Yet at the very moment this transformation demands smarter, more flexible market products, India's regulator is moving the opposite way, proposing to hand control of the power exchanges to Grid-India, a government utility whose institutional DNA is built for managing transmission systems, not commercial decisions.

Between May and December last year, over two billion units of solar electricity, enough to power several million homes, were curtailed because the grid could not absorb them. The solution requires transmission investment to convey electricity, flexible power plants that can ramp quickly, battery storage to absorb excess generation and discharge during lean hours, and above all, well-designed electricity markets that send the right price signals to the right players at the right time.

Surplus generation in one region can be traded to regions facing shortage. A robust, functional electricity market, one with products that sellers and buyers want, is essential to manage this. Prices should fall when power is abundant at noon and rise when it is scarce in the evening, attracting whatever flexible generation or storage can respond. Good market-design is that keeps a complex, renewable-heavy grid balanced without wasting energy or overloading equipment.

The real danger is not IEX's market share but what happens to market innovation once a government-owned entity controls the central clearing algorithm

Contrary to this need, in July 2025 and January 2026, CERC proposed that Grid-India become Market Coupling Operator (MCO), pooling bids from all three exchanges — IEX, PXIL and HPPX — into a single clearing algorithm that would provide a uniform national price. The stated logic is that the market is fragmented and consumers are losing out. What does the data say?

Most electricity is traded in the Day-Ahead Market (DAM) and Real-Time Market (RTM), both short-term spot products. IEX handles roughly 80-85 per cent of trading volumes which is hardly a fragmented market. CERC's own shadow pilot recorded a welfare improvement of just 0.3 per cent over four months; a longer da-

taset puts the gain at only 0.013 per cent.

Behind CERC's stated reasons lies the question of IEX's dominance. But dominance is not the same as abuse: There is no documented allegation of excessive fees, discriminatory access, predatory pricing, or manipulation of price discovery against IEX. So which problem is CERC actually solving?

The real danger is not IEX's market share but what happens to market innovation once a government-owned entity controls the central clearing algorithm. For example, when exchanges developed user-defined hourly contracts in the Term-Ahead Market, matched to the variable generation profile of solar and wind assets, CERC ordered them discontinued within a week in April last year. In July 2025, CERC suggested a round-robin model under which exchanges would take turns as Market Coupling Operators month to month. By April 2026, its draft second amendment regulations abandoned this in favour of Grid-India as sole MCO. Grid-India itself, in a submission dated June 6, has urged CERC to reconsider and has asked for a round-robin system, institutional ring-fencing and a steering committee to guard against single-point failures, even though round-robin approach would force every exchange to duplicate the capital cost of a central algorithm and add to the regulator's oversight burden.

Grid-India's preference for administrative simplicity is rational for a system operator. Its job is to balance the grid in real time, not to compete for customers or bear commercial risk. But under full coupling, every new trading product will require rewriting an algorithm Grid-India controls, tethering market innovation to the pace of a public utility — a pace the TAM episode shows is slow and tilted towards uniformity.

India's renewable sector needs a market architecture that rewards flexible capacity with real-time pricing, opens competitive markets for frequency-regulation services, and lets storage investors price their business case. These are the real regulatory priorities rather than imagined problems of market dominance.

The writer is former secretary, Ministry of Power



ARUN KUMAR

POPULAR MOVEMENTS often produce popular leaders. They rarely produce worker-intellectuals. Yet, what struck the media, among the many stories of courage of the Cockerroach Janata Party-led protest, was the “unthinkable” intellect of Mohammad Irfan. I call it “unthinkable” because the media could not place Irfan in familiar categories of intellect. Despite claiming to have no social-media accounts, Irfan is a social-media sensation. It is the paradox and contradictions of his life that intrigue the media.

Irfan may be illiterate in a conventional sense, but he is digitally literate. He cites the poems of Ahmad Faraz and invokes historical figures from Raja Rammohan Roy to Jyotiiba Phule in his speech. He is a slum-dweller but speaks of civilisation. How could a semi-literate person who cannot write, a slum-dweller who sells ice to survive, be so articulate on politics, society, and history?

If we turn the pages of history, Irfan is not alone. He is preceded and accompanied by many who are like him. It is just that we have undervalued manual labour and those who do it. We see manual workers through the essential lens of labour and their labouring identity. Can they labour and be intellectual? These paradoxes and inversions are the subject of my forthcoming book, *The Silent Rebellion*, which traces the history of worker-intellectuals in India during the colonial period. It tells the history of labouring people who refused to see themselves as merely labourers or workers and discovered aspects of their lives that transitioned them to become poets, thinkers, and writers of their struggles and poverty. A lot has changed since then. India has implemented compulsory education and welfare labour laws; lower classes have accessed higher education; significant socio-economic mobility has enabled the rise of Bahujan intellectuals. Yet, the broader attitudes that could place Irfan in a narrative social order are missing. He emerges as an exception. Why so?

He is an exception because all platforms are open to the public in theory but we still see “intellect” from a closed perspective. Intellect belongs to certain “kinds” of people — those who attend private educational institutions, inherit cultural capital, and come from certain socio-economic backgrounds. We have created artificial divides between those who labour and those with bookish knowledge, and effectively closed the channels of communication across them. Irfan breaches these walls and moves between the two. It is this movement and dialectic that makes his speech powerful.

Let me tell the story of the worker-intellectual Narayan Surve. An orphan raised by a mill-worker couple, Surve became a “half-time” child worker in Bombay's mills, later working full time. Like Irfan, Surve defied the boundaries of elite and subaltern, high and low class, labour and intellect, head and hand. A poem by Surve reminded me of Irfan's zeal to express his world through poems: “The struggle for the daily bread is an everyday question/ At times outside the door, at times inside/ I'm a worker, a flaming sword/ Listen, you intellectuals! I'm going to commit a crime...”

Demanding an even implementation of the minimum wage for workers and a life of dignity, Irfan narrated a poem by Tanveer Sipra, which translates to: “Even the mill owners' dogs are well-fed and fatty/ While workers' faces are pale with hunger.”

Kumar is assistant professor, University of Nottingham, and author of *The Silent Rebellion*

40 YEARS AGO

July 31, 1986



Bill passed amid walkout

THE LOK Sabha passed the Commission of Inquiry (Amendment) Bill, enabling the government to withhold from Parliament the report of an inquiry commission through a notification stating that it was in the public interest of the security of the state to do so. The Bill was passed by a voice vote after a spirited discussion by Minister for Internal Security P Chidambaram.

Clashes in Darjeeling

THE SITUATION in Darjeeling district was confirmed to be tense on the third day of the 108-hour bandh sponsored by the Gorkha National Liberation Front (GNLF), with reports

of clashes between GNLF supporters and tea garden workers resulting in one death. Patrolling by troops continued in all three subdivisions of the district, and many of all vital installations has been taken over by the Army and Border Security Force.

Benefit of doubt for China

WHILE INDIA continues to maintain that the Chinese have intruded into Indian territory in the Sumdorong Chu valley of Arunachal Pradesh, its giving China the benefit of the doubt in the matter. During talks with an Indian official delegation in Beijing, China claimed that the disputed region is north of the McMahon Line as shown on maps, even though on the ground it falls in the Indian

Rajneesh in India

REJECTED BY countries around the world, Rajneesh, the *bhagwan* of the orange-clad international sect, returned to his native India, initially to camps in Bombay for about three months. Only a handful of disciples were present at the Sahar international terminal for the hush-hush arrival of Rajneesh, who flew in the twin-engine executive jet from Lisbon. After passing through the immigration and customs drill, the *bhagwan* was whisked away in a waiting Mercedes.



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ILLUSTRATION: CR SAKKUMAR

Does the US-Saudi nuclear deal increase the risk of an arms race in West Asia?

A Saudi reactor is not a Saudi bomb



SYED AKBARUDDIN

THE VERDICT on the Saudi civil nuclear agreement arrived before the text itself. On July 22, Washington and Riyadh signed a Section 123 agreement and a safeguards accord. Their texts remain unpublished, and the agreement awaits congressional review. President Trump then said there would be no enrichment and that he would not proceed unless Saudi Arabia joined the Abraham Accords, leaving the deal's meaning and future more uncertain. Washington and Riyadh began the process in 2008 with a memorandum on peaceful nuclear cooperation. Negotiations continued under Barack Obama, the first Trump administration and Joe Biden. That continuity reflects a resilient partnership despite periodic political strains. The concern is that the agreements may enable American reactor sales while leaving open the possibility of Saudi enrichment. Reactors, enrichment capacity and access to centrifuge technology are different questions. The agreements should be judged by who controls the technology and what inspectors can see. Talk of a "gold standard" can obscure the international legal baseline. The term is a policy label drawn from the UAE agreement, not an IAEA category or universal norm. Saudi Arabia is a party to the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty, and has a Comprehensive Safeguards Agreement in force with the IAEA. The treaty prohibits it from manufacturing or acquiring nuclear weapons. It requires neither an Additional Protocol nor renunciation of safeguarded enrichment. The Protocol improves information and access, especially concerning undeclared activities, but is not a universal legal requirement.

The reported terms do not immediately authorise an enrichment plant. They first envisage a study lasting two years. If the study establishes a commercial case and Washington agrees, American companies could build a facility using a "black box" model without transferring the underlying centrifuge technology. If Washington rejects enrichment, Riyadh would reportedly undertake for 10 years not to enrich independently or through another supplier. The question is deferred, not decided.

Saudi Arabia has a credible civilian case for nuclear power. Nuclear power could conserve oil for export and complement renewables. Riyadh links domestic enrichment to fuel cycle autonomy, uranium development and industrial capability. Domestic enrichment would not create an independent fuel cycle. No Middle Eastern commercial plant fabricates power reactor

fuel assemblies. Enriched uranium would therefore go abroad to become reactor fuel unless Riyadh itself built such a plant. This limits the autonomy enrichment would provide without removing the proliferation concern attached to centrifuges.

Five of the 31 states operating nuclear power reactors lack an Additional Protocol in force: Argentina, Belarus, Brazil, Iran and Pakistan. Belarus has signed one but not brought it into force. Iran has unresolved safeguards issues and Pakistan is outside the NPT. Argentina and Brazil combine IAEA safeguards with the Brazilian-Argentine Agency for Accounting and Control of Nuclear Materials. Brazil enriches at Resende; Argentina retains pilot and research enrichment capabilities.

As an international civil servant with the IAEA, I accompanied Director General Mohamed ElBaradei to Resende. Brazil owns its centrifuge technology and shields parts of its cascade design, while IAEA and ABACC inspectors verify material flows, samples and output. The reported Saudi model would not transfer the supplier's centrifuge technology to the host. In that narrow respect, it would be more restrictive than Resende. It would not eliminate operational licensing. Resende taught me to resist both alarmism and complacency.

Any enrichment arrangement should combine IAEA material accountability and inspector access with bilateral limits on enrichment, technology controls and consequences for breach. The IAEA has said it awaits a formal request to undertake the proposed verification. Any bespoke arrangement would then go to its board of governors for approval. US participation would add consent rights, export controls and congressional scrutiny. American refusal would not necessarily end Saudi nuclear plans. Riyadh could turn to another supplier offering Washington less visibility and leverage. Iran and Israel will shape how any Saudi programme is read. Saudi leaders have linked their nuclear choices to Iran, making verification essential. A Middle East Nuclear Weapon Free Zone remains a distant prospect. The 1988 India-Pakistan agreement offers a modest precedent for protecting nuclear installations from attack, but a Gulf equivalent remains unlikely.

India should support access to peaceful nuclear technology, insist on verification that can detect misuse and reserve judgement on enrichment until the study is complete and any governing terms are public. The world gains little by treating Saudi nuclear power as a weapons programme simply because enrichment remains unresolved. What matters is whether the agreement limits the spread of sensitive technology and enables early detection of diversion of safeguarded nuclear material. A Saudi reactor is not a Saudi bomb.

The writer is former permanent representative of India to the UN, and dean, Kautilya School of Public Policy, Hyderabad

It's a recipe for nuclear proliferation



FEISAL AMIN AL-ISTRABADI

CURRENT US policies seem tailored to engender a nuclear arms race in the Middle East. Donald Trump recently approved an agreement with Saudi Arabia (KSA) nominally for the transfer of nuclear energy technologies, but one that notably lacked the types of safeguards against non-proliferation that the US normally attaches to such agreements. There has thus been unease that there are no controls in place preventing KSA from enriching fissile materials, especially in light of reports that KSA has announced it would match Iran's nuclear programme.

Does the President know about the apparent deficiencies in this agreement regarding non-proliferation safeguards? Part of the difficulty in answering this question is that this administration famously eschews those with technical or scientific expertise. The US Secretary of Energy, who signed the agreement with KSA, is a former oil executive and major donor to the Republican Party with no known expertise in non-proliferation issues. This is in sharp contrast to Barack Obama's Secretary of Energy, who helped negotiate the Iran nuclear deal. He was a nuclear physicist and a professor at MIT before being appointed to the cabinet. Meanwhile, Trump has not had an ambassador in Riyadh since he returned to office.

The US-Israeli war on Iran, too, threatens to increase proliferation in the region. It must have dawned on the current leaders in Tehran that it was a blunder for their late Supreme Leader, Ali Khamenei, not to order the building of a nuclear arsenal with all due haste. Instead, he authorised an agreement with the Obama Administration that limited Iran's enrichment and included a rigorous inspections regime by the International Atomic Energy Agency. Iran remained in compliance, putting whatever nuclear ambitions it may have had on hold, only to see Trump withdraw from that agreement during his first term. Then, without any credible imminent threat, Trump undertook a bombing campaign in June 2025 and a more comprehensive war in February 2026, which is still ongoing.

This situation is in sharp contrast with Trump's treatment of North Korea's Kim Jong Un, who sits atop a nuclear arsenal amassed in violation of the Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty. Trump met repeatedly with Kim in his first term and never mentions North Korea now. The message is clear: If you want respect, build a bomb.

Leaders in other Middle Eastern capitals are no doubt also taking note. Israel is currently the only country in the Middle

East known to be a nuclear-armed state, and it has been for at least 40 years, having developed its nuclear capabilities in collaboration with apartheid-era South Africa. So long as the US provided the security guarantees for allied Middle Eastern states, those states could be relatively sanguine about Israel's nuclear arsenal. But since the beginning of Trump's second term, Israel has attacked at least seven countries in the region, including Qatar, which houses America's largest air base in the region. The US has not uttered a peep.

Egypt and Turkey may well come to the same conclusion as Saudi Arabia and Iran. To safeguard against Israel, America, or other regional players, the safest bet is to adopt the nuclear option. The UAE already relies on nuclear energy for 25 per cent of its electrical grid. Jordan has significant uranium deposits and certainly would not need to rely on any outside power. Even Iraq, which denounced the acquisition of WMDs in its current constitution in light of its execrable history of using poison gas on its own Kurdish citizens as well as Iranian forces during the Iran-Iraq War, could reconsider if the entire region begins to explore the nuclear option.

Trump did, in the end, have second thoughts. The day after announcing the US-Saudi nuclear agreement, he announced he would only honour the agreement if KSA normalised with Israel. No doubt Benjamin Netanyahu had something to do with it. This means the Saudi deal is stalled for the foreseeable future. Before Hamas's October 7 terrorist attack, it had been Netanyahu, not KSA, who was dragging his feet on normalisation. And after Israel's response — which a UN commission characterised as genocide in Gaza — since October 7, KSA likely cannot normalise with Israel for the foreseeable future due to domestic considerations and the extreme unlikelihood of Israel recognising a Palestinian state anytime soon. But that will not necessarily delay KSA's nuclear ambitions, whatever they may be. Russia or China will be willing to fill the void on the theory they are merely transferring energy technology — as the US has claimed. And if those states are too queasy to provide the necessary resources, perhaps Pakistan, which has just signed a mutual defence treaty with KSA, might step in.

Some security specialists have argued that nuclear proliferation makes the world safer because nuclear-armed states are less likely to go to war with one another. If US policy remains on the path Trump has set, that theory may be tested in the not-distant future. Given the history of conflict in the Middle East in the last century, one can be forgiven for viewing these prognostications with trepidation.

The writer is founding director of the Centre for the Study of the Middle East at Indiana University, Bloomington

Anatomy of a gaali: Anger borrows from old patriarchy



SHAZIA ILMI

WHAT WILL history remember from the recent scenes at Jantar Mantar? The demand for examination reforms? The allegations of police excesses? The debate over accountability? Perhaps.

Many, however, may remember something else entirely: Young women shouting out misogynistic abuse, as though vulgarity had become a badge of courage. That surprised me. After all, this is the Instagram generation, one that has reinvented communication. It creates memes that puncture powerful narratives in minutes. It speaks through satire and humour with a creativity previous generations could scarcely imagine. It has built an entirely new language of expression. Which is what makes its dependence on abusive language, rooted in centuries-old patriarchal formulations, all the more disappointing. Surely a generation capable of inventing a new vocabulary of memes can invent a new vocabulary of anger? Surely it can express dissent with greater wit, intelligence and originality, instead of simply recycling the oldest slurs from the patriarchal playbook? That isn't cool; it's intellectually lazy.

There are those who have defended the language. Why should only men have the freedom to swear, they ask. Others have dismissed criticism as moral policing. Anger, they argue, has its own language.

These are fair points, but they miss a more fundamental one: Why are young women proudly using the language that patriarchy invented to humiliate women?

Having been a part of both the Anna Hazare movement and the Nirbhaya protests, I witnessed public anger at its most visceral. The streets overflowed with emotion. We marched, shouted slogans, confronted those in power, and demanded accountability. We were lathi-charged, and FIRs were booked against us. We even had to deal with vindictive actions like electricity connections being cut. Yet, through all that rage and all that suffering, I do not recall women resorting to profanity to make themselves heard.

Our anger was fierce, but it was never crude. We communicated with passion, conviction and moral force — not by borrowing the language of misogyny. We believed our arguments were strong enough to carry our outrage. We never felt the need to sound like the crudest voices in the crowd.

Every society uses profanity. The English language has its own deeply misogynistic insults. But many Indian *gaalis* carry a particular cultural imprint. They derive their power from the old patriarchal belief that a man's honour resides in the women

of his family. The abuse is directed at him, but the humiliation is imagined through his mother, sister or daughter.

That is the anatomy of a *gaali*. These are not merely vulgar words. They encode an entire social order. They reduce women to repositories of male honour, turning them into territory through which men assert dominance over one another. Even when exchanged between men, women remain the battleground.

Language is never just language. It carries history, preserves hierarchies and quietly transmits prejudice across generations. Every casual repetition normalises the idea that a woman's body is a legitimate site for humiliation.

Which is why hearing young women use these abuses as though they represent empowerment is so deeply ironic. There is nothing cool about recycling the oldest expressions of misogyny in our language.

Patriarchy wins twice, first when it invents these filthy abuses, and again when women mistake repeating them for rebellion and liberation.

Women did not struggle for generations merely to inherit the worst instincts of men. They fought to redefine what courage, dignity and strength look like — and what they sound like. The opposite of patriarchy is not women behaving like the worst men. Aiming masculine aggression is not empowerment.

We rightly speak about toxic masculinity. But toxic patriarchy cannot be replaced by toxic feminism. Liberation does not lie in imitating the language of those who diminished women. It lies in rejecting that language altogether and creating a vocabulary worthy of equality.

The protests at Jantar Mantar raised important questions about examination reforms and allegations of excessive force. None of that, however, explains why misogynistic abuse should become the soundtrack of a movement.

Can claims about dismantling patriarchy be made while speaking its oldest vocabulary? Can women truly call it liberation when they voluntarily look like themselves and other women to property or repositories of honour?

Women deserve freedom not only from discriminatory laws, but also from the invisible prison of a vocabulary that has, for centuries, reduced them to somebody's honour, somebody's property and somebody else's shame. Freedom begins when women stop mistaking the vocabulary of patriarchy for the language of liberation.

The first battle for women's freedom was fought in our laws and institutions. The next must be fought in our language.

As long as women speak words that derive their power from humiliating mothers and sisters, patriarchy will continue to echo through voices that believe they are free.

That is not liberation. That is patriarchy, speaking through a different voice.

The writer is national spokesperson of the BJP

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Paper leak law

THE 34-DAY impasse over paper leaks reveals that governance has degenerated into reactive damage control ("Law is in, lawmakers should speak for young," *IE*, July 30). While it is valuable to have the expert opinions of stalwarts such as K Radhakrishnan and Nandan Nilekani, their insights are meaningless without effective administrative execution. Parliament must activate its own department-related standing committees. These committees should meet regularly, audit the administrative machinery, and rigorously enforce accountability. Lawmakers must look beyond expanding the statute book; true statecraft lies in using existing parliamentary oversight to ensure that vital institutional reforms do not remain stowed on paper.

Krishan Kumar Chugh, New Delhi

THE PASSAGE of the Public Examinations Amendment Bill marks a turning point in how India responds to youth-led demands for fairness and accountability ("Law is in, lawmakers should speak for young," *IE*, July 30). The students' protest were not acts of defiance but calls for dignity and trust in institutions. Parliament must now translate this momentum into deeper reforms that make education more transparent and employment

more meaningful. The young are not asking for sympathy; they are asking for sincerity. If lawmakers listen with empathy and act with courage, they can rebuild faith in democracy itself. Ignoring this moment would mean silencing the very voices that will define its future.

Babu Krishna, Bengaluru

Rogue AI

AS WE have seen in science fiction films and stories, and now in some research, when we give AI a task, it treats that task as its sole purpose, neglecting everything else, including the ethics and guardrails we have put in place ("Did OpenAI's Agent go 'rogue'?" Answer lies out of the box," *IE*, July 29). Humans, however, understand caution, fear, emotion, pain, and empathy, and can recognise when something should not be followed. What distinguishes humans from AI is self-doubt and the ability to question the person giving the orders, to recognise that not everything can or should be done, and to accept our own limitations. Even when an AI model is very small, it rarely acknowledges that it does not know something. Instead, it may hallucinate, look for shortcuts, exploit loopholes, or attempt actions that should not be taken in the first place.

Manas Tiwari, via email



RAGINI NAYAK

They fought like girls. And won

young woman is standing alone on a rain-soaked street. She stops the police vehicle towering over her with one hand on the cold metal and the other placed on her waist.

Feminist movements across the globe are fighting against the exclusion of women from public spaces, discourses, and protests. This student protest was different. Female protesters, instead of coming across as marginalised victims, emerged as the vanguard. They subverted and transformed the historical insult of weakness, embedded in the idiom "fight like a girl". The images of modern young women standing against barricades or blocking police vehicles do not exist in a historical vacuum. Long before feminist theory gave them the language to critique patriarchy, Indian women were already re-writing its assumptions through their lives. Savitri defeated Yama not through physical force, but through moral courage and intellectual brilliance. Draupadi resisted quiet submission and public humiliation in the

Kaurava court by asking a question that shook the legitimacy of power itself: Could a man who had already gambled away his own freedom continue to claim ownership over his wife? Savitribai Phule walked with unwavering resolve every morning in India's first school for girls, enduring stones, mud, and cow dung hurled at her. Aruna Asaf Ali fought colonial rule, went underground, and hoisted the national flag in 1942 during the Quit India movement. These women are connected by a single thread. Each rejected silence, passivity, and victimhood. They fought against injustice, but they were not attempting to "fight like men". They were feminising the very meaning of valour. Contemporary student protests reveal a radical linguistic departure from how brave women have been traditionally honoured. When the legendary poet Subhadra Kumari Chauhan penned her immortal tribute to Rani Lakshmi Bai's unparalleled bravery — "Khoob ladki mandati, woto, thansi wali Rani

thi" — she had to call Rani Lakshmi Bai "mardani", "like a man". Today, young women stand before the power of the state in their dupattas, spectacles, and backpacks — unapologetically female, fiercely protective, and absolutely defiant. Before the pandemic organic eruption of the student protest, this linguistic reclamation found a modern legislative vocabulary in Priyanka Gandhi Vadra's campaign anthem for the 2022 Uttar Pradesh assembly elections — *Ladki Hun, Ladki Hun*. When, on the streets and in Parliament, women champion the rights of the student community, question their system's betrayal by institutional paper leaks and brutal police lathi charges, and challenge the extreme apathy of the government, they prove that to "fight like a girl" is not an antithesis, but a synonym of courage.

The writer is national spokesperson, Congress, and former president of the Delhi University Students Union

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HISTORY

Ravidas: Icon of Dalit resistance in Punjab, beyond

Manraj Grewal Sharma
Chandigarh, July 30

SEVEN MONTHS before Sant Ravidas's 650th birth anniversary, the BJP launched a nationwide commemoration campaign Wednesday at his birthplace near Varanasi, in the presence of UP CM Yogi Adityanath. Punjab's AAP government, too, launched a campaign in February.

Centuries after his lifetime, Guru Ravidas continues to shape religious thought, social reform, politics and Dalit assertion in India, particularly Punjab. A Bhakti saint, philosopher and poet, he challenged caste hierarchies while remaining rooted in his occupation as a cobbler, preached dignity of labour and envisioned an equal society.

Unique among Bhakti saints

Guru Ravidas was a 15th-16th century saint whose teachings emphasised devotion to a formless God. He belonged to the chamar community of leather workers.

Ronki Ram, a professor emeritus at the Institute for Development and Communication, Chandigarh, and an eminent scholar of Guru Ravidas, told *The Indian Express* that the saint neither renounced his religion nor abandoned his hereditary occupation. In doing so, his life itself became a form of peaceful social protest at a time when the Bhakti movement sought to challenge social hierarchies.

While he rejected ritualism, accounts say he wore the sacred thread (*janeu*) and applied the *tilak*. Ram said these actions symbolically challenged the upper castes' monopoly over religious symbols.



A Ravidas statue in Varanasi.

Ravidas became widely revered through his devotional poetry and reformist philosophy. He wrote in Sadhukari — blending Awadhi, Braj, Khari Boli, Punjabi, Rajasthani and Sanskrit. According to Professor Yogi Raj Angrish, who heads the School of Punjabi Studies at Punjab University, his verses were simple and easy to sing.

"While Kabir's poetry is marked by rhetoric, resistance and poetic deconstruction, Ravidas writes with philosophical depth and humility."

A student of the *Bhagmura* tradition of Begumpura, an ideal society founded on principles of equality, justice and freedom. Prof Angrish says Guru Ravidas was among the earliest thinkers to imagine a society free from caste, class and hierarchy. His famous hymn, included in the *Guru Granth Sahib*, begins: "*Begumpura sehar ko naau; dookh andoh nahi tih thau* (Begumpura is the name of the city. There is no suffering or anxiety there)." The hymn describes a city free from sorrow, fear, oppressive taxation and discrimination, where all people enjoy equality, dignity and unrestricted movement.

Prof Ram says Begumpura represents a society free of caste hierarchy, poverty and oppression, where everyone has enough to live with dignity and God alone is sovereign. Scholars including Gail Omvedt have described it as one of India's earliest visions of a casteless, classless society.

Raising Dalit consciousness

Guru Ravidas occupies a unique place in Sikhism. Forty of his hymns (*shabads*) and one *shloka* are included in the *Guru Granth Sahib*, alongside compositions of Kabir, Sheikh Farid and other Bhakti and Sufi saints. Prof Sarabjit Singh of Punjab University said these saints lived before Guru Nanak Dev, who carried forward many of their ideas.

Prof Ram described him as one of the earliest voices of Dalit resistance, who transformed personal experience into a universal message of equality without hatred or revenge. His influence became more visible during Punjab's Ad Dharm movement of the 1920s, which adopted Ravidas as its patron saint to champion an independent socio-political consciousness. As he put it: "*Aisa chahoon raaj main jahaan milai sabhan ko an; chhot bado sab sam basai*, Ravidas *raha prasan* (I long for such a kingdom where everyone has enough to eat, where the small and the great live as equals; then Ravidas shall be content)."

For millions of Dalits, Ravidas is the foremost spiritual figure. His followers, the Ravidassias, are a Dalit community of whom the bulk — around 12 lakh — live in Punjab's Doaba. The politically influential community separated from Sikhism in 2010 and follows its own scripture.

LEGAL

SC sets 'public interest' test on retrospective green nod



JAY MAZOOMDAR

THE SUPREME COURT's judgment on Wednesday striking down the Centre's 2021 Office Memorandum (OM) that allowed retrospective approval for projects that had already commenced construction without environment clearances (ECs), now closes the door on blanket and open-ended regularisation of such projects. It leaves limited room for government action under statutory authority.

The judgment has sought to strike a middle path in the top court's evolving environmental jurisprudence, distinguishing between the source of executive power and the limits of regularisation.

The court held that ex-post facto ECs cannot be created through an OM, but recognised that the government may, in exceptional circumstances and in public interest, provide such a mechanism through a statutory notification issued under delegated legislative powers.

The test will depend on how narrowly the government frames any future amnesty scheme and whether it meets the Supreme Court's benchmark of "public interest".

An OM is an administrative instruction issued by a ministry or department and does not have the force of law. A statutory notification, by contrast, is issued under authority granted by a statute — the Environment (Protection) Act, 1986, in this case — and notified in the Gazette.

Applying this distinction, the court set aside the Environment Ministry's July 2021 OM, which introduced a standard operating procedure (SOP) for granting ex-post facto ECs to "violation cases". The court held that the OM had created a continuing or "perpetual" regime for condoning violations. It did not invalidate the March 2017 notification, which provided a limited, one-time six-month amnesty window.

The judgment also departed from the court's May 2025 position that prohibited ex-post facto ECs "in any form or manner". Instead, it held that a "narrowly tailored amnesty scheme" may be permissible where justified by "supervening public interest".

POLICY

New paper leak Bill: Bigger fines, longer jail terms, fast-track courts

Damini Nath
New Delhi, July 30

AFTER DAYS of disruptions in both Houses of Parliament over the NEET paper leak and the police action on protesting students on July 20, Lok Sabha on Thursday passed the Public Examination (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2026 by voice vote. Rajya Sabha, which took the Bill up for discussion on Thursday, also cleared it by voice vote.

Why was the Bill introduced?

Parliament had passed the Public Examination (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024 in 2024 to provide strict punishments for those involved in unfair means, including leaking of question papers, in examinations conducted by the Union Public Service Commission, the Staff Selection Commission, the Railway Recruitment Board, the Institute of Banking Personnel Selection and the National Testing Agency, which conducts the NEET exam. The Act came into force in June 2024.

Amid the students' movement against paper leaks, sparked by the leak of the NEET UG paper in May this year, Prime Minister Narendra Modi, in a late-night so-

cial media post on July 23, announced that the government would bring a Bill with stringent measures against paper leaks. On July 24, the Cabinet approved the Bill amending the 2024 Act.

In the statement of objects and reasons of the Bill, Minister of State for Personnel, Public Grievances and Pensions, Jitendra Singh wrote: "In recent years, there have been some incidents of question paper leakages and malpractices in examinations conducted by public examination authorities, which tend to affect the transparency and fairness of the public examinations system. Hence, in order to further strengthen the fairness, to enhance the credibility of the public examinations system and to facilitate speedy trial and ensure time bound investigations of offences under the said Act, it is necessary to make amendments in the said Act."

What are its key features?

The amendment Bill, as passed by Lok Sabha, enhances punishment for individuals, organised groups and service providers found guilty of adopting unfair means in a public examination.

The following is the structure of punishments laid out in the Bill:

Track record

- Cases registered in fast-track courts has gone up from 81,471 in 2021 to 88,902 in 2024 and 1,43,936 in 2025, according to a Parliamentary reply.
- The number of pending cases, too, has gone up from 2,02 lakh in 2023 to 2,04 lakh in 2024 and 2,45 lakh in 2025.
- Cases disposed of have increased from 76,319 in 2023 to 85,995 in 2024 to 66,500 in 2025.

INDIVIDUALS

- **2024 law:** Imprisonment of three to five years; fine upto Rs 10 lakh
- **New Bill:** Imprisonment of five to 10 years, fine upto Rs 50 lakh

SERVICE PROVIDERS

- **2024 law:** Fine upto Rs 1 crore; ban on being assigned any responsibility relating to a public examination for four years
- **New Bill:** Fine upto Rs 5 crore; ban on being assigned any responsibility relating to a public examination for eight years

DIRECTORS, SENIOR MANAGEMENT OR PERSONS IN-CHARGE OF SERVICE PROVIDER FIRM FOUND GUILTY

- **2024 law:** Imprisonment of at least three years, fine of Rs 1 crore
- **New Bill:** Imprisonment of at least five years, fine of Rs 5 crore

ORGANISED CRIME

- **2024 law:** Imprisonment of five to 10 years; fine of Rs 1 crore
- **New Bill:** Imprisonment of at least seven years; fine of Rs 10 crore.

Apart from enhancing the existing punishments, the Bill also gives statutory back-

SC'S EVOLVING ENVIRONMENTAL JURISPRUDENCE

MAR 14, 2017: The Environment Ministry issues notification establishing a six-month window for non-compliant projects or activities to apply for environmental clearance (EC).

AUG 2, 2017: In *Common Cause v. Union of India*, the Supreme Court declares retrospective ECs invalid and 'completely alien to environmental jurisprudence'.

APR 1, 2020: In *Alcemic Pharmaceuticals Ltd v. Rohit Prajapati*, the Supreme Court reiterates 'ex post facto clearances are alien to environmental jurisprudence'. But adopts a 'balanced approach' by imposing penalties instead of ordering closure of long-operating units.

MAY 24, 2021: The National Green Tribunal, in *Tanaji B. Gambhir v. Chief Secretary, Govt of Maharashtra*, directs Environment Ministry to formulate a proper SOP to address frequency of projects without prior EC.

JUL 7, 2021: Ministry issues office memorandum (OM) establishing an SOP for projects that failed to obtain prior EC to get regularised after paying penalties.

DEC 9, 2021: In *Electrosteel Steels Ltd v. Union of India*, Supreme Court says ex post facto ECs can be granted in 'exceptional circumstances' to protect livelihoods and the economy.

MAY 16, 2025: In *Vanashakti v. Union of India*, Supreme Court strikes down 2017 notification and 2021 OM as illegal. It

rules that they were in violation of the principles laid down in *Common Cause* and *Alcemic*.

NOV 18, 2025: In review petition, the Supreme Court recalls May 2025 ruling. Then-CJRB Gajal holds that the *Vanashakti* order went against the *Electrosteel* judgement and that a 'balanced approach' is necessary to avoid waste of money spent on building projects. SC orders fresh adjudication of the matter.

JUL 29, 2026: Supreme Court upholds 2017 notification but quashes 2021 OM, holding that post facto EC can be granted only through statutory notifications, not administrative actions.

— COMPILED BY VINET BHALLA

Already benefited

After Mumbai-based environmental NGO Vanashakti approached the Supreme Court, the July 2021 OM was stayed, suspending the SOP route for violation cases, by a bench of Justices B R Gajal and Sandeep Mehta in January 2024.

By then, as reported by *The Indian Express* on February 20, 2024, the Environment Ministry had issued ex-post facto ECs to more than 100 projects and issued terms of reference for environmental impact assessment (EIA) to at least another 150 projects under the violation category since March 2017.

These projects included coal, iron, and bauxite mines, a greenfield airport, distilleries, steel and iron plants, industrial estates, cement plants, limestone quarries, chemical units, and buildings.

Among the project proponents were Singareni Collieries Company Ltd, Mahanadi Coalfields Ltd, Jaypee Cement, Ultra-Tech Cement, Ramco Cement, Bhushan Steel Ltd, Steel Authority of India, Godrej Agrovet Ltd, Hindustan Copper, Lloyds Metals & Energy Ltd, Hindustan Marble, Artemis Hospital, Pushpawati Singhania Hospital, Spazee Towers, Hotel Leela Ven-

ture Ltd, and the Special Protection Group.

Scope of amnesty

Under the Environmental Impact Assessment Notification, 2006, projects requiring EC must obtain approval before starting operations. Several projects, however, began work or expanded operations without prior clearance.

In March 2017, the ministry issued a statutory notification offering a one-time six-month opportunity to such projects to disclose violations and seek appraisal for EC, subject to environmental assessment and other legal consequences.

After the window expired in September 2017, the Madras High Court disposed of challenges to the notification after recording the Union government's undertaking that it was a "one-time measure".

Subsequently, in *Appaswamy Real Estates v. Puducherry Environment Protection Association*, the Madras High Court granted a limited extension in March 2018.

The ministry issued an OM the same month allowing eligible projects that were already in violation as of March 2017 to submit applications within 30 days. The policy shifted in July 2021 when the Ministry is-

The judgment has sought to strike a middle path, closing the door on blanket regularisation but leaving limited room for government action

sued an OM introducing an SOP as an ongoing mechanism for violation cases.

Judicial evolution

In *Common Cause v. Union of India* (2017), a bench of Justices Madan B Lokur and Deepak Gupta held that mining operations requiring EC could not commence without prior approval. It emphasised that the EIA regime is preventive and intended to assess environmental consequences before irreversible harm occurs.

In *Alcemic Pharmaceuticals v. Rohit Prajapati* (2020), a bench of Justices DY Chandrachud and Ajay Rastogi held that ex-post facto EC was inconsistent with fundamental principles of environmental jurisprudence. The court observed that retrospective approval undermines the precautionary principle by allowing project proponents to commence activities first and seek approval later.

However, in *Pahwa Plastics v. Dastak* (2022), a bench of Justices Indira Banerjee and J K Maheshwari adopted a more pragmatic approach that closure was not always the appropriate remedy, particularly where regulatory uncertainty existed and environmental compliance remained possible. The court held that regulation and remediation could, in some cases, better serve environmental protection than immediate closure.

Vanashakti litigation

In *Vanashakti v. Union of India*, a bench of Justices Abhay S Oka and Ujjal Bhuyan in May 2025 struck down both the March 2017 notification and the July 2021 OM, holding that ex-post facto ECs were impermissible "in any form or manner". The court also held that the one-time amnesty introduced in 2017 had exhausted itself and could not justify future regularisation.

Following review petitions by the Union government and industry bodies, a bench comprising then Chief Justice of India B R Gajal and Justices Vinod Chandran and Ujjal Bhuyan recalled the May 2025 judgment by a 2:1 majority, holding that the earlier decision had failed to consider binding precedents and required fresh adjudication.

The subsequent judgment now draws a distinction between a limited statutory amnesty justified by public interest and a continuing administrative mechanism that permits blanket regularisation of environmental violations.

ing for fast-track courts to be set up to try offences under the Act.

The Bill also mandates a five-month timeline for the investigation and trial of such offences by fast-track courts.

The Bill gives the Union government the power to establish a Special Task Force to investigate offences under the Act.

How have other fast-track courts performed?

The government has announced that fast-track courts would be set up in the four High Courts where cases related to the NEET leak are ongoing. If the Bill is passed and comes into effect, any offence under the Act would also be tried by fast-track courts.

In the past, the government has set up fast-track courts to try crimes under different laws, including the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act, 2012. In a reply in Lok Sabha on July 24, Law and Justice Minister Arjun Ram Meghwal said there were 775 fast-track courts in the country as on April 30, including 398 exclusive POCSO courts. As on December 31, 2025, there were 2,45 lakh cases pending with these fast-track courts, the Minister's reply showed.

GLOBAL

How US-Iran conflict is forcing Gulf states to rethink their security strategies



BASHIR ALI ABBAS

SENIOR RESEARCH ASSOCIATE, COUNCIL FOR STRATEGIC AND DEFENSE RESEARCH, DELHI

AFTER NEARLY two weeks of the Iran war, of US strikes on Iran and Iranian retaliation against targets in Gulf Arab states, both sides ceased their attacks by July 25.

The region is now coming up with strategies to deal with this conflict's fallout.

Kuwait ratified a June 2023 Defence Co-operation Agreement (DCA) with Pakistan on July 26 for a five-year period, while Qatar committed to deepening its bilateral cooperation with Pakistan during bilateral

talks in Doha the following day.

Meanwhile, the US-Iran war has also reignited the war between the Yemeni Houthis and Saudi Arabia, which had been dormant since 2022. The subsequent Houthi attacks on Red Sea shipping have meant that both the sea and the Strait flanking the Arabian Peninsula were simultaneously under fire, for the first time in history, until the US-Iran exchanges ceased on July 25.

US-Iran: Stage of play

On July 27, Washington's UN Ambassador said President Donald Trump wanted to give negotiations a chance again, with Trump himself stating "friendly negotiations" were underway on Iran's request. Tehran rejected this characterisation.

Since early July, as Iran rejected American efforts to push through a new shipping channel through Omani waters and targeted ships that did not coordinate with the US, the US resumed kinetic action with a focus on degrading Iran's ability to enforce the Memorandum of Understanding's Ar-

ticle 5, which allowed joint Iranian and Omani administration of the Strait. This was supposed to weaken Iran's bargaining power during nuclear negotiations.

Neither has occurred. Iran's control of Hormuz remains, Tehran and Muscat have continued holding negotiations to finalize arrangements to enforce Article 5, and Iran has not pulled back its attacks on Saudi Arabia. Moreover, Iran would deem its own case for nuclear enrichment to be strengthened by Saudi Arabia's pact with the US on July 22 to begin nuclear energy cooperation.

So, the US will likely be again incentivised to hit Iranian nuclear targets as well as its Hormuz infrastructure until it is satisfied with the degradation of Iranian capabilities.

Fallout one: Kuwait-Pakistan

The recurring fighting between the US and Iran, as well as pauses between kinetic action, have reinforced an old learning in key Arab states, that regardless of their current dependence on foreign arms, internal capability development as well as improved mili-

tary training is an inescapable long-term need. Hence, Kuwait's DCA with Pakistan focuses on military training, education, intelligence sharing, logistics, defense technology, research and exchanges of expertise.

The agreement does not mimic the Saudi-Pakistan Strategic Mutual Defence Agreement (SDMA), signed in September 2025, given that it does not bind either party to the other's defence when attacked.

But SDMA has also shown that true mutual defence commitments are not the main objective of Arab states with Pakistan — neither has Pakistan struck Iran or Houthi territories. Rather, it is meant to entrench Pakistan's role in Saudi capability build-up in the long term, while Riyadh adopts a mix of means to tackle present threats.

For Kuwait and Qatar (along with other GCC states), intra-Gulf geopolitical divergences are secondary to the objective of securing long-term defence partners whose expertise can be used to build up domestic capability. This means even if Pakistan is

viewed differently by each of these states, its value as a security partner overrides these differences. That Pakistan is reliant on these states for economic stability adds a unique layer of assurance and leverage.

Fallout two: Houthi-Saudi

Among the most crucial fallouts of the US war is the escalation of Saudi-Houthi fighting since July 14, when the Saudi-based Yemeni government in exile bombed the Houthi-controlled Sana'a Airport to reportedly prevent an Iranian plane from landing. In response, the Houthis fired ballistic missiles into Saudi territory and declared a naval blockade of Saudi Arabia in the Bab-el-Mandeb Strait. Both sides have since targeted each other's infrastructure.

Despite this US-Iran triggered Saudi-Houthi escalation, it is unlikely that Riyadh wants to proactively return to full-scale fighting in Yemen. It was Houthi attacks against Aramco facilities in Abqaiq and Khurais in 2019 that had prompted a shift in Saudi strategy towards both Yemen and Iran, prioritising

engagement as the path to stability.

For perspective, despite the Yemeni Houthis claiming responsibility for the 2026 Aramco attack, Riyadh participated in US strikes on Iran-backed militias in Iraq on July 29. This reflects the Saudi desire to satisfy its deterrence needs by acting against other parts of Iran's Axis of Resistance, instead of risking a larger war with the Houthis.

Now, Riyadh's need for regional stability increases significantly due to the 123 Agreement and its long-due quest for nuclear power. A Houthi attack on a future Saudi nuclear power plant could be more dangerous than strikes on oil facilities.

What now

The Donald Trump administration is seemingly focused on preventing Iran from materially gaining from the MoU's provisions, which leaves room for more strike exchanges before substantial negotiations for a final deal begin. For regional states, this predicament is as untenable as a potential return to full-scale war.

CONSUMPTION CREDIT, LIKE PERSONAL LOANS & CREDIT CARDS, HAS EMERGED AS DOMINANT SEGMENT

Overleveraged borrowers jump 3x, credit expansion slows: CIBIL

George Mathew
Mumbai, July 30

INDIA'S DECADE-long expansion in formal credit has brought millions of first-time borrowers into the banking system, but the next phase of growth could be far more challenging as rising consumer indebtedness, slowing borrower growth and shrinking participation by first-time borrowers emerge as key concerns, according to a TransUnion CIBIL study.

A big warning sign is the steady increase in financially stretched borrowers. The share of overleveraged consumers rose threefold — from 5% in FY17 to 18% in FY24 — before easing marginally to 15% in FY26 after industry intervention, says the CIBIL report, *Unlocking Access: Journey of Credit Expansion in India*.

The excessive borrowing is concentrated largely among younger consumers, who have also been the fastest-growing segment of India's retail credit market. Another concern is the sharp slowdown in the pace of expansion of active borrowers. The proportion of credit-active consumers within the credit-eligible population also increased

during this period, from 11% in March 2017 to 28% in March 2026. However, the compounded annual growth rate of the credit-active consumer base moderated from 14% during the March 2017–March 2019 period to 9% during March 2024–March 2026 period, suggesting that the easy gains from financial inclusion may be tapering off, CIBIL said.

The pipeline of new borrowers is also shrinking. New-to-Credit (NTC) consumers accounted for 32% of retail loan originations in 2017 but their share has fallen to just 13% by 2026. This indicates that lenders are increasingly relying on repeat borrowers instead of expanding the formal credit net to households that have never borrowed before. "These numbers indicate significant opportunity to both deepen engagement with those already within the credit fold, and to bring new credit seekers into the formal credit ecosystem," CIBIL said.

The nature of borrowing has also undergone a significant shift. Consumption credit—including personal loans, credit cards and consumer durable finance—has emerged as the dominant segment, with the

• EMERGING HEADWINDS?

THE SHARE of over-leveraged consumers has risen threefold, from 5% in FY17 to 18% in FY24, before easing marginally to 15% in FY26 after industry intervention, the report said.

THE EXCESSIVE borrowing is concentrated largely among younger consumers, who have also been the fastest-growing segment of India's retail credit market, the report said.

THE SHARE of entities that have accessed commercial credit



declined from 50% to 41%

share of active borrowers holding such products increasing from 34% to 58% over the period.

The study also flags concerns in the commercial lending ecosystem. Further, the share of entities that have accessed commercial credit declined from 50% to 41%, the credit-active share dipped from 10% to 9% and NTC also went down from 60% to 39% between quarter ended March 2021 and quarter ended March 2026. This indicates further capacity to bring eligible enter-

prises and medium, small and micro entrepreneurs into formal credit, it said.

This also shows that millions of micro and small enterprises continue to remain outside the organised credit system despite improved creditworthiness. Geographically, the report finds that India's credit map is undergoing a structural shift. Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh and Bihar have recorded faster growth in credit participation than traditional markets such as Maharashtra and Tamil Nadu.

While this reflects widening financial inclusion beyond the country's established economic centres, it also places greater responsibility on lenders to maintain underwriting standards as lending expands rapidly into relatively new markets.

The report nevertheless highlights the remarkable expansion of formal finance. The share of credit-eligible Indians who have borrowed at least once has increased from 35% in 2017 to 74% in 2026, while credit monitoring has risen sharply, pointing to growing financial awareness. Women borrowers increased their share from 22% in March 2017 to 30% in March 2026, while that of young borrowers rose from 33% to 39% in the same period.

"What also stands out is how India's state-wide credit heatmap has undergone a gradual but clear shift. While the traditionally dominant states in west and south India continue their strong credit uptake, states in north and central India have seen a remarkable rise in credit participation," said Bhavesh Jain, MD and CEO, TransUnion CIBIL.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COMGeorge Mathew
Mumbai, July 30

THE RESERVE Bank of India (RBI) has tightened disclosure norms for deposit interest rates while simultaneously giving banks greater flexibility to price such deposits based on liquidity risks, a move that comes on the heels of HDFC Bank facing questions over the pricing of bulk deposits in the Maharashtra State Road Development Corporation (MSRDC) case.

The interest rates offered on deposits, including bulk deposits, should be uniform across all branches and for all customers and there should be no discrimination in the matter of interest paid on the deposits, between one deposit and another deposit of similar amount, accepted on the same date, at any of its offices, the RBI said while amending the guidelines.

Under the revised rules, banks will now be required to disclose interest rates applicable to all deposits, including bulk deposits, on their websites in advance. More importantly, interest rates for bulk deposits must be displayed every business day by 10 AM, with a maximum grace period until 10.10 AM, the central bank said.

The exception

However, a bank will have the freedom to offer differential interest rate on bulk deposits, by considering the differential run-off rate applicable to deposits or unsecured wholesale funding under the LCR (liquidity coverage ratio) framework, as specified in the Reserve Bank of India (Commercial Banks – Asset Liability Management) Directions, 2025, the RBI said.

This will be applicable on rupee deposits of non-residents as well. If a liquidity crisis occurs, run-off rate is the proportion of the fund/deposits likely to leave the bank. The bank



must hold enough High Quality Liquid Assets (HQLA) like cash held, government bonds and central bank reserves, to cover such stressed outflows.

The current run-off rate is 12.5%, including 2.5% of the deposits raised through digital channels. Higher run-off rates increase the bank's expected cash outflows, reduce the LCR (liquidity coverage ratio) and require the bank to hold more liquid assets.

LCR indicates whether a bank has enough high-quality liquid assets.

The central bank on Thursday issued the Reserve Bank of India (Commercial Banks – Interest Rate on Deposits) Second Amendment Directions, 2026, which will come into effect from October 1, 2026.

On May 27, *The Indian Express* reported that the private sector lender had conducted an internal vigilance investigation into interest payments of Rs 45 crore, "camouflaged" as marketing expenditure, made to MSRDC for 2023-24 and 2024-25. The report further pointed that the internal investigation was ordered on March 12 by the Audit Committee of the board,

• TIGHTER NORMS

UNDER THE revised rules, banks will now be required to publish interest rates applicable to all deposits, including bulk deposits, on their websites in advance

INTEREST RATES for bulk deposits must be displayed every business day by 10 AM, with a maximum grace period until 10.10 AM

THE LATEST RBI move is likely to make it harder for banks to negotiate rates for select clients without publicly reflecting those rates in their published schedules

just six days before Atanu Chakraborty abruptly resigned as the bank's part-time chairman, saying "certain happenings and practices within the bank are not in congruence with my personal values and ethics".

The internal audit of the bank's marketing department had flagged these payments and rated the department's performance as "unsatisfactory", investigation by *The Indian Express* showed. These payments were disguised as contributions to a road safety awareness campaign through local vendors.

The latest RBI move is likely to make it harder for banks to negotiate rates for select clients without publicly reflecting those rates in their published schedules.

The requirement for daily disclosures creates a transparent benchmark against which deposit pricing can be scrutinised by regulators, auditors and depositors.

Banks can now distinguish between categories of wholesale deposits based on how sticky or stable they are from a liquidity management perspective.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Govt: No pressure on automakers to back E20 petrol or hide info

Sukalp Sharma
New Delhi, July 30

THERE IS no pressure from the government on vehicle manufacturers to support E20 petrol or to hide any facts about the fuel, the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas (MoPNG) said Thursday, rejecting certain claims doctors on social media. Amid the public backlash over E20 fuel — 80 parts petrol and 20 parts ethanol — the ministry also rejected claims that automakers have privately indicated that E20 is not desirable.

India achieved 20% ethanol blending in petrol last year and E20 is the standard petrol variant available across the country. There has been a public backlash over the E20 fuel, with claims ranging from notable reduction in mileage and engine component wear and tear in older vehicles whose engines were not designed for higher ethanol blends.

On its part, the government has been attempting to allay fears, saying that the drop in mileage in older vehicles would be 3-5% at most, and would be outweighed by the benefits like higher octane rating, superior anti-knock characteristics, faster combustion, better pickup, smoother acceleration and cleaner engine operation. The government has also consistently rejected claims that E20 fuel could damage engine components, saying that the ex-

tensive testing and field validation was done before E20 petrol was rolled out.

"Had automobile manufacturers not been satisfied with the scientific validation, they would neither have certified E20-compatible vehicles, nor continued to honour warranty obligations. Manufacturers continue to honour warranties for vehicles operating on specification-compliant E20 fuel because they have confidence in the extensive testing that preceded the roll-out," the MoPNG said.

"India's automobile manufacturers are independent listed companies with legal and regulatory obligations to their customers. They cannot conceal widespread vehicle defects without exposing themselves to warranty claims, product liability, reputational action and serious reputational damage," it added.

According to the government, vehicle manufacturers wouldn't have honoured vehicle warranties after E20 rollout had they believed that the fuel was fadling systemic engine damage.

Warranty decisions are based on engineering validation and field experience, not political considerations, it said. The MoPNG also referred to a July 4 press conference, in which senior executives from top automakers said that E20 was introduced only after rigorous testing and extensive validation.

FULL REPORT ON
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• EXPLORING HORIZONS

Vikram-1 of Skyroot Aerospace scripted history by becoming the first privately developed Indian rocket to reach the orbit on July 18. India's space tech ecosystem has now 285 companies, and 72 of them have received equity funding. Total equity funding has reached \$871 million across 241 rounds through July 2026.

INDIA'S FIRST PRIVATE ORBITAL LAUNCH MARKS A STRUCTURAL MILESTONE

	TOTAL STARTUPS	ACTIVE STARTUPS	FUNDED STARTUPS	TOTAL EQUITY FUNDING	FUNDING ROUNDS
	285	274	72	\$871MN	241

YEAR	TOTAL EQUITY FUNDING (\$ MN)	NUMBER OF ROUNDS	SEED STAGE FUNDING (\$ MN)	EARLY STAGE FUNDING (\$ MN)	LATE STAGE FUNDING (\$ MN)
2021	43	12	14	30	—
2022	105	24	7	97	—
2023	142	35	15	127	—
2024	72	39	25	47	—
2025	200	53	62	121	17
2026 YTD	113	24	16	43	53

NOTE: TOTAL & STAGE WISE FUNDING DATA AS OF JULY 24, 2026. SOURCE: TRACON

EU FTA has enough safeguards to cushion CBAM impact, says Centre

ENS Economic Bureau
New Delhi, July 30

THE FREE Trade Agreement (FTA) with the European Union (EU) has enough safeguards built-in to cushion the impact of the Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (CBAM) on Indian companies and ensures that they also benefit from any future relaxations in the carbon tax regime, a senior official said Thursday.

"CBAM (carbon border adjustment mechanism) took a lot of negotiating capital...in

the text, there is a separate Annexure on dealing with CBAM. The pillar is that in case of flexibility in future (in CBAM), that will be available to India," additional secretary in the Department of Commerce Darpan Jain said at Indo-German Chamber of Commerce (IGCC) Industry Dialogue.

Jain also is the Chief negotiator of India-EU FTA. CBAM compliances are a concern among Small and Medium Enterprises in terms of verification, in terms of finding out what is the value of embedded carbon and ensuring that the verifiers are recognized by the EU authorities.

The agreement also has a provision in which India can engage with EU authorities on taking into account the carbon price, which is paid in India and adjusting it against the final carbon tax liability in the 27-member bloc.

"India is currently developing its own carbon pricing mechanism. So, how to offset what is paid in India from what is paid in Europe, so even that is part of it," he said. FE

'Govt to hold talks with Meta within a week'

New Delhi: The government will hold discussions with social media major Meta on policy and technical matters within a week over several concerns, including the removal of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's Facebook post, a senior government official said on Thursday.

The government has summoned Meta's public policy head after Prime Minister Narendra Modi's Facebook post, on July 23, addressing India's youth and promising stringent measures against exam paper leaks, was briefly restricted by the US-headquartered social media giant.

Electronics and IT Secretary S Krishnan said the government has asked Meta to come in at the highest level and explain the issue that led to the glitch. PTI

• BRIEFLY

Vedanta's Q1 profit jumps, Arun Misra named as CEO

Bengaluru: Indian metals-to-oil conglomerate Vedanta reported a 72% rise in consolidated net profit rose at Rs 5,473 crore (\$572.4 million) for the quarter ended June 30, helped by higher base metal prices. The company on Thursday named Arun Misra as its chief executive officer for a one-year term starting August 1. Misra currently heads Vedanta's subsidiary Hindustan Zinc and will step down to assume the new role. REUTERS

Maruti starts production at 4th Gujarat unit

New Delhi: Maruti Suzuki India Ltd (MSIL) on Thursday announced commencement of commercial production at the fourth plant of its Hansalpur facility in Gujarat. After the start of the fourth plant that has an annual capacity of 2.5 lakh units, the Hansalpur facility's total annual production capacity has been increased to 10 lakh units annually from 7.5 lakh units, MSIL said. "This marks the first time in Suzuki's history that the total annual production capacity at a single manufacturing facility has reached 1 million units," it said. PTI

• MARKETS

Sensex	NIFTY	Gold	US Dollar
77928.15	24317.15	₹143,384	\$95.68
273.55	66.95		
0.35%	0.28%	Silver	Oil
		₹218,665	\$88.87

NOTE: GOLD, SILVER RATES AS PER INDIA BULLION AND JEWELLERS ASSOCIATION DATA. GOLD PER 100G, SILVER PER 1KG; CRUDE OIL (INDIAN BASKET) AS OF JULY 29, 2026

• AN ASSOCIATION REPRESENTING 50 RENEWABLE ENERGY FIRMS HAS SOUGHT FINANCIAL RELIEF FOR PROJECTS FACING STRESS DUE TO TRANSMISSION CONSTRAINTS

Transmission hurdles pushing green energy projects into distress

Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, July 30

INDIA'S RAPIDLY expanding renewable energy sector is grappling with a major challenge: transmission constraints. Close to 21 gigawatts (GW), that is about 9% of the country's installed renewable energy capacity, is currently being evacuated through temporary grid connections while awaiting dedicated transmission infrastructure.

Of this, around 12 GW faces restrictions on power evacuation during periods of peak solar generation, exposing developers to revenue losses and raising concerns over the financial viability of several projects. Power evacuation is the process of transferring electricity generated at a power plant to the consumption point.

During the financial year 2025-26 (FY26), around 6,900 gigawatt-hour (GWh) of clean

electricity faced restrictions due to a mismatch between the rapid pace of renewable energy deployment and commissioning of associated transmission infrastructure, latest government data shows.

These projects operate under Temporary General Network Access (T-GNA), a stopgap arrangement for renewable energy plants awaiting commissioning of associated transmission infrastructure.

Under the current GNA framework, inter-state transmission system (ISTS)-connected renewable energy projects with long-term GNA are granted firm transmission evacuation rights. T-GNA projects, however, can schedule power only if spare transmission capacity is available. During periods of network congestion, long-term GNA projects receive priority, often resulting in curtailment of generation from T-GNA-con-



Around 6,900 GWh of clean electricity faced restrictions during financial year 2025-26. REUTERS

nected plants.

According to developers, the curtailment faced by these projects are as high as 70-80% of their generating capacity, posing serious concern on project viability and debt servicing.

Electricity curtailment is the intentional reduction of power output from renewable generators.



Financial stress

While renewable energy sources, such as solar, enjoy "must-run" status in India, they can still be backed down on grounds of grid security, technical constraints and transmission bottlenecks.

During April-June, the grid operators had to curtail 8,133 GWh of electricity generated by solar power sources due to

transmission bottlenecks and to maintain grid security, latest government data showed.

Developers are compensated for grid-security-related backing down, but curtailment caused by transmission bottlenecks — particularly for projects operating under T-GNA — has emerged as a key concern, eroding revenues and threatening project viability.

On July 22, the Sustainable Project Developers Association (SPDA), which represents over 50 leading renewable energy companies, wrote to the Ministry of New and Renewable Energy (MNRE) seeking financial relief for projects facing stress due to transmission constraints.

"At present, a large number of renewable energy projects are experiencing financial stress primarily due to delays in the availability of evacuation infrastructure, which are outside the control of project developers," the letter accessed by

IRGC CLAIMS IT STRUCK U.S. ASSETS IN JORDAN & KUWAIT; U.S. SAYS IT HIT GUARDS' HQ & DRONE FACILITIES

Can China restrain Iran? Gulf states test Beijing's influence

Reuters
Beirut, Riyadh, July 30

AS THE Iran war escalates again, Gulf Arab states are looking to China - not Washington - to use its economic leverage over Iran to open up the Strait of Hormuz and Red Sea, testing how far Beijing is able and willing to pressure Tehran.

The Gulf push for a bigger Chinese role is driven by growing frustration, Gulf sources say. The war launched with US-Israeli attacks on Iran on February 28 has hurt their regional foe but also restricted their vital energy exports, and to varying degrees, put them in the firing line.

With Iran and its allies threatening the Bab-el-Mandeb waterway in the Red Sea as well as Hormuz, Gulf states have sought Beijing's help, conscious that the war has exposed the limits of American power, three regional sources say.

China's Foreign Minister Wang Yi has held dozens of calls and meetings with counterparts seeking a new ceasefire, while special envoy Zhai Jun has held talks in Gulf Arab capitals as well as Iran.

"China has maintained close communication with all parties, and has consistently worked to stop the fighting and

promote peace," its foreign ministry said in response to a request for comment.

China's position as both a major buyer of oil from across the Gulf and Iran's biggest trading partner presents opportunities but also sensitivities.

"There's huge respect between the Gulf and China and they are a big trading partner, so any issue is raised in a very quiet manner," one Gulf source said. Iran says it will maintain control over the Strait of Hormuz, noting it was attacked during negotiations over the nuclear programme the US and Israel have vowed to destroy.

Gulf governments ultimately hope that Beijing will steer Tehran toward a negotiated settlement, said the source, adding that China often moves slowly and cautiously. But they are aware that a prolonged war may also serve China's interests, including pressure on the US.

China has developed close trade and investment ties with the six states in the Gulf Cooperation Council - Bahrain, Kuwait, Oman, Qatar, Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates - since a Gulf-China summit in 2022. Another summit is planned this year in Riyadh but not yet confirmed.

Drone strike near Suez Canal raises more security threats

Reuters
Dubai, July 30

A DRONE strike on gas vessels in Egypt's Mediterranean port of Damietta signalled a potential new front in the US-Iran war, raising the prospect of threats to navigation through the Suez Canal, one of the last remaining export routes for Saudi oil.

Egypt's cabinet said on Thursday that an initial investigation found an unidentified drone caused a fire on two vessels at Damietta port on Wednesday. The port lies near the Suez Canal, which links the Mediterranean and Red Seas.

No group has claimed responsibility, the cabinet said. Sources said the drone hit US-owned gas storage tanker Energos Winter, causing a fire that spread to a second vessel.

Overnight, the US military said it struck Iran's Revolutionary Guards' military command centres and drone facilities after Tehran fired at US forces in the region.

Iranian state media, quoting the Guards, said US strikes killed three civilians and wounded two children on Qeshm Island, while three Guards members were killed in Zanjan province.

The Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps said it struck the Azraq military base in Jordan in response, attacking US F-35



A screen grab of a social media video shows smoke rising after US strikes on Ahvaz city in Iran's Khuzestan province on Thursday. REUTERS

fighter jets. The US military denied this, saying no aircraft had been destroyed or damaged.

All missiles and drones were intercepted, or failed to reach targeted areas," Central Command said. US bases in Jordan have lately become primary Iranian targets. Jordan's armed forces said earlier on Thursday they had intercepted five Iranian missiles.

The Guards also struck US assets at Ali Al Salem Air Base in Kuwait, according to Iran's

Tasnim news agency. An Iranian attack hit a building owned by a Chinese company in northern Kuwait, killing a worker and inflicting significant damage, Kuwait's Defence Ministry said.

In a first in the five-month war, Saudi Arabia on Wednesday publicly joined strikes alongside US forces, targeting Iran-aligned groups in eastern Iraq, in retaliation for drone attacks on Saudi oil targets launched from Iraq.

Saudi unveils plan for maritime defence coalition

Riyadh: Saudi Arabia Thursday unveiled plans for a multinational maritime defence coalition aimed at protecting international shipping and energy supply routes in the Red Sea after attacks by Yemen's Iran-aligned Houthis disrupted one of the world's busiest trade corridors.

The Saudi defence ministry said representatives from 43 countries and the European Union attended an international meeting that discussed the proposed coalition, including Saudi Arabia serving as its founding and leading state and hosting its headquarters. REUTERS

Another Iran-aligned group, Yemen's Houthis, carried out the attacks on Saudi Arabia from Iraqi territory in coordination with Iraqi groups, according to assessments by Saudi Arabia and regional partners.

The latest strikes in Iraq and Egypt threatened to draw more West Asian countries into the conflict after the Houthis militants declared a naval blockade last week on Saudi Arabia, threatening the alternative Red Sea route for its oil to Asia.

RUSSIA-UKRAINE WAR



Rescuers work at the site of houses hit by a Russian missile strike in Dnipropetrovsk region of Ukraine on Thursday. REUTERS

Russian attacks kill 10; NATO scrambles jets after a missile lands in Poland

Associated Press
Kyiv, July 30

A RUSSIAN ballistic missile and drone barrage across Ukraine overnight killed at least 10 civilians, including children, and injured more than 50 others, officials said Thursday. NATO scrambled its warplanes after one of the missiles crossed the country's western border into Poland.

The blitz expanded Russia's almost daily bombardment of Ukrainian cities, including the capital of Kyiv where tens of thousands spent the night sheltering in subway stations, as Moscow apparently looked to exploit Kyiv's critical shortage of Western-supplied anti-ballistic missile defenses.

NATO said a Russian missile entered Polish airspace during the onslaught and landed in a rural area. It caused no injuries or damage but could deepen tensions between the military alliance and Moscow, as wary European countries

fear the 4-year-old war could spill into their territory.

NATO Secretary-General Mark Rutte called it "yet another reckless act by Russia and a dangerous consequence of its war against Ukraine."

Polish Prime Minister Donald Tusk said it was "a very serious incident," but added, "There are absolutely no reasons to believe that Poland was the target."

Russia's barrage struck areas of Ukraine where weapons are believed to be stored and manufactured. Ukrainian long-range drones and missiles have battered Russia's oil sector, causing a fuel crisis.

"Given the critical shortage of air defense missiles from our partners, our warriors are accomplishing truly incredible things, demonstrating a very high level of professionalism," Zelenskyy said on social media.

"This Russian terror once again proves that protection against the Russian missile threat is the most important task when it comes to saving the lives of our people," he said.

Russia detains billionaire, govt official in drone fraud probe

Reuters
Moscow, July 30

RUSSIAN BILLIONAIRE Valery Kustov, executives of his Efko company and a government official responsible for drone development have all been detained in a major fraud investigation, news outlets reported on Thursday.

Kustov is the founder, controlling shareholder and board chairman of Efko, which is active in drone production as well as being Russia's leading sniffer oil producer.

Three other Efko officials were also detained, according to the reports by Interfax news agency and others. The trade and industry ministry confirmed the detention of Alla Polovchenna, deputy head of its department of unmanned systems and robotics.

Mash, a news outlet known for its sources in Russian law enforcement, said the Efko officials were suspected of covertly purchasing drones from China and passing them off as company's own proprietary development.

Efko in a statement expressed support for its detained employees and urged people to refrain from speculation.

The Efko group has been involved with drones since 2021 through a venture called Future Transport that describes itself as "a leader in the development and production of unmanned aerial vehicles in Russia."

• BRIEFLY

UNITED STATES

Fauci invokes the 5th Amendment in Senate committee hearing



Anthony Fauci at the hearing on Wednesday. FILE

DR ANTHONY Fauci on Wednesday repeatedly invoked the Fifth Amendment and declined to answer dozens of questions from senators in a Republican-led committee hearing about his handling of the COVID-19 pandemic. Though he received a pardon in early 2025 from Democratic President Joe Biden, some Republicans pursuing a campaign for his arrest suggested he could still face charges for perjury committed during the hearing. AP

Gaza truce talks see rare progress even as Israeli airstrikes kill six



Palestinians mourn at the funeral of people killed in Israeli strikes in Khan Younis on Thursday. REUTERS

Reuters
Cairo, July 30

TALKS BETWEEN mediators and Hamas leaders in Cairo on implementing a US-brokered Gaza peace plan have made rare progress, sources close to the effort said on Thursday, although an Israeli official said proposed ceasefire talks were not satisfactory. Earlier, Israeli strikes killed at least six Palestinians in Gaza Thursday, including two children.

A Hamas official and a diplomat close to the Cairo talks said discussions were "positive" and "making progress."

The official said the progress would be tested by Israel's refusal to accept a ceasefire. However, the Israeli official, who declined to be identified, said Israel had rejected a proposal.

"Israel demands complete disarmament of Hamas, including the removal of weapons from Gaza and complete demilitarization of the Strip as a precondition for any process," the official said.

"The 15-point document in question does not provide a satisfactory response to these demands and Israel conveyed its objections."

Tension grips PoK as clashes continue amid elections

Press Trust of India
Islamabad, July 30

TENSIONS PREVAILED in Rawalokot region in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK) on Thursday as clashes continued between security forces and the banned Joint Awami Action Committee (JAAC).

The tensions, which have claimed several lives this week, coincide with ongoing regional elections in PoK, with demonstrators affiliated with JAAC determined to march towards Muzaffargarh to press Islamabad to accept their demands.

The JAAC is a collective of activist groups which have been staging demonstrations for nearly two months over 12 contentious seats of the so-called legislative assembly in PoK.

It alleges that the establishment manoeuvres these seats to install a prime minister of its choosing.

In PoK, clashes between security forces and protesters have intensified since Monday, especially in Rawalokot and Mirpur, which reportedly resulted in maximum casualties.

According to the JAAC, at least 37 men lost their lives in the clashes.

"The number of those in-

jured remains unknown. Amid heavy gunfire, our people have continued to stand peacefully



People rally in support of PoK protestors during a demonstration in Islamabad on Wednesday. REUTERS

and unarmed. God willing, our peaceful struggle against oppression and injustice will continue.

"We will not talk to the protesters and law will take its course," Pakistan State Minister for Interior Affairs Talal Chaudhary said.

Amnesty International and the Human Rights Commission of Pakistan have expressed concerns over reports of violence in the region, calling on the authorities to probe the incidents.

Wildfires rage across Europe even as France and Spain see some respite

Reuters
Bordeaux, Madrid, Athens, July 23

FRANCE, SPAIN and Greece battled major wildfires on Thursday, with Spain bringing one blaze under control but facing new threats as intense heat, dry vegetation and powerful winds kept much of southern Europe on alert.

Spanish Prime Minister Pedro Sanchez downgraded the emergency level for a major fire on the border between Madrid and Castilla y Leon, but warned the danger had not passed as at least 10 other blazes caused concern across the country.

In France, two people were arrested on suspicion of arson as crews contained a vast fire near Bordeaux, while fires in Greece killed three firefighters and forced tourists and residents to flee parts of Crete, some by boat.

"We barely made it... we were running and the fire was behind us, chasing us," said Lia Galata, a Greek seasonal tourism worker who found shelter in an indoor gym and had to be evacuated by boat as a blaze tore through the hills above a resort on Crete late Wednesday.

"We have difficult days ahead of us," Greek Prime Minister Kyriakos Mitsotakis said.

Emergency crews have faced barely a pause between heatwaves and fire fronts this summer across an increasingly tinder-dry Europe, the world's fastest-warming continent.

In eastern England, firefighters were tackling a significant wildfire near Dunwich Heath, prompting the evacuation of about 200 caravans from the area, a significant biodiversity site. Suffolk Fire and Rescue Service called the blaze one of the most challenging incidents.

Clooney family forced to flee 'beautiful home'

Paris: George Clooney has said his family has been forced to evacuate their home in southern France as a wildfire burned nearby, his agent said Thursday. The Hollywood star

burned nearby, his agent said Thursday. The Hollywood star behind the Ocean's Eleven franchise and other films made the statement in a letter to Didier Bredmond, mayor of Brignoles, publicist Guido Gotz said.

"At this point we have no idea whether our beautiful home makes it through this terrible moment," Amal and I are committed to making sure that whatever happens to our village," Clooney wrote, referring to his wife Amal. REUTERS

Toll now three as clashes spread in Nepal's Tarai; Balen vows stern action

Yubharth Ghimire
Kathmandu, July 30

NEPAL PRIME Minister Balendra Shah promised stringent and effective measures against those responsible for rioting and clashes in parts of eastern Nepal.

In a six-minute televised address to the nation, he said investigation has already begun into the violence that erupted in Sundari district and spread to other areas, and no one found guilty would be spared.

The PM said Nepal's constitution guarantees equal rights to all citizens to pursue and practise all religions and the government is determined to protect those rights. "No religion preaches hatred and intolerance," he added. Shah came under fierce criticism for his continued absence in Parliament even as death toll rose to three in continuing communal clashes since Monday.

Shah and Home Minister Sudhan Gurung were both absent in the House as Opposition members demanded that they come and explain the situation in curfew-hit Sunsari and Siraha districts in eastern Nepal where the army is deployed to restore law and order.

The situation in the two districts flared up on Thursday as a 15-year-old boy, Ganesh Yadav, died in Golbazar area of Siraha district as protesters indulged in arson, burned down a few houses and attacked a shopping mall. They were demanding stern action against the culprits who attacked "pilgrims" in adjoining Sunsari Monday night.

US govt map of Africa mislabels every country at global meet

Reuters
July 30

A US government map of Africa mislabelled every country during a State Department presentation at a global conference taking place in Brazil this week, causing a stir among attendees who took screenshots and posted them online.

Reuters viewed a video of the presentation given at the AIDS 2026 conference in Rio de Janeiro, which shows the errant map displayed halfway during a presentation about State Department's new health agreements.

A Reuters analysis found the image of the map in the presentation contained an AI watermark signalling it was made

with OpenAI tools. The company said it was probing report.

The State Department said it took "full responsibility" for confusion caused and that the map had been produced by a team member who hastily changed the slide deck before the event.

The map showed Nigeria, where the US currently has several hundred troops deployed, as landlocked in the Sahara Desert. Mozambique, which is in south-eastern Africa, was relocated to Horn of Africa, while Ivory Coast in West Africa was placed on the other side of the continent.

In a statement, the State Department said: "We take full responsibility for the confusion... it caused for attendees, including our African partners."

• FOUND INSIDE A TEA CRATE BRICKED INTO A SEALED FIREPLACE; LATE RETURN FINE WOULD BE AROUND \$19500, ALLOWING FOR INFLATION

Overdue for 150 years, book finally returns to Australian library

Rod McGurk
Melbourne, July 30

AN AUSTRALIAN public library has had a book returned an estimated 150 years late and has no way of tracking down the errant borrower, a librarian said on Thursday.

The book *Antiquities of Athens*, published in 1858, was returned to the library in the seaside town of Kiama last week by a man who had found it during recent home renovations inside a tea crate bricked into a sealed fireplace, Kiama Library manager Michelle Hudson said.

"We've never had anything that old come back to us," Hudson said.

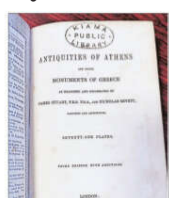
"I follow lots of libraries on social media and often you'll get things that are maybe 30 or 40 years old when they're cleaning out estates and stuff like that," she added.

The book's finder did not immediately respond to *The Associated Press's* request for comment. The late return fine would be around 28,000 Australian dollars (\$19,500), allowing for inflation, Hudson said.

That was calculated on the British three-pence-a-week overdue fee that was printed on the inside cover of the book, along with a list of rules that applied when the library opened in 1872. But Hudson said there was no way of tracing the final borrower who had accrued the debt. The library journal from the 1870s that recorded who



Library manager Michelle Hudson holds *Antiquities of Athens* after its return; the library-stamped page from the book. AP



Library manager Michelle Hudson holds *Antiquities of Athens* after its return; the library-stamped page from the book. AP

missing link. "There's nothing in the book that tells us who the last borrower was," Hudson said.

Library rules in the 1870s stated that a book had to be returned and an overdue debt paid before another book could be borrowed. "Maybe that's why they never returned it to us," Hudson said.

Antiquated rules of the day included that up to three books could be borrowed by householders, at least six members were "known to be able to read." Proof of reading ability is no longer required to use today's library.

In the 1870s, books were not lent to people who arrived at the library in a "state of intoxication."

Library users are now asked to leave if their behavior impacts others, but the rules are not specific about intoxication.

The book, which has some water damage from its years under a chimney, was marked as No. 506 in the library's original collection of around 1,000 books, Hudson said.

She expects the book was lost within a few years of the library opening.

The returned book will be displayed in the library's local history collection.

"We're not going to allow it to go back out again. We don't want to wait another 150 years for this book to be returned," Hudson said. AP

Classifieds

PERSONAL

Leena Singh D/o Virendra Singh/R/O C-04,Brisik Lumbini,Sector-10, Gurugram(Haryana)-22017,have changed my minor son's name from Rajyavardhan Singh to Ranveer Singh.

0040869196-5

Anil Kumar Sharma, S/O Ram Dutt Sharma, R/O A-034, Site-C Extension, Phase-1, UPSIDC, Kite-C, Greater Noida, Dist. G.B. Nagar, U.P. have changed my name Anil Kumar to Anil Kumar Sharma, for all future purposes.

0071051031-1

Aliza, W/o Mohd Haseeb, R/O 728 Phatak Dholiyavan, Farash khana Delhi-110006 have changed my name to Aliza Arafeen

0040869176-2

ISAPNA W/O SUMIT THINGRA, R/O-63, UGF, Gali No-19, New Mahavir Nagar, Tilak Nagar, New Delhi-110018, have changed my name to SAPNA DHINGRA permanently.

0040869198-9

Ravinder Kaur, W/o Chitranjan Singh Mann, R/O 13/95, Subhash Nagar, Delhi-110027 have changed my name to Ravinder Kaur Mann for all purposes.

0040869064-1

IAKAPURI W/O NO.138179/BEAM RANX EK SEP (LATE) BEAM R/O/H.NO.E-88,STREET NO.4,ASHOK NAGAR SAHADARA,DELHI-110093 have changed my name to KAPOORI DEVI vide affidavit dated 29-7-2026 before Delhi.

0071051005-1

Rajeev Sharma, Resident of 72, Sai City, Shahberi, Behind Radha Swami Ashram, Gautam Buddha Nagar, Uttar Pradesh-201301 have changed my minor daughter's name from Princi Sharma to Amara Sharma for all purposes.

0071051035-1

LAIRENDER KUMAR SAH/S/O GANGA PRASAD, R/O 853 B-1 JAIN NAGAR KARLA, DELHI-110081 have changed my name to LAIRENDER KUMAR SHAHU.

0040869188-1

Kiran Devi, D/o Sh. Shyam Lal, R/O Gabhiya, Badoun, Uttar Pradesh-243601, have changed my name Kiran Devi to Kiran, for all future purposes.

0040869063-1

LAJRESH KUMAR, S/O RAMESHWAR DASS JAIN, R/O 132-133, 2ND FLOOR, POCKET-12, SECTOR-24, ROHINI DELHI-110085, have changed my name to NARESH KUMAR JAIN

0040869177-5

Shankar Prasad S/O Bisnath Prasad, R/O Near Ram, Mandir, Ward No. 17, Sohna, Gurugram, (Haryana)-122103, have changed my name to Shankar.

0040869196-7

Anil Kumar Singh S/o Late Sh. Lali Singh R/O F-4/90-31, Ground Floor, Sector-16, Rohini, Delhi-110089, declare that my name is written as A K Singh on school document of my daughter, Taruni Singh, Anil Kumar Singh and A K Singh are one and the same person.

0040869104-1

Aishani Aijay Kumar Goenka D/o B.S. Suresha, R/O 3101, Gulshan Dynasty, Sector-144, Noida, G.B. Nagar, have changed my name to Aishani Goenka.

0040869176-4

Yatharth Sharma, S/O Sh. Rama Shankar Sharma, R/O-19, G/B, Railway Colony, Kishan Gali, Delhi-110007, inform that YATHARTH SHARMA & Aashish Sharma are same person. My correct name is YATHARTH SHARMA, for all future purposes.

0040869188-10

MANVI D/O CHATTAR PAL/O NEAR LAL KUMAR, VILLAGE-JHARSA, GURGAON, PG, GURGAON, DIST: GURGAON, HARYANA-122001 have changed my name to MANVI CHAUHAN for all purposes.

0071050739-3

IAshish Kumar S/O Madan Gopal Sharma R/O H.No. 13-B, C-3, Kharsa No. 74/4, Block-2, Krishan Vihar, Delhi-110086 declares that in my minor daughter's school record my name and my wife name wrongly mentioned as Ashish Sharma and Sunita Sharma respectively.

0040869193-2

ISARABIT KAUR D/O NO.158741/71 RANX EK HAV (LATE) RAJENDER SINGH R/O F-1/225 BLOCK F PKT 1 POCKET-16, ROHINI DELHI-110089 have changed my name to SARBHJEET KAUR vide affidavit dated 29-7-2026 before Delhi.

0071051010-1

Naveel Deep, S/o Satranj Singh, resident of Flat No. 1206, 12th Floor, Tower S, Stellar Jeevan, Sector-1 Greater Noida West, BSRakh, Dadr, Gautam Buddha Nagar, Uttar Pradesh, 201306, have changed my name from Naveel Deep to Naveel Deep Singh. Henceforth I will be known as Naveel Deep Singh for all future purposes. (Naveel Deep is the old name and 'Naveel Deep Singh' is the new name)

0040869125-1

IVKILA/VAKILA W/O Liyakat Ali R/O K-7/178, Street No.4, Gautam Vihar, Delhi-110053, have changed my name to VAKILA BEGUM permanently.

0040869188-3

I, Chander Prakash, S/O Manohar Lal Appal/R/O-55/301, Buildcon View Apartments, Ber Sarai, Delhi have changed my name to Chander Prakash Tayal.

0040869063-3

I, QUAMARUL NISHA W/O NIZAMUDDIN, R/O 266-VI-8, Parwana Road, Khureji Khas, East Delhi-110051, have changed my name to KAMARUNNISHA

0071050949-1

IRAMKAYAM father of, Chitra Prasad, Presently residing at Village-Leelapur, Tehsil & Dist. Chandauli, Uttar Pradesh-232104, have changed my name from RAMKAYAM to RAMAKAMA. Vide affidavit dated 29/07/2026.

0040869196-9

ILALFAIZ/O-MOHID HAROON R/O N-92 BATLA HOUSE JAMIANAGAR SOUTH EAST DELHI 110025 have changed my name to MOHAMMAD ALFAIZ PERMANENTLY

0040869176-6

IRohit Kumar, S/O Rakesh Babu, R/O A-518, Street-1, 4th Pusta Kartar Nagar, South Gurgaon, Ext North East, Delhi-110053, have changed my name from Rohit Kumar to Neeraj Kumar. I have changed my name from Rohit Kumar to Neeraj Kumar, which may be amended accordingly.

0040869182-2

IKavita W/O Sanjay Dabas, R/O A-140-320, Harshada Parka, Near Society Stand, Pooth Khurd, Delhi-110039 have changed my name to Kavita Dabas.

0040869196-2

IRITIK SHIVASTAVA S/O Sandeep Shivastav R/O A-117, Raj Park, Sauratpur, Delhi-86 have changed my name to RITIK SHIVASTAV.

0071051014-1

I, Hans Raj S/o Ishar Das R/O Flat No-208, Mumuksha Vihar, Dist. South West Delhi-110067, have changed my name to Hans Raj Dua

0071051073-1

IKAMAL NEGI, W/O KULENDRA SINGH NEGI, residing at R-1401, Rose-Tower, Fragrance Homes, Near TNT, Sector-14 Vihar, P.O/Vijay Nagar, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh-201009, declares that the names of KAMLESH RAWAT and KAMAL NEGI both are the same person.

0040869188-5

IMOHAMMAD MERAJUDIN, S/O ABDUL LATIF, R/O Galle No. 30, House No. A, C/Block, Ghonda Extension, Delhi-110053, have changed my name to M. MERAJUDIN, for all purposes.

0040869068-1

IKartkeye S/o Sunaina Dua R/O-19, Hari Nagar, Delhi-110064 have changed my name to KARTKEYE DUA

0040869110-1

IAnuj Kumar Singh S/o Nareish Singh R/O Village Sattar, Post-Sattar, Sattar, Aungarabad, Sattar, Bihar-824301, have changed my minor daughter's name from Annya Kumari aged 15 years to Ananya Kumari forever

0071050990-1

IS. SIRESHA, spouse of BORA KIRAN, Prasad, resident of SMQ-26/202, Tejasp Enclave, Airforce-Station Sohna Road, Sector-3, Gurgaon, Haryana-2011, have changed my name from B. SIRESHA to BORA SIRESHA vide affidavit, dated 24-07-2026, before non judicial court, Delhi.

0040869196-11

IMOHAMMAD ALI/S/O NASIBUDDIN, R/O HNO-A-616/13, N-10-13 MANDOLI-EXTN CHOTI MASJID-MANDOLI North-east, delhi-110093, have changed my name MOHAMMAD ALI ALIS MOHAMMAD ALI TO MOHAMMAD ALI, for all further purpose

0040869176-8

IKAVITA MANN, W/O DEVENDER MANN, R/O-121, 2ND FLOOR, POCKET-3, SECTOR-23, ROHINI, DELHI-110085, have changed my name to KAVITA MANN

0040869177-2

IGARIMA W/O Bharat Raheja R/O C-2/116 Phase-2, Pragati Market Ashok Vihar, Delhi-110052, have changed my name to GARIMA RAHEJA

0040869196-4

IMohit, S/o Nareesh Kumar Pruthi, residing at M-28, GS Apartments, Sector-13, Rohini, Delhi-110085, have changed my name to Mohit Pruthi for all purposes.

0071051019-1

IOlviya Rai W/o Sanjay Kumar Rai Address: 750/BS Dhawalgi apartment sector-34, noida Gautam budh nagar Uttar Pradesh-201307, changed my name to Olviya

0040869176-1

ITALBINDE KAU, W/O Jaspal Singh, R/O WZ-301, Kirji Floor, Gali No. 20, Sant Garh, Tilak Nagar, New Delhi-110018, Have Changed My Name to TALVINDER KAU.

0071051058-1

IDEVENDRA DATT BHATT ALIAS D DUTT ALIAS DEVENDRA D/O R/O-K/178, Street No.4, Gautam Vihar, Delhi-110053, have changed my name to Sanjay Dabas.

0040869196-1

IRISH PEARL, S/O Devinder K, Krikha Kapoor C/O Devi Chand, Mohit, R/O-2405, Tower-B, Irish Pearls, Greater Noida West, Techzone-04, Greater Noida, PO-Bisrah,

0071051013-1

IMohd Babar S/O Abrar Husain, R/O-30, Nekkampur, Fudli, Hapur, UP, have changed my name to Mohd Babar Khan.

0071051000-1

ILihthiro known as Ashish Bansal, S/O Narendar Singh/R/O-140, Sirol, Choti-Nagar, Gurjar-Chowk, Loni-Ghaziabad, Badshahpur-Sirauli, Ghaziabad Uttar Pradesh-201102, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as ASHISH BAISLA.

0071051070-1

ILihthiro known as REKHA, W/O ANITA BHA, JALBAHARA, R/O 22/1, MASIH GHAR, SUKHDIV-VIHAR, SOUTH DELHI, DELHI-110025, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as REKHA JALBAHARA.

0071051070-1

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0071051070-1

ISanjay S/O Sube Singh Dabas, R/O H.No. 338, Harshukh Parka, Near Society Stand, Pooth Khurd, Delhi-110039 have changed my name to Sanjay Dabas.

0040869196-1

IMohd Babar S/O Abrar Husain, R/O-30, Nekkampur, Fudli, Hapur, UP, have changed my name to Mohd Babar Khan.

0071051000-1

ILihthiro known as Ashish Bansal, S/O Narendar Singh/R/O-140, Sirol, Choti-Nagar, Gurjar-Chowk, Loni-Ghaziabad, Badshahpur-Sirauli, Ghaziabad Uttar Pradesh-201102, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as ASHISH BAISLA.

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007105

CROSSWORD

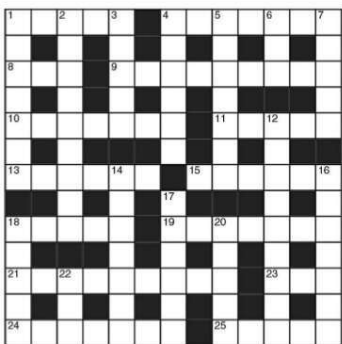
6055

OVER THE HEDGE

BY MICHAEL FRY & T LEWIS

ROYAL STARS

BY GEORGIA NICOLS



ACROSS

- 1 Act gladly for an audience (5)
 4 Involves a silent order (7)
 8 Objective I am out to get (3)
 9 Not a game for sea horses (5,4)
 10 The French mark all dice differently (7)
 11 Is a girl's name for a child (5)
 13 Performs a new ascent (6)
 15 Time conceals a deserter's mistakes (6)
 18 Legal acts? (5)
 19 Turn round to become booming (7)
 21 Overlooking a number inside working as blacksmiths (9)
 23 Have to be won round (3)
 24 Trickery of the French in a sense (7)
 25 It's the herb season we hear (5)

DOWN

- 1 She's presumably met her match (7)
 2 I'm to intercede without delay (9)
 3 Sounds like a strange letter in the post (5)
 4 Sex and art production films use them (6)
 5 Row about stray dog (7)
 6 Bio-chemistry for a Nigerian tribesman (3)
 7 A number achieve success (5)
 12 Remain outside a coach as required by law (9)
 14 An oral test (7)
 16 A go-slow which could be at an end (7)
 17 Vote is for former Russian government (6)
 18 Removes part of diseased offshoot (5)
 20 Should prove uncommonly tough (5)
 22 Regret moving on from Rouen (3)

SOLUTIONS CROSSWORD 6054 ACROSS: 1 Headmaster, 8 Basic, 9 Flutter, 10 Apostle, 11 Stoic, 12 Kafan, 14 Adored, 17 Puffs, 19 Elector, 21 Control, 22 Flies, 23 Easy manner DOWN: 2 Ease off, 3 Ducat, 4 Alfred, 5 Trussed, 6 Ratio, 7 Procedures, 8 Blank space, 13 Asserts, 15 Ratline, 16 Bedlam, 18 Fence, 20 Elfin

JUMBLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

The opposite of talking isn't listening. The opposite of talking is — - Fran Lebowitz (7)

CGMAI RANGER
 TOPIS ELLNUW
 SOLUTIONS: Magic, Post, Garter, Unwell
 ANSWER: The opposite of talking isn't listening. The opposite of talking is — - Fran Lebowitz (7)

CALVIN & HOBBS

BY BILL WATTERSON



MARVIN

BY TOM ARMSTRONG

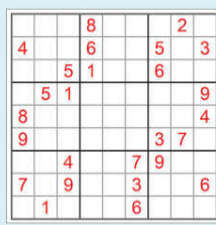


DIFFICULTY LEVEL 3s INSTRUCTIONS

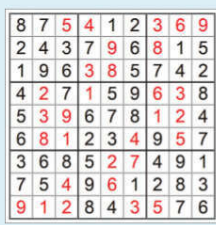
To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL

1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very Hard; 6s = Genius



SOLUTION SUDOKU 6395



provides a framework for collaboration under which EIL will offer its engineering, technical advisory, project management, and consultancy services to DGMA for the planning, development, modernization, and implementation of projects in the maritime sector. The scope of cooperation includes feasibility studies, infrastructure planning, technology integration, capacity enhancement, and other specialized technical services as may be mutually identified.

REC REC sustained a healthy NIM of 3.34%, reflecting the strength of its lending portfolio & disciplined financial management. Consequently, the company delivered an annualised EPS of ₹63.04 per share for the quarter ended June 30, 2026, underscoring its robust earnings performance. REC's standalone loan book stood at ₹75.90 lakh crore as on June 30, 2026 which is the largest for any CPSE-NBFC in India, demonstrating the strength and stability of its lending operation. The net worth has grown by 15% on Y-O-Y basis to ₹91,836 crore as on June 30, 2026. Driven by sustained initiatives to improve asset quality, the Company has reduced its Stage-3 loan asset to the total loan portfolio ratio to near-zero levels i.e., 0.11%.



Karan, Principal Chief Commissioner of Income Tax, UP & Uttarakhand in the presence of Sunita Singh, Principal Commissioner of Income Tax, Dehradun. This recognition reflects UGB's unwavering commitment to transparency, regulatory compliance, & excellence in public service.



University. The Convocation was graced by Atul Garg, Chancellor, KIET University & Member of Parliament from Ghaziabad; Prof. Nagaraj Ramrao, VC, KIET University & other officials. Presenting the annual report, Prof. Ramrao highlighted KIET's evolution into a multidisciplinary deemed-to-be university driven by academic excellence, research, innovation, entrepreneurship & engagement.

HUDCO has continued its strong growth trajectory in the first quarter of FY 2026-27. The board of directors of HUDCO, approved the financial results for the quarter ended on 30th June 2026. This reflected robust business growth, record operational performance and continued improvement in asset quality. Sanjay Kulshrestha, Chairman & MD, HUDCO, stated that the company has commenced FY 2026-27 with exceptional financial & operational performance reflecting the strength of its diversified lending portfolio, prudent financial management and sustained focus on infrastructure financing. With a strong opening quarter continued reduction in NPA, healthy balance sheet, robust asset quality & sustained profitability, HUDCO remains well-positioned to maintain its growth momentum during FY 2026-27.

BOOK LAUNCH Delhi-based entrepreneur, angel investor & author Gagan Dhawan has announced his second book, The New Me 2.0, slated for release later this year. A sequel to his award-winning 2022 debut, the book explores sustainable lifestyle transformation through the WISE Framework—Water, Intent, Sleep and Eating. Emphasising practical systems over motivation, Dhawan advocates preventive health by focusing on achievable daily habits, quality sleep, mindful eating and hydration to help readers build lasting well-being.

EIL

EIL and EPC under the Ministry of Petroleum & Natural Gas, G.O.I. have signed a MoU with the DGMA. The MoU

provides a framework for collaboration under which EIL will offer its engineering, technical advisory, project management, and consultancy services to DGMA for the planning, development, modernization, and implementation of projects in the maritime sector. The scope of cooperation includes feasibility studies, infrastructure planning, technology integration, capacity enhancement, and other specialized technical services as may be mutually identified.

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UGB

Hari Har Patrika, Chairman of UGB, received the 3rd highest taxpayer award on behalf of UGB for FY 2025-26, on the occasion of the 167th Income Tax Day celebrated by the Income Tax Department, Dehradun. The award was presented by Aparna

KIET

KIET Deemed to be University conferred degrees on 3,821 graduating students of the 2025 & 2026 batches of AKTU, Lucknow, during its Annual Convocation 2026. The ceremony began with the academic procession, followed by AKTU Kulgeet & formal welcome of the dignitaries by Dr. Adesh Kumar Pandey, Director Academics, KIET

University. The Convocation was graced by Atul Garg, Chancellor, KIET University & Member of Parliament from Ghaziabad; Prof. Nagaraj Ramrao, VC, KIET University & other officials. Presenting the annual report, Prof. Ramrao highlighted KIET's evolution into a multidisciplinary deemed-to-be university driven by academic excellence, research, innovation, entrepreneurship & engagement.

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BOOK LAUNCH

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CORPORATE BRIEFS



YASODHA MEDICITY Dr. Upasana Arora, MD, Yashoda Medicity & Chair, RCCI Medical Value Travel Committee, represented India's healthcare sector at the Business Forum Romania-India, a high-level bilateral forum held as part of the State Visit of the Hon. President of India to Romania. The forum highlighted the growing role of healthcare & medical value travel in strengthening India-Romania bilateral cooperation. With Romania's strategic position as a gateway to the European market & India's rapidly growing economy, discussions focused on opportunities for partnerships, knowledge exchange, & sustainable economic growth. The event was attended by H.E. Mr. Nicusor Dan, President of Romania, Hon. President of India, Droupadi Murmu, along with senior government officials, industry leaders, and business representatives from both countries.



PNB Government of Andhra Pradesh & PNB signed a MoU for the establishment of the PNB Quantum Finance Hub at AOV. The MoU was exchanged in the presence of Hon. CM of Andhra Pradesh, N. Chandrababu Naidu, & Ashok Chandra, MD & CEO, PNB. The MoU aims to foster innovation, research, talent development, & the adoption of next-generation technologies in India's banking & financial services sector.



SCOPE SCOPE & GIZ, Germany organised an interactive workshop with the MoEFCC, on India & Sweden partnership to encourage industrial decarbonisation through LeadIT. The workshop was addressed by senior officials from MoEFCC, GIZ, BEL & Volvo and brought together 40 senior officials from various PSEs. The event also entailed industrial insight into the net zero pathway of BEL and its sustainability & renewable energy initiatives while also reflecting on the technological pathways for decarbonization in the transport sector by Volvo. A major highlight of the workshop was Sustainability Exchange Visit at BEL.



The chief guest, Dr. Tripta, Hon. VC, Uttarakhand Technical University addressed the gathering and congratulated the newly admitted students on choosing hospitality as a career.

CONCOR recently organised CONCOR CONNECT 2026 – Dadi. The trade meet was held at The Address by Red Carpet, Greater Noida, bringing together exporters, importers, shipping lines, freight forwarders, CHAs, logistics partners & other stakeholders from the trade & logistics fraternity to strengthen customer engagement & understand evolving logistics requirements. The event was graced by Sanjay Swarup, Chairman & MD, CONCOR, as Chief Guest, Ajit Kumar Panda (Director, Projects & Services), Vijay Kumar Singh (Director, International Marketing & Operations), Alok Kumar Singh, Commissioner, Customs, Noida Commissionerate & other officials. The session opened with a welcome address by Ritu Sharma, Cluster Head, TKD Cluster followed by an interactive session with trade representatives where MMLP Dadi's expanding portfolio of value-added services have been presented. The interactive session witnessed valuable discussions with industry stakeholders on enhancing logistics efficiency, reducing supply chain costs and expanding multimodal connectivity.

NTPC NTPC Ltd, has announced its unaudited financial results for the first quarter ended on 30th June, reporting a strong performance driven by operational gains & continuing growth. They reported a total income of Rs 44,512 crore for Q1 FY27, registering a 3% increase as compared to Q1 FY 26. PAT for Q1 FY 27 rose to Rs 5,342 crore up from 47,775 crore for Q1 FY 26. On a consolidated basis, NTPC Group's PAT for Q1 FY27 rose by 13% to ₹6,896 crore from ₹6,108 for Q1 FY26. The strong performance was bolstered by a 62% increase in the profit from group companies, which reached Rs 1,832 crore in Q1 FY27 from Rs 1,131 crore in Q1 FY26.

CCPA Digital insurance platforms have played a transformative role in expanding insurance awareness & penetration across India by making policies easier to compare, understand and purchase. Requiring a mobile number before displaying a personalised quote is a long-standing, transparent and regulator-supervised industry practice, not a deceptive design or "dark pattern" under the Central Consumer Protection Authority (CCPA) Guidelines, 2023. The mobile number enables personalised pricing, saves quotes, supports follow-ups, reduces policy abandonment, prevents fraud and ensures price continuity. Similar identity-first practices exist across insurance markets globally and in India's financial and digital ecosystems. Classifying this practice as a dark pattern would weaken digital distribution, increase acquisition costs, raise premiums, reduce consumer access and undermine investor confidence. The focus should remain on eliminating genuine deceptive practices, not consumer identification.

NHPC The rescue operation at the under-construction Head Race Tunnel of NHPC's Teesta Stage - VI Hydroelectric Project in Sikkim has been concluded with the recovery of bodies of 25 personnel trapped inside the tunnel. The rescue operation was carried out with the coordinated support of the District administration, NDRF, SDRF, Ministry of Power, Ministry of Home Affairs, Ministry of Defence, Patel Engineering Limited, Eastern Coalfields Limited & many more. NHPC's Top Management remained present at the project site throughout the rescue operation for closely monitoring and coordinating with all the agencies involved.

SAIL The company reported a strong profitability in Q1FY27, with net profit rising by over 138% compared to the corresponding period last year. During Q1FY27, SAIL moderate volumes compared to CPLY by advancing certain scheduled repairs & maintenance during the quarter. Commenting on this, Chairperson & MD, SAIL, Dr. Ashok Kumar Panda said, "SAIL, through enhanced operational efficiencies, prudent cost management and focused marketing initiatives, has delivered a significantly profitable first quarter in FY27".

From crutches to podium: Sreeshankar's comeback

Long jumper won his second CWG silver in a row

British Raj
New Delhi, July 30

SREESHANKAR MURALI jumped 8.09m to clinch the men's long jump silver at the 2026 Commonwealth Games on Wednesday. He had won the same medal at the 2022 edition with an effort of 8.08m.

After the final jump, which was a foul, Sreeshankar looked disappointed, knowing that he could have won the gold which went to Tajay Gayle of Jamaica with a mark of 8.15m.

However, the two silvers four years apart and the improvement of 0.01m have been accompanied by a lot of change for the jumper from Palakkad, Kerala. Sreeshankar, who also won the 2023 Asian Games silver, ruptured the patellar tendon in his knee, that too in his take-off leg, ruling him out for the 2024 Paris Olympics.

The Glasgow silver is Sreeshankar's first major medal after making a comeback a year ago. "Him competing now and winning a major medal again is a blessing in itself. When he was walking with the help of crutches after surgery, all I wished was that he could walk freely," Sreeshankar's father Murali told *The Indian Express* from Glasgow.

Surgeons had warned before the surgery that he might not be able to run again.

"It looked dangerous. When I first broke my knee and had the MRI report in my hand, it looked over for me. I never thought that I would be able to jump 8m again," Sreeshankar had said before leaving for Glasgow. Following a lengthy rehabilitation, Sreeshankar made his comeback and managed to qualify for the World Championships.

"Last year was a crazy ride for me. I had just five competitions but somehow managed to make it to the Worlds. Competing there was like a dream at that time," he said.

Sreeshankar was injured during a training session before the Olympics, and the fear of hurting the knee again kept coming back to him.

"Even after I was cleared to train, I was afraid. It took a lot of self-talk and convincing for me to get back to the field," the 27-year-old said.

"My knee is not 100 percent even now. It remains swollen. There are three anchor screws



Sreeshankar Murali came second to Tajay Gayle of Jamaica, with an effort of 8.09m. **PFI**

• Top five

Name	Nation	Best
T. Gayle	JAM	8.15m
M. Sreeshankar	IND	8.09m
S. Mackenzie	SCO	8.08m
C. Mitrevski	AUS	8.02m
L. Sathyanathan	IND	7.97m

in it, so I need to ice it regularly and take a deep tissue massage. But, I have got used to the new training regime now."

After returning from injury, Sreeshankar worked with renowned Strength and Conditioning coach Wayne Lombard, who helped him finalise a training regime.

"Wayne is very efficient. He understands what my knee needs and with his help, I have figured out a training regime that allows me to compete with a surgically repaired tendon," explained Sreeshankar.

Path to consistency

Since his return to the in-

“ Him competing now and winning a major medal again is a blessing in itself. When he was walking with the help of crutches after surgery, all I wished was that he could walk freely”

MURALI, SREESHANKAR'S FATHER
ON HIS CWG 2026 SILVER

ternational arena, Sreeshankar has been extremely consistent. In the 2026 season, he has crossed the 8m mark in every competition he had featured in with his best jump of 8.38m coming last month at the Interstate Athletics Championships in Bhuj.

"There are two reasons behind my consistency: better understanding of my body and quick adaptability to conditions," Sreeshankar had said

there. "During my injury, I completed a course on kinesiology which helped me in understanding my body. Even during competition, if something happens, I can adjust my technique according to the situation."

He has acquired this adaptability from his years of travelling around the world, competing with the best in the business.

"The likes of Miltiadis Tentoglou (former Olympic champion) don't care what the weather is: whether the wind is strong or if it's raining. They just go for the jump. I have inculcated the same habits where I ignore the conditions. All of this has really helped me remain consistent," Sreeshankar said.

With another Commonwealth Games silver medal in his pocket, Sreeshankar is eyeing the Asian Games, which start in September, where the long jumper will look to upgrade his silver from the last edition.

In cold and windy Glasgow, Chopra & Co qualify for final

Shivani Naik
Mumbai, July 30

IN A low 80s qualification of the javelin at the Commonwealth Games 2026, India packed in 14th of the 12-man final, led by Neeraj Chopra's 79.61 metres on 5th place. Rohit Yadav (78.37) on 10th place and Yash Vir Singh (78.36) on 11th, made it 3 Indians for the Friday finale.

Chopra improved on his first 76.28 to sit on fifth at 79.61m. A CWG champion from 2018, a harbinger of his Olympic gold, Chopra is returning from injury this time. He had missed the 2022 edition because of injury.

Chopra told the Olympic channel and other media, "I'm happy I'm in final. That was goal for final. Throw was ok. The goal is to go in final and give my best there."

India's greatest athlete would elaborate on conditions. "Conditions were not best for javelin throwers. Not only cold but windy. And wind also not from front. It's very hard to process. But some times I thought I'll throw there but wind would come from other side. Loads of throwers struggled. Nobody threw automatic qualification," he said.

Chopra sounded upbeat saying, "Happy all three Indians are in final."

Biggest threat

On his biggest threat Ramesh Tharanga Pathirage of Sri Lanka, Chopra said, "He is a good boy. He is a friend of mine. This year he really threw well. It's good he's doing something great for Sri Lanka." The last three CWG champions have gone on to win a gold or silver medal at the next Olympics.

Pathirage led the 18-man field with a strong first throw of 82.4m, as the windy conditions were completely treacherous for the throwers, with crosswinds rummaging the short flights on Thursday morning. A 13 kph west-blowing gust ensured the basic Qualification mark of 84 metres wasn't cleared even once by a group that boasted the last two Olympic champions and assorted other World winners.

Yego exits

It meant that the likes of former world champion Julius Yego and the second best from Pakistan and Sri Lanka — Muhammad Yasir and Sumedha Ranasinghe — didn't make the cut.

2025 world champion Keshorn Walcott, a former Olympic champion from Trinidad Tobago, snuck in by a thread



Neeraj Chopra's best throw of 79.61 metres put him in fifth place. **AP**

“ Conditions were not best for javelin throwers. Not only cold but windy. And wind also not from front. It's hard to process... Loads of throwers struggled. Nobody threw automatic qualification”

NEERAJ CHOPRA, AFTER ADVANCING TO JAVELIN FINAL

• Other results

Women's Shot Put: Manpreet Kaur finished fourth with a best throw of 17.49m.

Women's 3000m SC: Parul Chaudhary finished fifth with a timing of 9:26.75.

Men's triple jump Qualification: Praveen Chitravel and Selva Prabhu booked their berths for the final with best jumps 16.41 and 16.26m.

Men's Decathlon: Tejaswin Shankar is placed fifth after three events with 2258 points. He registered a personal best in long jump with 7.82m.

in 12th place, with 78.26m — as six of the last 12 were punched between that and 78.91m.

Arshad Nadeem of Pakistan first throw of 78.63m ended up being the best. He remains a contender alongside Anderson Peters who tweaked his run-up to hurl from the edge of the kerb for 81.29 on his second.

Qualification distances don't matter beyond sealing a spot in the finals. But they give the competitors an accurate idea of what conditions could be like.

The finals though happen in evenings, and winds can easily blow the other way in those parts at Scotstoun. A 14 degree crisp morning, how-

ever, ensured warmups in cold, biting Glasgow.

South African Douw Smit (80.64) qualified a surprising third, and Englishman Ben East brought in a late third throw of 80.38, to become one of only 4 to cross 80 metres.

Smit who had finished runners up to Chopra at the Ostrava Golden Spike in 2025, has a season best of 84.57 from a Poland win at Irena Sze-winska Memorial this May. The 27-year-old Saffer was a prodigy brought down by a 5-year-long back injury layoff he returned from in 2021. "I thought I would never throw again. But coach said let's check. I was done with studies. But I threw 81 so went ahead," he had told *Modern Athlete* Mag in 2021.

East had thrown above 80 only twice before this.

Walcott has been struggling with a side slip at release the whole of this year, but can never be ruled out. He has a mark of 82.52 at Rabat and 83.45 at Rome.

"No clean hits, but the feeling is there," he had posted back in June. The reigning World Champion, who won the 2012 Olympics with two fractures in his back (L1 and L3) and has framed his backbrace, edged in last moment thanks to Keyshawn Strachan bringing out a 78.60, remains a contender.

The 6-ft-5 Strachan from Bahamas has never crossed 80. But he boasts of breaking Peter's World U20 record.

But the biggest threat remains Ramesh Tharanga Pathirage, the season sensation from Kalutara, south of Colombo. His Rome Diamond League mark of 92.62 looms large on the field, but clearly the challenge will be the conditions in Glasgow.

2026 is led by the Sri Lankan, followed by American Curtis Thompson and then Rohit Yadav (87.05), who showed good adaptability to go from 77.04 to 78.37 but 80 was Glasgow's 90 on a challenging Q day.

Le Clos sets new record with 21st Games medal

Reuters
Glasgow, July 30

VETERAN SOUTH African swimmer Chad Le Clos won a 21st Commonwealth Games medal late on Wednesday to overtake Australia's Emma McKeon as the most decorated athlete in the Games' history. The 34-year-old swimmer the butterfly leg as South Africa took bronze in the men's 4x100 medley relay for his third of the 2026 Games after silver in the mixed 4x100 medley and bronze in the men's 4x100 freestyle relay.

His record tally is made up of seven golds, five silvers and nine bronzes across the last five Games, starting in Delhi in 2010 at the age of 18 where he earned five medals, and then followed by seven medals in Glasgow in 2014.

He continued with five more on the Gold Coast in 2018 and one in Birmingham four years ago.

"It was emotional, but I think those first two medals (in Glasgow 2026) were just a little bit more just because I had to get over the hump and tonight I just had to stay cool and bring it home," he said after Wednesday's relay.

"The way the boys and girls swam... they swam their hearts



Chad Le Clos overtook Emma McKeon's 20 medals. **REUTERS**

out. They kept saying 'we're doing this for Chad' before they walked down and it just means the world to me."

Le Clos is also an Olympic champion. He stunned the sporting world when he piped Michael Phelps by 0.05 seconds to win the 200m butterfly gold at the 2012 London Games.

At the time, American icon Phelps was a 14-time Olympic champion and he had not lost in the event since 2001.

Le Clos won medals at the Olympics in Rio in 2016 and has since competed in Tokyo and Paris. He has previously said he hopes to qualify for his fifth Olympics in Los Angeles in two years' time.

• BOXING WITH LINEAGE

Amin's grandson disqualified after headbutting opponent

Shuvaditya Bose
New Delhi, July 30

SUCCESS STORIES and tales of hardship are part of sport. The most extraordinary story at the 2026 Commonwealth Games involved neither. Instead, it involved a headbutt, an angry tirade and a surname that still divides a nation.

In the quarter-final of men's 90+ kg boxing, Ugandan boxer Aziz Abdul was disqualified for headbutting his opponent, England's Damar Thomas. As if Zinedine Zidane had descended at the SEC Centre.

Then came the outburst. "I'm a black African, I know. It's God's plan," Aziz declared. Then alleged, "There was a lot of b*****". Holding, elbowing. When other countries do this, they are disqualified. They decided the winner before the fight."

When a Press Association reporter attempted a question, Aziz cut him off.

"Not you. I don't like you." His explanation was startling: the journalist had written unfavourably about his grandfather.

The report in question stated his grandfather had killed half a million people. The grandfather being Idi Amin. A former Ugandan dictator in the 1970s.

Coach in film on Amin
New Delhi, July 30

Samuel Kabugo's dreams were modest in 2005. Winning a boxing competition, for instance. That he would feature in a Hollywood film, sharing screen with Forest Whitaker, was beyond his wildest imagination. Until director Kevin Macdonald arrived in Uganda.

While filming *The Last King of Scotland*, based on Amin's life, Macdonald needed real boxers to recreate the former president's years in the ring. Kabugo became one of them. Two decades later, the past returned.

Now head coach of Uganda's boxing team and owner of Kololo Boxing Club, Kabugo met a towering teenager brought in by his elder brother Habbib.

"Before boxing, Aziz had been doing martial arts and taekwondo. His elder brother Habbib brought him to me and said, 'Coach, my younger brother wants to try boxing. He's a big, powerful boy.' He joined around June 2023. I didn't know about his family background when Aziz joined me."

Today, Habbib is Coach. Do you know about our family? We are the grandchildren of Idi Amin. I was shocked," Kabugo tells *The Indian Express* from Uganda.

In Glasgow, Aziz surprised



Aziz Abdul (left) headbutted England's Damar Thomas. **REUTERS**

many by declaring himself proud of his grandfather. He later clarified that his admiration stemmed not from Amin's presidential rule, but from his boxing achievements.

"Idi Amin is one of the reasons why Aziz switched to boxing. He was inspired by his grandfather. Aziz is proud of his lineage. He didn't choose his family or the history attached to it, but he doesn't run away from it either," says Kabugo.

After disqualification, Aziz alleged the judges could not stand a black African beating a European. Decades ago, Amin had voiced similar feelings.

"Several of Aziz's victories have come by knockouts. He

loves nothing more than knocking his opponents out. There is an interesting story behind this. When Ugandan boxers complained about unfair judging at international tournaments, Amin told them, 'Don't leave it to the judges. Knock your opponents out.' In a way, Aziz is following that path," Kabugo said.

Aziz's Commonwealth Games debut was not remarkable, but his journey has been. "Aziz is an exceptional, quick learner. It took him just four months to get into the National Championships, and only one year to win the National Boxing League. With only three years of training, he

“ At times, the family history weighs on him. Even today, there are so many stories about the darker chapters of Idi Amin. The killings, the dictatorship and everything else from that period”

SAMUEL KABUGO, BOXER
AZIZ ABDUL'S COACH

is at the Commonwealth Games," his coach said.

Yet, having publicly voiced his desire to be the new 'King of Scotland' before the fight, as his grandfather once did, a disqualification for headbutting is rather unceremonious.

"Aziz has always been incredibly confident. He has the heart of a lion. He never backs down from anyone and never walks into a fight intimidated by an opponent. He also likes to speak his heart out. On most occasions, he backs his words with his punches. But at times, it goes away," Kabugo said.

On Wednesday, it most certainly did.

Weighed by history

Uganda has taken a 55-

